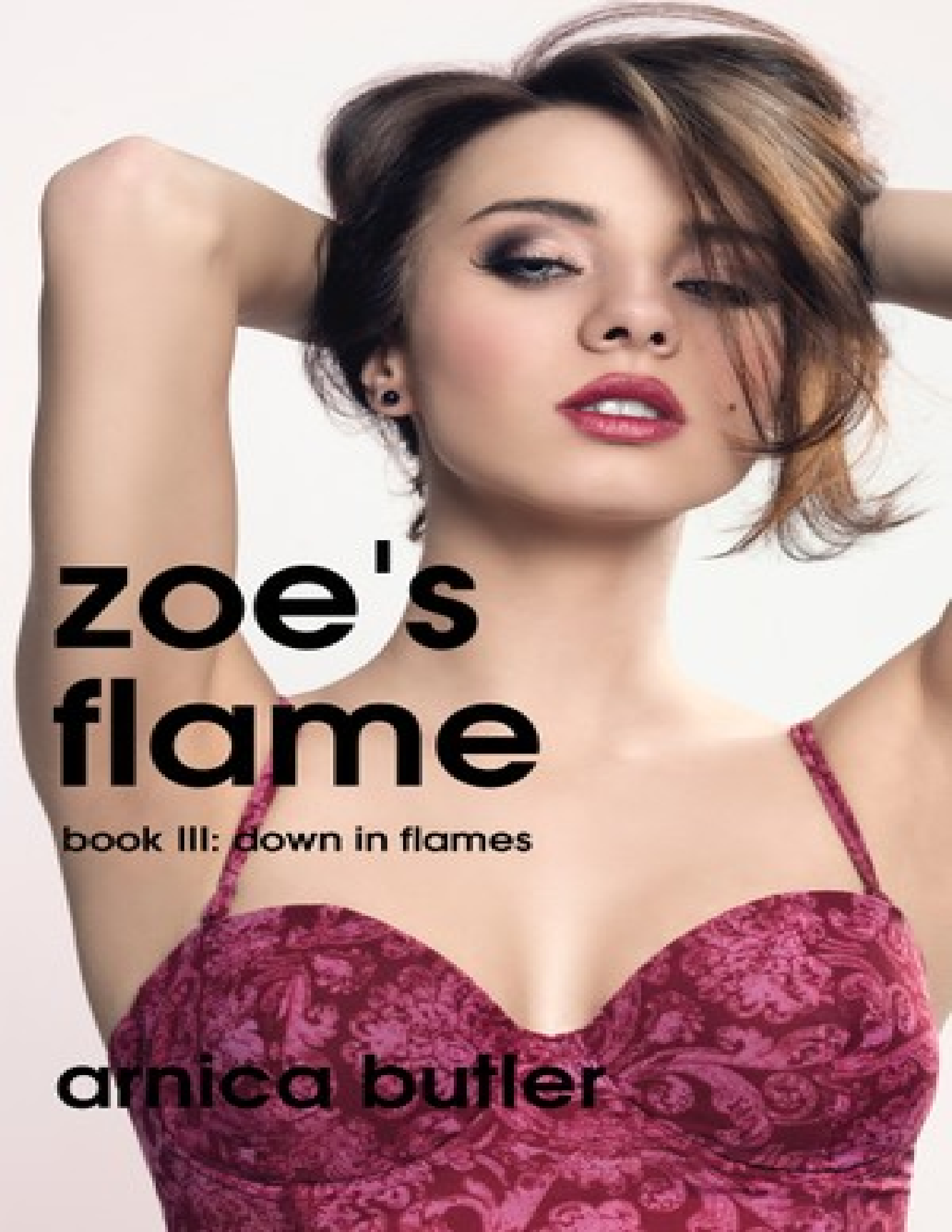




zoe's flame

book III: down in flames

arnica butler

ZOE'S FLAME

BOOK III: DOWN IN FLAMES

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

The kitchen was illuminated by a single light below the microwave, a silver-blue LED hue called "daylight" which Zoe professed to hate and which Josh had promised to change. The light was always on, but he had somehow never noticed its stark color before.

Now, sitting in the small dining area adjacent to the kitchen, having let the house grow dark around him, he had marinated in the light long enough to understand why Zoe hated it so much: it was cold, metallic, and nothing like daylight at all. It threw the kitchen, and much of the adjacent home, into ghoulish relief, like the lighting of a psychological thriller.

The drink he had fixed for himself had long since warmed in his hand, wrapped around it in a tense fist that he had also forgotten about. He noticed it now, as a dull ache began to permeate through the deep, despairing fog in his head. His arm hurt, he realized, with a suddenness that did not quite align with the dawning realization that it had been hurting for quite some time.

When he released the glass of now-watery whiskey, his muscles responded with a sharp spasm. He stretched his fingers absent-mindedly and looked back at the green-blue digits on the clock.

11:57pm.

He had come home late, intentionally. It was both a necessity, if you asked his boss Pete Stark, and a desire: he hadn't wanted to sit in his kitchen alone, or pace his house like a caged animal, while he waited for his wife to return home from her lover.

He touched his fingertips to his phone and spun it toward him. He knew there was nothing to check on the screen of his phone: the incoming message signal was set to a loud alarm and a vibration, and could not be missed. At 9:46 he had been subjected to the sound and it had set his heart racing, and his blood running hot and cold in violent pulses, for the brief seconds it took to pick the phone up and look at the screen.

But that message - a reminder from the phone company that he had overused his data plan - had not been from his wife, who had sent her last missive at around 7:30pm.

Randy wants me to come see him around 8. I think I can get you some pictures???? What do you think?

Randy. Randy who had spent the weekend with his wife, turning her over and propping her up for his pleasure, putting his huge cock in every hole, filling her to overflowing with his cum, while Josh lurked in the shadows and crept through the dark rooms and hallways of his own home to watch from the shadows like a pervert. Randy, who seemed to have loaded up on a whole box of Viagra and who should have had a raw dick with all the things he had done to Zoe for almost two full, uninterrupted days - *Randy* had called her to lure her to his house yet again, after fewer than 36 hours had transpired since his last romp with her.

And he, Josh Wilson, had approved:

That's hot.

Sorry - just got interrupted by Pete. Zoez, it's hot but are you sure you can handle it?

Okay, I guess I missed you.

I love you, see you soon.

Zoe had disappeared from the text messages, wasn't answering her phone, and was now very, very late coming home. Josh had believed that if he arrived home at 9:30pm he wouldn't have to wait very long: after all, Zoe was still maintaining the ruse with Randy that she had kept her relationship with him a secret from Josh.

Not only that, Josh thought miserably for what seemed like the millionth time, Zoe had been so thoroughly used by Randy, all weekend long, that it seemed impossible she could physically withstand what seemed to, as of now, be a four-hour onslaught by Randy's huge cock.

The memory of Zoe's tiny ass held in place by Randy's tree-trunk thighs, his dripping, engorged crown nearing her tiny asshole, made Josh shudder. He heard the phantom sound of the wet, splitting sound of her sphincter being spread open impossibly wide, and then the sticky sawing smacks as Randy hammered her ass full of his cum.

What was she doing for him right now? Lying limply with her legs spread? Looking him in the eye while she swallowed his musky cum? Taking it in the ass on her hands and knees, telling him she loved to be his sex slave and she wanted more?

Or even dirtier, more humiliating, pornographic things?

Randy's imagination seemed to know no bounds... and Josh's didn't, either.

And while at every turn, Zoe seemed to enjoy being fucked like a whore, screaming and writhing and coming time after time - how much more could her tiny body take of Randy's monstrous pummeling? The man's dick was absurdly thick, decently long, and he never seemed to tire. When Josh had made slow and gentle love to Zoe to reclaim her Sunday night, he knew she was sore and worn-out from the way that she squirmed and moaned.

The hours had ticked by at a glacial pace since Josh had come home, and sat in the kitchen, his abdomen ice-cold, his cock hardening with each passing moment until an ache had penetrated to what felt like his kidneys, and he had realized he needed to take a piss, but could not. Every sound on the street alarmed him, made his blood race and boil, his heart stamping in panic as he faced the possibility that within seconds, Zoe would be there, used and full of another man's cum, for him to contemplate.

But it was never Zoe. Cars passed and stopped on the street outside, and no one came to their door. No texts came to his phone, no one answered the calls that he made. Occasionally, panic would grip him: what if something had gone wrong, and Zoe was actually in a hospital somewhere, because she had never even arrived at Randy's place? Or what if Randy was mercilessly fucking her and she would still be there for hours? How could she take any more?

Or - and this was the darkest part of his mind, the closet he peeked into occasionally and then slammed the door closed on as fast as he could - what if Zoe was lying peacefully asleep in Randy's bed, lured to stay there with promises of mind-blowing sex, and Randy's Jag, and his daddy-like persona, and his leisurely lifestyle that left all the time in the world to take Zoe to fancy dinners and then make her scream for hours every night?

What if Zoe wasn't going to come back to him, tonight, or ever?

Or what if she came back, in her physical form, but was no longer with him mentally? Surely, she couldn't rid her own mind of the filthy things Randy had done to her any more than Josh could? What if she lay her body out sweetly for Josh, but thought only of the veined, slightly crooked fat prick of Randy's, in perpetuity? Never to *really* belong to Josh ever again?

He could plummet further still: what if Zoe had never really been all his to begin with?

He gulped the watery, warm whiskey and regretted it immediately: it was foul and he'd had enough as it was. It was late and he had to get up early tomorrow, but there was no way he was sleeping until Zoe came home.

Lights flashed outside, a car turning down their odd little street.

But they continued on, fading away as they headed east, and Josh was left to continue on, in his increasingly panicked contemplation, waiting for his wife.

CHAPTER 2

Zoe locked her door after dropping into the driver's seat of her car. It was force of habit: here in Jackson Heights, the crime rate was probably somehow negative, but that wasn't true everywhere.

Her heart was racing, and she was shaky. A chill was in the air and it was unusually damp for this time of year, but that chill was nothing compared to the chill that was going through her after what she had done with Randy.

She fumbled through her purse and found her phone.

1:11am.

"Jesus," she whispered.

How was that possible? How was that *even possible*?

She hurried to find the pictures that Randy had sent: she had done it herself from his phone, but until she saw them for herself, she wasn't going to believe that she had them.

There they were. She stared at them, disbelieving the sight of herself.

Her plan was to send them to Josh, but as she scrolled through her messages to get to their conversation, she thought better of it: she was crazy letting pictures like this go out on the internet in any way, shape or form. She had deleted them from Randy's phone, deleted the file and the sent messages from Randy to her own phone.

But something told her that Randy had a trick up his sleeve, because he had caved to her demand fairly quickly. A cold fear settled again in her chest and lower abdomen. Randy might have these photos somewhere, and he might decide to use them someday.

For a millisecond, a horrific tableau played out in her mind, whereby she sent the pictures to some group conversation, or to her boss, accidentally.

Or that Randy, in a jealous rage or as part of some intimate, intricate, perverse blackmail he had designed, sent them to the same people.

Her face turned violently red as she imagined Neil, her boss, looking at the most incriminating of them all, the one that showed enough of her face to make a clear, unmistakable identification of her.

The one with her mouth stretched wide by Randy's dick, her watering eyes hovering over it, willingness and need for approval shimmering in her

irises as clearly as if she had spoken the words aloud: *I want to suck your huge dick and get your approval, Randy.*

She dismissed all of these thoughts with as clean of a sweep as she could muster, closing her eyes as though the action would send the curtain down on the whole horrible play. Her heart stopped again when she caught the first few lines of Josh's messages as she started to sweep her fingers over the phone and turn the screen off

...

I love you, see you soon...

She opened her phone again and almost dropped it in her hurry to look at the message again. The last thing Josh had sent her, in response to her message about Randy, was *"that's hot."*

That was part of the reason she had been so... whoreish?... tonight, with Randy.

That's hot, she had been thinking bitterly. Well, if that was all Josh had to say about it, then she would show him just how "hot" it could be.

But now, in her car, all of those things done and not un-doable, she read the three messages subsequent to "that's hot," shaking her head.

That's hot.

Sorry - just got interrupted by Pete. Zoez, it's hot but are you sure you can handle it?

Okay, I guess I missed you.

I love you, see you soon.

A fifteen-minute pause had occurred between Josh's "that's hot" message and the rest. But she had never seen the other messages. Not until now. She bit her lip.

They hadn't even come up on her notification screen... or had they?

She couldn't remember now.

She was freezing. Impatiently, she started the car, annoyed with herself for being so scatterbrained that she hadn't started it already, even as she shivered in the cold. Air conditioning poured out at her feet; it had been warm that afternoon.

She shifted in her seat, a very sore, dull ache throbbing between her legs, in her pussy, and in her ass. The skin of her bottom burned with a sharp reminder of Randy's latest perversion, but when she remembered it,

she felt her cunt throb and well up with excitement, involuntarily, against her better judgment.

Against her rational judgment.

She had never had anyone do that to her before. Never even thought of exploring the possibility. Somewhere in the back of her mind, it had lurked around as a vague fantasy, an element that sometimes made it into her thoughts when she masturbated. Occasionally a pang in her lower abdomen would remind her of her passing interest in it when she saw a certain scene in a movie, or read some trashy novel.

But that had never been something she would have *asked* someone to do to her.

Had Randy sent his perceptive, psychiatrist tentacles into her dark fantasies to find that secret arousal? Or was it just something he wanted for himself?

It hardly mattered.

The gushing juices that had poured out from between her thighs had confirmed, whether Randy had suspected it or not, that in the well-guarded secret vaults of Zoe's mind, she liked to be spanked.

She typed furiously to Josh.

*I didn't get your messages sorry on my way home I had
no idea it was so late*

She paused, the phone in both hands, wondering if she should tell him that she had the pictures. Or wait?

Or send them now?

Or - and this was not what she was supposed to think about - never send them at all?

She tossed the phone back into her purse and wiped at the windshield with a small sponge Josh had insisted she have in the car. The windows were fogged except for a tiny black patch at the bottom of the windshield. They fogged immediately again.

Zoe leaned forward and ducked her head to see through the clear patch. She needed to get moving, away from the scene of her depravity.

It was the second time she was leaving Randy's house, and not sure what she was going to tell her husband when she arrived at home. At least this time, the only thing she had to hide - if she chose to - was the details.

But that was against the rules between her and her husband.

She would figure it out while she drove, she told herself.

CHAPTER 3

Approximately 8pm, the previous evening

"Where are my manners?" Randy asked. "Do you want a drink?"

Zoe was panting, her mouth open in disbelief. "I don't... I..."

"I want you to have one," Randy said quietly. There was a beat of silence, and Zoe waited, because she knew something else was coming, and she knew, deep in her abdomen and at the root of her tortuously aching clit, that it was going to turn her on.

Randy had moved closer in the interim, she certainly didn't remember him stepping toward her. She felt drunk already. Her spine tingled, and an eternity seemed to pass before he said, in a low voice, his mouth close to her neck, his breath hot on her shoulder. "I want your mouth to be cold when I put my dick in it."

Only then did he turn and walk to the room where he had fucked her the first time, and begin to make her a drink, without looking back, sure she would follow.

She obeyed, knees weak, Randy's voice whispering in her head, over and over again:

And now you need to be punished.

The word "punished," in particular, flicked at a nerve inside of her. She couldn't explain why, or why it rose above all things as more salient than any others. What form of punishment would Randy dispense to her? Something worse than fucking her in the ass in the middle of the day, renting a hotel room for about an hour like she was, in fact, a whore, and then demanding that she return to work, unsatisfied, with an order not pleasure herself and get any relief until she came crawling to him this evening?

Something worse than the humiliation that was heaped upon her simply by the act of *coming back here*, like she was his slave, even after she'd relieved herself?

And why, when she imagined that his punishment would be worse than all of those things, did it send a chill running up and down the length of her spine, but also an electric vibration straight to the center of her clit?

She followed Randy, her chest tight, her breath ragged. She tried to settle down: this was no different than adrenaline at the top of a wild run, at the door of a plane. She just had to jump, and then it would turn to liquid magic in her arteries. This was just the overdose, before it was matched to a physical activity. Her hand was shaking as she took the drink that Randy made for her. Ice floated in the liquid, as he had promised.

"You're not nervous, are you?" Randy asked calmly, his eyes on her hand. She didn't answer, and he lifted his gaze and looked into her eyes for a moment. Then he pushed her hair back, tucking it behind her ear. "No. Not Zoe. I think not."

Zoe lifted the drink to her lips and sipped it. It was cold, sweet, she had no idea what it was but it had clearly been in the freezer. She felt her mouth getting cold, just like Randy wanted it. She could feel herself oddly salivating for the heat of his cock, the musky scent of him, the salty precum that would be dragged along her palate and then to the back of her throat, while Randy stared down at her and fed himself to her until she couldn't breathe.

She could feel Randy's eyes on her as she sipped the whiskey. A growingly familiar ripple of guilty pleasure, tinged with guilt, traveled through her. Was it wrong to like Randy's obsession so much? It certainly was miles away from anything she would ever want to admit: to her friends, to Josh.

She lifted her eyes from the brown liquid and met his, just as he reached forward to take the glass from her hand. With a practiced smoothness, a flow of motion that only a man who was supremely confident in the malleability of the woman in his presence, Randy put a hand on her shoulder and pushed her down to her knees.

She could almost see herself from the outside, sliding to the floor, her eyes locked on Randy's glacial and dominating stare the whole way down. The obedient opening of her mouth, her hands resting on her knees without him having to tell her to do it.

Randy took himself out of his pants and boxers with one hand while he pushed her hair away from her cheek again. He dropped the heavy meat to her lips, slapping it gently onto her upturned face. Her tongue rose to meet him, to lick the underside of his shaft as he rocked minutely back and forth to drag it and push it over her lips and nose and chin. When his precum

smearing her forehead her pussy squeezed: he wanted her enough to drip before she even touched him.

Randy took his cock in his hand and guided the crown to her lips. He shook himself, landing a few demeaning slaps on her mouth, before grasping her hair and shoveling himself into her mouth.

As he filled her to the back of her throat with his meat, the scent of his body rose intoxicatingly through her nostrils. Her eyes watered and she gagged, and then the scent was gone, and she could no longer breathe.

Randy pushed in deeper, crushing his balls against her chin, while he pushed her head against his pelvis. Staring down at her, his cock completely choking her, he watched as she maintained eye contact. A flutter of panic traveled through her as the lack of air began to seep through her chest as pain, and she raised her hands to his thighs.

A tear overflowed in her left eye and she blinked very slowly, blurriness overtaking her vision for a moment. She made a noise and pushed on his thighs, but Randy shook his head very slowly. "You can do it. Be good."

When he released her, she gasped for breath and let her head fall forward. Randy tipped it back and looked down at her, shaking his head almost too subtly to be noticed. "Try again," he told her. "And put your hands down."

Again, he pushed into her throat, and watched her, as she tried to keep her eyes on his and not to blink. She balled her hands up on her knees, and held them there, but the panic rose up inside of her again and she squeezed her eyes closed to control it. Randy gave her head a tiny jerk by the hair, and she opened them again.

As she gasped for breath, when he slithered from her throat with a sticky crackle, saliva rolled down her chin. She was tempted to wipe it away, but she knew Randy wanted her to keep her hands there. The act of obeying him made her lower abdomen wring itself into a sickly pleasurable knot.

"I'm going to fuck your throat, now, Zoe. And you're going to look at me and show me how much you like pleasing me in your eyes. And when I come, you're going to suck my cum from the end of my cock," Randy said. He put the crown of his dick into her mouth, holding it so that she didn't swallow him. "Close your lips around me now, show me how you'll do it."

Zoe closed her lips around his crown, and swirled her tongue over the hole and the ridge just inside her mouth.

Randy moved a hand below her jaw and squeezed firmly. "Suck," he repeated. "Suck like you want to suck the cum right out of my balls."

Zoe blinked slowly, her only protest to the submission and humiliation that Randy was subjecting her to, before she began to suck on the tip of his cock, as hard as she could. A stream of precum, bitter and salty, dribbled into her mouth.

"Good girl. That's how you do it, when I tell you to."

Randy's voice was husky and ragged. He curled a thumb up to her mouth and pulled her jaw open. "Now open up for me, all the way. Keep your eyes up here, Zoe, show me what a good cocksucking whore you can be for me."

He fucked her throat, hand cradling her head to keep it steady, fingers gripping ever more tightly in her hair. She struggled to breathe, sounding like an animal, through flaring nostrils each time he retracted his dick enough for her to suck in a gasp of air through her nostrils, then expel it on the next thrust. Her eyes watered until she could barely see Randy's face, but she kept her gaze rigidly fixed on his eyes, trying to convey to him that she loved to please him, just as he commanded. The sound of his cock fucking her mouth was a sticky, spitty gurgle.

He paused for a moment, deep in her throat, and so she was helpless to even react as he brought his phone out from seemingly nowhere and held it over her head. "Eyes up here, Zoe," he told her, and she was powerless to do anything but obey. The flash blinded her, and when she could see again, he was pumping into her and the phone was in his free hand, at his side.

She felt his cock change before he paused on the outward stroke and said, his voice barely steady, "I'm going to come, Zoe. Suck it. Suck it out of my dick."

She closed her lips around his already spewing crown, the bitter cream spurting into her mouth, some of it splashing out of her lips and down her chin. She sucked, as hard as she could, and closed her eyes without realizing it.

"Keep that cum in your mouth, Zoe," Randy said, and she was grateful because it was too much all at once. "I want you to taste it. I want you to

show it to me before you swallow it." He groaned through this command, because his seed was pumping in spurts onto her tongue.

His cum was hot and filled her mouth, some spilling over her lips as he let his cock fall from her mouth. A final spurt escaped him, and a rope of cum landed on her cheek, some of it catching on an eyelash. She blinked and closed her mouth, trying to hold the impossibly bitter liquid in her mouth.

Randy had the phone up again. "Open your mouth, Zoe. Show me your dirty, dirty mouth full of cum. Look at me, that's good. You're being a very good girl, look at me with your mouth open. Good."

She waited. Randy stood over her. She was breathing heavily, saliva and cum cooling on her face and neck. Her eyes watered from the strain of looking up at him.

The phone flashed again.

"Now swallow it," Randy ordered quietly, fingers running through her hair.

She nearly gagged on the massive load but was able to swallow it all. Randy swept his fingers over her cheek and chin, feeding the last bits of cum to her.

"Randy," she said hoarsely. She wanted to say something about the photographs he had just taken, because the sense of incrimination was buzzing about in her head, and the full reality of just how slutty she was being was coming into view.

Randy put a finger to her lips and shook his head, though, and so she said nothing.

"I'm not done with you yet," he told her.

He stepped out of his pants and boxers, then pulled his shirt off, tossing it onto the floor. Then he picked up his drink from the bar, and, leaving Zoe on her knees, he walked to his sofa and sat down. He spread his arms over the back of the sofa, much like he had the first time he had fucked her.

Zoe remained on her knees, awaiting his instruction with the tiniest bit of fear crawling around inside of her. Her pussy ached, and drowned out the weak voices that tried to catch a foothold in her mind: why, why was she doing this? Why was she here, on her knees, cum dripping down the back of her throat?

Randy patted his knee. It was an insouciant gesture, and Zoe stared at him, a flush rising to her cheeks.

"Come over here, Zoe," Randy said, lifting his drink to his lips.

Zoe hesitated, her heart pounding. *Punishment*, not so much as a lexical item but as an idea, a slippery whisper, a cord in the center of her body that was plucked by the thought of it, slithered around inside of her.

She edged forward on her knees: standing up would have been silly, he was only a few feet away.

She stopped about a foot from him, and he patted his knee again. She looked at him: somewhere in her chest, and between her legs, she knew what he was asking her to do. But her mind could not catch up to it, nor move her limbs.

"Has anyone ever spanked you, Zoe?"

She knew her face registered alarm, and surprise, though in truth she was not surprised and that was not the feeling that traveled through her. Her abdomen went cold with a thrill, and her pussy throbbed. Her head shook subtly, quickly, and her mouth fell open. Then she shook her head slowly, as if in disbelief.

Randy could see it: she could see that he recognized in her something that she didn't want to admit even to herself. He knew that he was turning her on, and he also knew that she was slightly horrified by it. Her eyes dropped to the floor. Randy leaned back again, arms over the back of the sofa. "You've been very bad, Zoe. So, I think you need to come here, and lay down over my knees, and get spanked."

Her breath rattled through her chest like fragments of frosty glass. She felt her knees wobbling.

Spanked.

But she was edging toward him, then crawling onto the couch next to him, then leaning over his lap as he adjusted himself, sitting up. She was on her stomach, her ass draped over his lap, before her conscious mind had time to even catch up with what her body was doing.

Randy placed a hand on her thighs and pushed her skirt up, slowly. Beneath her stomach, she could feel his hard cock throbbing between his legs. Her skirt bunched up at her waist, and Randy caressed her bare bottom. Only her soaked thong underwear remained, and he tugged on it slightly, pulling it against her clit and making her mewl.

He rested a hand on her ass, patting her skin menacingly. "You were a very, very bad girl today Zoe," he told her. "And so I'm going to have to give you a very, very bad spanking."

She whipped her head around, sucking in her breath. "Randy," she began, but when she saw his expression she realized there was not much she could say to stop him, and she was making no *move* to stop him. For Randy had guessed at some dark thing inside of her that was true, whether she wanted it to be or not.

He lifted his hand, and Zoe heard the slap against her bare bottom long before the sting of it traveled to her brain. It was sharp, biting, taken over almost immediately by a burn that made her kick her feet and whimper. It faded in waves, as her eyes watered.

It was too much, she was thinking, but Randy was already spanking her a second time, and the bite of it was overwhelming her senses just as he delivered another, and then another, until she let out a cry and started to buck against him.

As perhaps she had known would happen, Randy leaned one arm on her upper back and she was immobilized for the rain of slaps that landed on her skin, each one turning up the temperature on her burning bottom, each one making her pussy ooze and then gush into her panties, each one making her eyes overflow with tears as one does when something smarts painfully.

At last he stopped, leaving his hand on her skin, where its warmth was almost intolerable heaped on the waves of numbness and sharp pain that rolled over her skin in ever-diminishing ripples.

She realized she was not breathing, and gasped for air.

Randy caressed her bottom while she lay still, humiliated into submission, putty in his hands. Her tears spread on the couch beneath her, but she lay still, feeling only Randy's hand on her over-sensitized skin.

He slid a finger beneath her taut thong, and she could feel her own slick juices that had soaked her panties and dripped into her ass crack, spread out to her sticky inner thighs. Randy explored her asshole and her slit perfunctorily, and then withdrew his hand.

"I knew you were the kind of girl who liked to be spanked," he told her, rubbing her skin with such a light touch that it started to itch. He patted her bottom a few times, slowly, somberly, and left his hand heating her skin

almost intolerably. "But now you're going to go to the bedroom, and take off all your clothes, and be a good girl, aren't you?"

"Yes," Zoe whispered.

Randy patted her. "That's good. Get going."

She pushed herself up, and climbed off the couch, walking unsteadily toward the bedroom. She stopped to take off her shoes.

"Leave those on," Randy said. He was watching her, drink in hand, his arms spread over the back of the couch.

Zoe put her foot back in the shoe. Randy crunched an ice cube. "I'll be in in a minute, and you should be ready, with nothing but those shoes on."

*

In the end, Zoe chose to sit on his bed on her knees, facing the door. She was pleased with her choice when she saw his face, saw that he wanted her like that.

"Bend over," Randy said, when he got to the door frame. "Get your ass in the air for me. Show me your red ass."

She leaned forward, onto her chest, and lifted her ass into the air for him, tilting so that he could see from the door. He walked slowly around the bed to take the scene in from behind.

"If you had been a good girl, Zoe, I was going to give you a treat," Randy said, after a long time. She heard a drawer slide open. Another flutter of fear traveled through her, but she remained as she was, straining to see what Randy was doing without moving her head. "But I don't know if you deserve it anymore."

She tried to look back at him and moved her hips.

"Do you want it, Zoe?"

She exhaled. She didn't want to say yes, but she found herself not only saying, instead practically whining it: "Yes."

She felt the weight of Randy's knee on the bed. He slid his hand under her throat, lifting her by the neck. At the same time a silky fabric passed over her eyes, and then he set her head down, turning her face to the bed, and she felt him knot the fabric tightly behind her head.

From there, he picked up her wrists, handling them gently until he brought them together, and wound them with the same kind of fabric, at the small of her back. The length of fabric fell softly onto her back, into the

crack of her ass, all the way to the back of her knee. Randy's weight lifted from the bed, and then was almost immediately replaced.

Randy rolled her gently onto her side, and then onto her back. He gave her time to adjust herself onto her tied hands. It was ever-so slightly uncomfortable, and she couldn't see anything but a sliver of light at the bottom of the blindfold.

Her breath had become an excited staccato, her chest cool with fear and anticipation. Randy spread her legs open and bent her knees, then slowly shifted his calves until they were pressing onto her ankles.

She was pinned open now, and her mouth was open, her eyes moving uselessly behind her eyelids, searching for what he would do next.

She heard the vibration first and it frightened her, it sounded momentarily like a dentist's drill or something equally horrific. She took her breath in sharply, the idea that Randy might be an axe-murderer flitted through her head, and so she screamed when a cool object touched the ridge of her clit.

She could only wriggle her upper body, and that motion did almost nothing. Her scream gurgled away as the sensation reached her mind: it was not a drill or an axe or some other instrument of blind torture - though in Randy's hands, she sensed, it would be - it was a vibrator, and he was holding it to her clit, close to the root, where it was stimulating her wildly but in an unfamiliar place. The pleasure, as such, came in waves that were always delicious but unsatisfying, arousing but unsettling.

She heard herself grunt, and then wail. Heat overtook her: heat of sexual frustration, nearing orgasm, fitful masturbation. It was familiar and yet now outside of her control. She turned her head side to side in fits, and squirmed to get the bundle of nerves at the slippery face of her clit beneath the vibrator, but Randy held her pinned with his heavy legs, his hands handling the more minute manipulations of her body, so that his vibrating toy only went to where he wanted it to go.

Zoe thrashed for a while, but at last gave up and lay, panting, with her legs spread open. She was acutely aware of the gushing juices pouring into the crack of her ass, and the way her whimpering and moaning had turned into a sound more akin to a pleading sob.

Whenever her breath accelerated, or her muscles squeezed, and the end came nearer, Randy moved the vibrations to some more foreign patch of her

clit, or lifted the pressure just enough to cause her orgasm to elude her, making her edge without release.

This went on for some period of time that she would never be able to guess at, until she heard herself, in gulping, wet gasps, begging Randy. "Please, Randy, please. Please, let me come, make me come."

And when that plea fell on his deaf ears, she tried another tack, because she couldn't see his expression or whether her begging was having any effect on him at all.

"Randy, please, please make me come. I'll do anything you want, Randy, I'll be a good girl. Please, please."

Her hair was as wet as if she had plunged her whole head into the pool. It stuck to her cheek in fat ropes each time she turned her head from side to side. Her back began to ache from the tension in her body as she strained to glean from the ever-changing stimulation the final spark needed to set her orgasm in motion.

Randy had taken a picture of her in these moments, and then in the even more awful moments that followed, ceaselessly, because after she came, he was far from done with his perverse torture.

*

Zoe felt pretty sure that almost every woman had tried it: placing the pulsating head of the shower massager against her clit, feeling a shattering pleasure of such intensity that it was unbearable. That, like her, every woman had settled on a greater distance, firing the pulses until she came, and then experiencing for one brief and frightening moment, the sensation of having an immensely powerful vibrator pulsing on her clit *after* coming.

The orgasm that Randy finally allowed her to have snuck up on her, curling around the edges of her body from a different direction, seizing her with unfamiliar hands and a staggering intensity. Her eyes, held loosely closed by the fabric over her lids, squeezed until stars began to fill her vision, and her thighs shook uncontrollably. Somewhere below the bold ringing in her ears and the thumping of her own blood as it crashed into the delicate vessels of her ears, she heard her pussy gushing and squelching, but there was no way to control the sound or even give it much thought.

She was struck silent again, screaming inside but deprived of the mechanism by which to actually give voice to her feelings. Her whole body shook, and she was grateful for the release, though a tiny dissatisfaction

lurked somewhere in her body, for Randy had not scratched exactly the *right* itch, in the *right* way.

She had only the briefest of moments to ponder that dissatisfaction, though, because the true torture to which Randy would subject her was about to begin.

As the waves of pleasure rolled away, and the wild sensitivity set in, Zoe realized that Randy was not going to drop his vibrator and let her lie, spent, recovering from what he had just done to her. Deep in her chest, a sob grew and tried to leave her throat, but, as if it were a bubble trapped inside of her, it burst before she made the sound and all that left her lips was a strangled cry. "Raaaaaaa -" she began, but her voice was cut short.

Randy had moved the vibrator to the center of her clit, where it now inflicted a very specific type of agony on her. "Oh God," she screamed, or perhaps only wanted to scream. Randy's hands, which had held her very delicately before that moment, clamped down on her, so that as she flailed about, attempting to remove her swollen, shrieking clit from the assault of vibrations, she did nothing but strain against his solid grip.

The sensation, which was akin to pain and yet so clearly not, rose like a shrill voice, escalating ever-higher, ever-more intense, always seeming to have become as awful as it could ever be. She screamed, and then sounds that were indecipherable to her own ears left her throat, and her whole body went so rigid she felt as if she might turn to stone. She started to cry, but it was a silent sob into the fabric on her eyes, already wet with sweat.

Until finally, because there seemed no way to avoid it, she collapsed into utter submission. The pulse on her clit was now almost numbing, but still stabs of excruciating pleasure jerked through it.

Randy held it there as she lay limp, her legs twitching uncontrollably but her body otherwise inert.

Randy said nothing, and her submission didn't cause him to take pity on her. On and on the torture went, until she was crying, and her legs were shaking as if she'd caught hypothermia.

She would never know how long this went on. Long enough that the tide shifted again, and she started to crave another release, long enough that she was able to figure out that it was a game, long enough that by the time she figured out how to beg Randy to stop stimulating her, she no longer wanted him to.

"Please, Randy," she whispered. "Please... I can't..."

What was she saying? What did she want?

"Do you want me to stop?"

Randy's voice was calm, assured. He knew before asking her what her answer would be. It occurred to her that she should defy that expectation, and attempt to regain the upper hand. All it would take would be to form the word "yes;" a single syllable, and he would stop.

The perverted contraption of his psychological torture was clear to her for a second: if she asked him to stop, he would, and she would be the one to pay for an interrupted orgasm, perhaps never to feel release again for hours.

If she said no, then she was his whore completely, a slavish, quivering body that would spread and suck and bend to his every whim, and he would know that.

His hand was in her hair, tugging the sopping strands away from her cheeks. She felt his cock as it swung, hard as a rock and wet at the tip, against her thigh. He centered it at the entrance to her cunt, and her pussy lips nibbled at it like the mouth of a fish, smacking wetly. Her insides ached, like sore muscles, with the phantom sensation of his cock deep inside of her. And the vibrator continued sending her to ever-higher pitched levels of intensity, never letting her fall.

"You have to choose, Zoe," Randy said calmly, sliding a strand of hair over her cheek and tucking it behind her ear. "You have to beg me to do one or the other. Otherwise, you are going to be a very, very bad girl. And you wouldn't want that, would you?"

With the same skill he had used earlier that evening - it seemed like lifetimes ago - Randy retracted the pressure of the vibrator until it was only a wispy breath on her clit, still torturous, but no longer sending her toward the edge of orgasm.

Zoe sobbed. She tried to squirm.

Randy waited, patiently. She imagined the look on his face: smug, arrogant, complete dominance. Some other dark perversion beneath his skin, blackly shimmering in his eyes.

"No," she whispered, and found her throat was dry. Her voice cracked, and another sob left her lungs. "Don't stop."

"Beg," Randy said, almost before she finished.

The vibrator hummed ever-more lightly, the promise of relief evaporating.

"Randy, please, please," she said. Her lips felt swollen, clumsy. Tears trickled into her ears. "Please. I'm begging you. Please, don't stop."

"Better," Randy said quietly. "You can beg me better than that."

"Please," she sobbed. His humiliation was falling over her, intensifying her pleasure and amplifying the pain. "Randy, I'll do whatever you want, I'll be good, I'll be a very, very, very good girl, I'm begging you... I..." her voice was choked by a sob. "I, please, please don't stop, I'll do whatever you want."

She was met with silence.

"What else can I do?" she said, crying like a child. "Randy, please."

The vibrator was still humming, but he let it hover just above her clit. A reversed sensation, almost like numbness, washed over her, and then the craving that had been building smashed through it, and she sobbed pitifully. The air between the vibrator and her clit pulsed as a feathery, teasing whisper, only enough to make her want to scream.

She was limp as Randy flipped her over. Her fingers tingled, released from the pressure of her body that had cut off her circulation and made the tips fall asleep. Randy pushed her body into place, her ass in the air, and the fabric around her wrists squeezed tightly as he gripped it, suspending her arms above her lower back.

She howled as he slowly fed his cock into her ass. He took his time, as she howled into the bedsheets, finally biting them, not because her ass hurt, but because she knew that he was going to fuck her slowly, enjoying her need for release for a long time.

He fucked her at a leisurely pace as she howled uselessly into the bed. His dick was thick enough that when he plunged deep inside her, the root of her clit was jostled vaguely and she was given the promise of eventual release.

It went on and on, and she begged him, and lay still, and sobbed, and moaned. Finally, he pushed deep inside of her and tugged at her arms, pulling her up to a seated position on his lap. His breath was hot against her ear, and she felt his cock throb in her ass as he spoke to her.

"Beg me one more time, you little whore. Beg me to make you come, tell me you're going to be a good little whore and do whatever I tell you to

do. Whatever dirty, filthy thing I want to do to you Zoe, you're going to let me do it. Say it."

The sound of the vibrator again, the wispy feel of it between her legs, pumping the air around her sodden clit but not touching her. Her legs jerked, and she leaned back, a glob of spit rolling down her chin.

"Please, Randy. I'll do whatever you want -"

"Whatever filthy, dirty thing I want," he said.

"Whatever, whatever filthy, dirty thing you tell me to do, I'll do whatever you want," Zoe sobbed. "Please. I'll be a good girl."

"You'll be a good slut."

"I'll be a good slut."

"My little slut. My dirty, filthy, nasty little whore who does whatever I tell her to do."

A flicker of some indescribable feeling traveled through Zoe, laced with an urge to resist this request. She wouldn't do anything, she shouldn't do *anything*, there were rules.

But the thought was drowned out by the screeching need between her legs, and so her lips were moving long before it vanished from her mind.

"I'm your little slut, Randy..."

"My dirty.."

"Your dirty, filthy... uh..."

"You'll be my good little slut..."

"I'll be your good little slut. I'm your little slut. Please Randy..." her voice was desperate. "I'll do whatever you tell me to do...ah, ah, ah, *oh God!*"

The vibrator, whose contours she had only imagined, slipped into her pussy. It was bigger than she had expected. Maybe it was even different than the one he had used before. This was phallic in shape, small compared to Randy's dick. It rumbled at the root of her clit as Randy squeezed her between his legs and pressed her immobile against his chest.

Another immeasurable period of time passed as the orgasm built up from there, more slowly than some other application might have done. Zoe screamed, and fell silent, and then was shattered by an orgasm so strong it nearly wiped her mind clean of everything.

The next thing that was clear to her was that she was face down on the bed, and Randy was hammering his cock into her ass in hard, unrelenting

thrusts.

And then her ass was hot and wet, and he fell on top of her, still inside of her, and his weight crushed her for a moment or two, as she still lay twitching with the remnants of the orgasm that shook her from head to toe.

CHAPTER 4

"I need to go home."

Randy tied his bathrobe and regarded her coolly. She was collecting her clothing from the floor, wrapped in a towel, her hair wet, her body sore. "It's almost ten."

Randy said nothing, just sat in a chair, tossing an article of clothing aside as he did.

Zoe continued to arrange her clothing on the bed, gripping the towel. Randy's lack of response cut both ways inside of her. She was relieved, in one way, because her ass was sore and her legs were still weak, and she felt like she needed a gallon of Gatorade. There were physical limits to what she could do for Randy, and psychological limits to what she *would* do for Randy. And this was nearing the far-off, serious, outer-rings-of-the-solar-system level-of-"out," out of control.

But his lack of reply also angered her. Or made her wish for something else, at least.

Her hands were trembling, not so much out of fear, but with the tired tremble of exhaustion and dehydration.

"Josh is expecting me... home, so... I really, I don't even know what I'm going to tell him," she said, shakily. She wondered why she had said this. In theory, she knew it was because it had just occurred to her that she was still keeping up the ruse - with Randy - that Josh didn't know what they were doing.

But did it even matter anymore? It seemed to have gone to a distant, far darker place, in just one day. She wondered if Randy even cared whether Josh knew or didn't know.

She looked up at him. He had a glass in his hand, from where, she had no idea. A brownish color indicated it was whiskey. The man seemed to be able to produce drinks from nowhere.

His bathrobe was faintly tented, by his seemingly interminable erection.

His eyes were on her, and they burned her with an icy heat.

Something - a cousin of amusement, or perhaps the embodiment of a cat's sentiment while playing with a mouse - flashed across his face. He

brought the whiskey to his lips, and she thought she saw a faint smile just before his mouth was obscured by the glass.

He sipped it, and she stepped into her sodden panties.

"That wasn't our agreement, Zoe."

She looked up, abandoning the panties more because they were too crusted and twisted to be anything more than a nuisance. She let them fall to the floor and looked at him, the towel still clutched around her. "Randy," she said hopelessly.

He tapped his glass with one finger and arched an eyebrow.

"I can't... do... anything... I can't..." she stumbled on the end of the sentence, unable to say what it was she couldn't do. Randy's predatory gaze was peeling away her resolve, and the layers of thought and reason that surrounded her mind, and beneath all of that, she was just a trembling, gushing, swollen, engorged, aching piece of flesh.

"I need to go home," she said, tonelessly, after a moment passed and Randy said nothing.

He set his glass down, watching it as he did. It was done the way she might have imagined him setting down a cup of coffee in his office. For a moment, his spell was broken, and Zoe felt like she might be able to leave. She reached for her crumpled blouse, but made the mistake of looking back at Randy.

His eyes were burning into hers again. A knife of aroused fear stabbed her in the chest, cool and penetrating. Her back tingled, as if she had been touched. Worst of all, almost impossible to control or fight against, her pussy quivered and a heat radiated from there to the rest of her body.

"Of course you do," Randy said.

The blouse slipped from her hand, which had fallen open in weak paralysis. The coolness in her chest was only increasing, grabbing a hold of her with the kind of adolescent panic-attraction she hadn't felt since high school. She became aware of her chest rising and falling, its rhythms abnormal and as fast as if she had sprinted up a flight of stairs.

She was suddenly confused, the mismatch between Randy's words and his actions causing her head to move, like a glitch in a computer game. She felt the urge to say something, but if she did say something, what would it be?

"But you told me you were going to be a good little slut, Zoe," Randy said, unthreading the belt of his bathrobe. The material fell open, and his muscular body emerged from it, rather than it slipping away. His cock was prominently pointed above his lap, and Zoe's eyes fell to look at it, almost against her will. Randy dropped a hand to his dick and stroked it languidly.

Zoe lifted her eyes back to Randy's face, aware of the expression of helplessness on her own face, cringing inwardly at it but unable to stop it.

"You were going to be a dirty, filthy, little slut. *My* little slut."

"Randy," she whispered weakly.

"And I'm not done with you yet. So you may *need* to go home, Zoe..."

She took a sharp breath in.

"But you're not going to. Isn't that right?"

For a moment she was still. Her head shook, more like a reflexive tremor than an intelligible yes or no.

"Come over here."

She hesitated, and then made a final attempt to resist. "I have to go, Randy," she mumbled, her voice barely above a whisper.

Randy didn't answer. He continued to stroke his cock, staring at her with an intensity that she could feel against her skin, making it hot. Beneath her hair, her neck was sweating again.

"Come here," Randy repeated.

She walked toward him, wishing that she could stop herself. At the same time, the fire in her belly, the pulsing need of her pussy, the icy arousal in her chest and limbs, was intoxicating. The skin of her bottom flared with heat, as suddenly as if Randy had slapped her ass again. Each step rubbed the tender insides of her abused asshole against themselves, a sore, aching massage, exacerbating the emptiness of her body, feeding the craving to feel the massive organ in Randy's hand inside of her again.

She was in front of him now, and her lip quivered involuntarily. Randy let go of his cock and reached for her towel. He tugged at it and it fell from her body with a soft ploosh. He raked his eyes over her body.

He reached, one hand at a time, his eyes locked again on hers, for her knees. First the right, which he jerked toward him, to the outside of his left leg. She lost her balance but recovered, just before he jerked her left leg to the outside of his.

He gripped her waist, and spread his knees apart, pushing her legs open wide, until she had to fall forward to brace herself against his shoulders.

Then, as if she were no more than a rag doll, he lifted her hips easily and situated her cunt just above his turgid cock. She was leaning against his shoulders, but most of her weight was balanced on his arms, and he seemed to be no more strained by it than picking up a grocery bag. His knees pressed hers to the outside of the armchair, pinning her legs open. His cock brushed against her dripping cunt, over her clit, which was so sore and distended that the slightest touch made her jerk, and gasp.

Randy was staring at her pussy, at his cock embedded in her inflamed pussy lips as he moved her slowly back and forth, teasing her slit with his cock. His shaft swayed a little with the motion, bobbing away from her clit and making her mewl before it slapped back again into the wet muck of her cunt.

"I haven't fucked your sweet little pussy yet, Zoe."

Zoe stared down at his cock between her spread legs. Her pussy was screaming to be filled by him, and all she could muster was a whimper as he continued to tease her.

He arranged her hole over the crown of his dick, and with some minute adjustments, aligned her enough to push only his head in. Her fingers dug into his shoulders. The ache in her cunt was consuming her, her thighs starting to tremble out of need.

"Do you want it, little girl? You want this cock in your pussy?"

Zoe nodded, squirming. Her pussy was pulsing around his dick, and she was eager for more, desperate to feel all the thick inches of him slam deep inside of her and fill her up.

Randy waited, and Zoe mewled. She lifted her eyes to meet his. The message was implicit, and it burned through her as if he had voiced a command.

"I want it," she whispered. "I want to feel you in my pussy. I want you to fuck me, Randy."

A few inches of his cock pressed forward inside of her as he lowered her weight, but left her suspended tantalizingly away from filled. Her pussy squeezed around his cock, and his lips formed a domineering smile.

She continued to massage his dick with her pussy, unable to stop herself from howling listlessly as she did. "Please, Randy," she heard

herself begging.

And she was begging. She was begging him to fuck her because it felt like if he didn't, she was going to disintegrate, like the ache and emptiness in her pussy would swallow her whole.

Slowly, slowly, while she whined and begged, he lowered her onto his dick, until her weight was on his lap and his crown pushed against her cervix, in so deep that it strained the boundaries of her small body. She leaned her head back and started to rock against him, but the way he had trapped her legs with his and his firm grip on her waist made the movement almost futile.

One hand left her waist and traveled over her breasts, up to her lips, along her jawline. He tilted her head toward him and looked at his fingers as he smeared them over her lips. "Not so fast," he whispered. "I'm going to fuck your little pussy for a long, long time, little girl."

He moved his fingers to the back of her neck, and pressed gently but firmly against the base of her skull. His thumb pressed deep in the side of her neck, each finger putting pressure in a line on the other side.

Zoe tried to roll on his cock, grinding her clit against him. But he held her immobile again, with this new grip on the base of her skull and the back of her neck.

She whimpered in frustration. Randy's cock throbbed inside of her. "Now I'm going to make you fuck me nice and slow, Zoe."

He pushed up on the base of her skull and used the hand on her waist to control her ascent, and then, with equal control, lowered her slowly back to his lap. Again. And again. And again.

Zoe's legs began to tremble and she heard another series of animal, tortured sounds coming from her throat. But Randy kept fucking her - or making her fuck him - at the glacial pace, for what seemed like hours, until Zoe was covered in a sheen of sweat and her fingers were driven like nails into the flesh of his shoulders.

He lifted for what seemed like the millionth time, and Zoe quivered and moaned.

"What do you want, Zoe? Let me hear you say it."

"I want you to fuck me," she said, almost like a reflex. "Please, Randy, please fuck me."

Down his shaft she went, slowly, squirming, and then back up. She howled in desperation. "Please, Randy, please, I want you to fuck me, I want it. Oh!"

She tried to grind against him, but it was useless. He held her trapped, fucking at his own leisurely pace. A frustrated sob-moan left her lips.

"I could fuck you all night like this Zoe," he said, and she shuddered.

"Please Randy," she begged. He smiled.

She put her hands on his forearm. "Randy please, please fuck me harder, please. Please, I want you to fuck me harder."

Randy pressed his lips together, still sliding her up and down his cock, no faster. Her juices were running down her thighs, her ass was slippery with hot, wet pussy juice, cum, and sweat.

"Tell me what you want again," Randy breathed.

"I want you to fuck me," she whined. "I want, I want you to fuck me hard, I want you to fuck me, Randy, please."

"You love my cock."

Zoe mewled.

"Say it."

Zoe moaned and tried to roll against him. "Please Randy,"

"Say it and I'll fuck you nice and hard, Zoe. Tell me you love my cock and you want me. Say it."

A cold-hot warning of danger flashed through her again, and she met Randy's eyes. Had she heard him right? Was it *wrong* to say that?

"Say it," Randy repeated, holding her firmly by the waist and gripping her hair with his fingers. He suspended her halfway down his cock and pushed gently out on her legs until they were locked against the sides of the chair again. He let her struggle, futilely, against his grip, and squirm, but she was unable to move.

Zoe's lips trembled. Her pussy ached so badly now that she could hardly think of anything else. "I... I..."

"I love your cock, Randy. And I want you."

Zoe's eyes watered, though she wasn't sure what from. Randy's grip on her hair stung, and her need to be fucked drove her to desperation. "I love, I love your cock, Randy. I love your cock."

"I want you," he repeated firmly.

"I want you," she whispered.

Randy didn't move. Zoe's chest felt shattered. "I love your cock, Randy, please. I love your cock and I want you, I want you, I want you to fuck me."

A long moment came after this, in which sweat dripped from her face onto Randy's belly, and she stared at his cock, halfway encased in her pussy. Her cunt was red, glistening, swollen beyond recognition, gulping at his dick like a strange sea animal. She made a terrible sound.

Randy released her hair, and gripped her waist, ramming his cock into her with one violent thrust.

She was bouncing on him next, his cock ramming deeper and deeper inside of her, until she felt like she might split open. His fingers slipped into the wet, sweaty, cum-slimed crack of her ass and wormed into her asshole. He gripped her ass with two fingers deep inside of it, and used the leverage to lift and smash her, over and over, on his cock.

When she came, she shrieked, and she heard herself, howling and screaming, but she felt like she was outside of her own body by then, watching it. She watched, as if from afar, as her legs spasmed and then went limp, and Randy stood up, her head lolling like the head of a limp doll. As he threw her onto the bed, and lay on top of her, and began to slowly fuck her, intimately, for a long, long, long time.

He fucked her until her hips were sore, and her pussy was just a throbbing, heaving mess. She didn't know which side of an orgasm she was on. This went on forever, while Randy fed her lines to say to him and she did so obediently, legs spread, cock sawing in and out of her, gliding through the slosh of her cum like a piston in oil.

It was like a dream, and maybe it was, and maybe she faded in and out of consciousness. Randy was on top of her and she rose and fell too many times to count, until all experience felt like she was coming, or just about to come, or never going to come. It was torture and ecstasy.

So, who could be responsible for what they said in a moment like that? Who could even know if, by the end of that long, endless session of slow, torturous fucking, she had gone from saying:

"Randy, I want you to fuck me, yes, I love your cock, I want you..."

To:

"Fuck my pussy, this pussy is all for you..."

To:

"I love it when you fuck me. All I want is your cock, all I want is for you to fuck me."

And who could be sure if, in that delirium, because Randy gripped her hair and growled in her ear, and she had been saying whatever he wanted to hear, she *didn't* say: "I love you?"

Was it *I love you* or *I love you fucking me*?

I love you or *I love your cock*?

It was hard to know, among all the things he made her say, all the ways he made her beg.

He lay on top of her after he came, filling her pussy up just as she crested one final orgasm. Their skin was totally slick with sweat, and when he finally rolled off her, it seemed more like he slipped, finding no way to stop himself. His cock slithered from inside of her, and she struggled to pull her legs together. Her hips were sore from being spread open so long, her pussy was throbbing wildly and raw, and somehow a craving still lurked inside of her.

Her eyelids felt heavy. She closed them, and then they flew open in a sudden burst of blood pressure, as the memory of the evening, and the realization that it must be wickedly late, erupted in her mind.

She jerked her head toward the bedside table, where she thought she had seen a clock.

"Oh God!" she shrieked. She sat up, pushing Randy aside. He rolled onto his back and draped an arm over his forehead. From beneath it, he was looking at her. He reached for her body but couldn't get a hold of her. She scurried off the edge of the bed and grabbed her clothing.

Randy lay where he was as she got dressed, but then rose, entirely with his abdominal muscles, to sitting. He draped his legs over the edge of the bed and tried to reach her leg.

"It's almost one," she hissed at him, straightening her skirt out the best she could.

Randy rubbed his face.

"You might as well stay," he said, at last, as she fell to the floor to look for her phone.

"Stay? Stay?!" she whisper-shrieked. "Randy, Jesus!" She was shaking. She was dehydrated, disoriented, and she had been out way too late, and done way too many utterly crazy things...

One by one, the moments hit her, like a slap in the face.

She sat up on her knees and put her hands on Randy's. "I need the pictures," she said. "You took pictures. They're on your phone, I saw you - I need them. I need those. You have to delete those!"

She had no idea why this particular detail, of all the details, came to her as suddenly and as frighteningly as it did. Since he had done it, she hadn't given it a single thought, not while he was fucking her and torturing her and making her say crazy things. Not a single thought. But when she saw her own phone on the floor the memory crashed through her: Randy had taken utterly obscene photos of her.

Randy shrugged. "I'll get them to you later -"

"Where is your phone?" she hissed.

Randy looked at her, and for a brief second she was terrified that he was going to crack his terrible, arrogant smile, and make her do something to get them back.

But he leaned back, his abdomen rippling with strength, and dropped his arm to the floor at the foot of the bed, pulling up his pants. He shook his phone out.

She snatched it from his hand.

"What's your password?" she said, her voice frantic.

Randy took the phone from her calmly, shaking his head. "No," he said, and his tone was calm, orderly. Fatherly. He swept his thumb over the pattern-lock and handed the phone to her. Then he leaned back on one elbow and watched her.

"I thought you wanted those for Josh," he said, as her fingers swept wildly over the screen. He seemed neither upset, nor sinister. Almost amused. She looked up at him.

Her heart thudded in her chest. The first picture she had seen was of her, with Randy's cock in her mouth. It was pornographic, slutty, shameful, and needed to be deleted... but...

Her stomach twisted.

Shaking, she fiddled with the phone, trying to send the pictures to herself. She didn't know how his OS worked, she felt drunk and her fingers were clumsy. Frustrated, she tipped her head back and pushed her hair from her face. She felt like she might cry. "Just... I can't..." She tossed the phone at him. "Get rid of them," she said desperately.

Randy raised an eyebrow. "Get rid of them...?" he asked. He twirled the phone in his hand. "Or do I keep them? Or do you want them for Josh? Do you really, really plan to show your husband pictures of what you've done?"

Zoe looked at him icily. "This isn't... that's what this is, Randy."

She said this with less conviction than she meant to. Her heart fell when she heard the unconvinced tone of her own voice. Something, something about all of this felt like betrayal to Josh, and reminding herself that *he knew where she was* did not help things. She would tell him everything. Everything.

Her eyes narrowed. "Send those pictures to my phone," she said. Her voice was quiet. Anyone who knew her might have recognized that she was angry.

Randy registered nothing on his face. He flipped the phone toward himself, moved his fingers across the screen, and then looked up at her.

Her phone buzzed.

She confirmed that she had the pictures, unable to look at them for long. She kept her face serious, and then she met Randy's eyes again.

"Give me the phone," she said, putting her hand out.

Randy paused, as if he were considering something, and then smiled. He dropped the phone into the flat of her hand.

She deleted the photos, and then handed the phone back to him. She pushed off the floor and stumbled toward the door.

"Maybe you shouldn't drive, Zoe -"

"I'm not drunk," she snapped. She looked back at him. He was leaning his elbows on his knees. There was something almost pitiful in his expression, and it made her heart sink and a guilty throb ping around inside of her, but there were so many conflicted feelings in her chest that whatever she felt in that moment melted into the soup of regrets and betrayals and guilt, and she knew no more why she felt that way than she did about anything else terrible inside of her. "I have to... I just have to get home," she said, hurriedly.

And then, almost running, she scurried out of his house.

CHAPTER 5

The house was sealed up too tightly, like all modern constructs. His father had informed him of that, within five minutes of arriving for his first, and so far, only, visit to the new townhome. Even though he lived just half an hour outside of the city.

This was the first thought that went through Josh's head when the air pressure of the sealed-up house changed, causing a soft pop of air in his ears to sound like an explosion, mingle with a dream, and shake him suddenly awake. His eyes opened to the darkness of the living room, the blue light from the kitchen, and moving shadows on the floor that confused and dazzled him, dancing with the wisps of his dream, which burnt up like papers in a fire and floated away like ashes.

Another change of pressure, this one from within, made his ears pop with a dull thud:

The shadows were his wife. He had fallen asleep. It was - he looked at his watch - 1:37am.

And his wife had been out, or most likely *in*, with Randy. How long was that? From the end of her workday until now?

She moved in the darkness, like a grainy black and white photograph. She held her shoes in one hand and moved oddly. Her movements were the sort of jerky, slow-motion stagger that a person uses to creep along soundlessly, but they seemed strangely clumsy.

A stab of crisp pain, growing ever-more familiar, jabbed at his heart. She was *trying* to be quiet, to come in unnoticed, not to wake him.

The inherent unfairness of it was the first thing he thought of: their agreement was that she tell him everything, and that she would stay so late with Randy doing god-knows-what, and try to sneak into the house, made anger flare up inside of him. It flared up, incipient, from the same place that all flares of marital "unfairness" came from, a sense that someone was not holding up their end of the buckets of banal details that come with sharing a life with someone. From the place where un-broken-down cardboard boxes are tossed into recycling bins, or dishes are stacked in the sink, or toilet paper not replaced on rollers.

But it grew into something vicious, because what that spark was burning was something much more than a mere banality.

Josh was slouched on the couch, having fallen asleep, head up toward the ceiling. He sat up, resting his elbows on his knees. It was a movement designed to start his circulation flowing, give him time to think. The whiskey glass that had been in his hand when he fell asleep, and slipped onto his knee in a precarious balance with his arm, fell to the floor. It landed with a subdued plop on the heavy rug, but the sound was the only one in the entire building, and Zoe jumped, whipping around to look in the direction of the noise.

His eyes were adjusted to the dark, he had that advantage over her. He could see that when she looked into the living room, she was searching blindly in the shadows. She was scared, but that could have been because the sound was unexpected and could be a burglar, as much as it might have been because she was caught.

"What?!" Zoe whisper-screamed. Then there was a slap, and the room blazed with light, forcing Josh to squint.

"Josh," she said, less frantically. He judged every contour of her voice and decided that she sounded both terrified and disappointed.

"It's 1:30," he said, though he wasn't quite sure why.

Zoe set her shoes down. She arranged them carefully, as if she were placing them where they belonged, though they were being placed against a piece of furniture that divided the room and not where shoes were ever stored. When she stood up, she shook her head to send her hair away from her face, over her shoulder, where it clung ever-so-briefly to her shoulder blade before sliding forward again. "I know that," she said. Her voice was as flat as Josh had ever heard it. "I was trying not to wake you up," she added, also flatly.

Her hair, Josh noticed, was stuck together. It had an unwashed, mussed appearance to it. Strands seemed damp, others sticky. Her face was pale, all make-up smeared off it. Her lips were a reddish-pink, where her lipstick had stained them and then been rubbed away.

"You were with Randy all this time?" Josh asked, but the question was silly. "Did you fall asleep again?"

Zoe was still holding a small handbag in her left hand. She stared at the air between herself and Josh, as if the question had left his mouth as a phantom and now hovered there for her to contemplate. The pause was entirely too long for him to trust whatever she was going to say next, and

she seemed to awaken to this fact, blinking, focusing on Josh. "I... asleep... no. Not really. Not exactly."

Not exactly. What could that mean? Josh wondered, his mind helpfully percolating filthy images that drifted in a mist over his vision as he looked at his wife.

His heart had begun to tick faster, accelerating with each tense second that transpired between them. He had no right to be angry at her, and he knew that: she had only done what he had asked her to do, nudged her toward doing, fantasized that she would do, and she had done it with his permission.

And yet some film of dishonesty was hanging on the words between them.

His cock was hard. It probably had been when he had fallen asleep, and when he dreamed, and the whole time he was awake, looking at his used, damp, fucked-out wife. But only at that moment did he become aware of it, a pain that had been pressing at him for such a long time it had faded to the background. Like a noticed headache, it was now prominent, consuming his thoughts.

"Come here," Josh said quietly.

She shifted her weight, almost imperceptibly, from one foot to the other. "Josh, I -" she began to say, but her voice was hoarse, almost like she had a cold. She cleared her throat. "I stayed way too late..." she said. "I'm so... tired, I really have to sleep... work is already a mess... because of..."

But she trailed off, and in the middle of the sentence she seemed to give up on the idea of going to bed and started walking toward him.

"Did you sleep here?" she asked, when she was close to him.

Josh didn't say anything at first, and Zoe didn't seem to know what to do, so she fell down to her knees in front of him. Now that she was close, he could smell cum and her pussy. Her clothes were wrinkled, like they had come from the bottom of a hamper. His cock pulsed, and his balls ached. He touched her hair. "I was waiting for you," he said simply.

Zoe's eyes blinked heavily, and the truth of her claim to be tired was evident. He knew he should probably let her go to bed - in fact, he knew that was what he *should* do. But he knew that he wouldn't, and his fingers were already unzipping his pants as he leaned back against the couch.

The deal, after all, was that she would tell him *everything*. A mean thought, one he felt bad for having, fluttered through his mind: if she didn't want to be so tired, she should just come home at a reasonable hour. After all, if he was going to let her go out and get her brains - and by the looks of it, everything else - fucked out of her, then she could extend the courtesy of holding up her end of the bargain.

It was a shitty thought to have, and he knew it, but he couldn't avoid thinking it. Feeling it, viscerally.

He would only realize later that Zoe's reaction was strange. She seemed to contemplate this, as if she had heard his thoughts, etched in the tone of his voice, and had some time to weight them in her sleep-addled mind. She was seated on her heels, knees to one side, because she had slowly collapsed from standing and relaxed.

Her expression was somewhat vacant, directed nowhere, and then she blinked heavily again, looking up at Josh when she opened her eyes. Her demeanor changed, and she straightened her back and rose to sit straight on her heels. "I had a hard time leaving," she said. Her eyes dropped to Josh's cock, which was now in his hand. "I had a picture I needed to get off of Randy's phone."

She leaned forward and licked the tip of his cock. A quick, baby-animal-like lick, incredibly stimulating, vaguely disturbing. She watched her own tongue again as she swirled it around his crown, scooping up his precum.

The cool stab of jealousy pierced his chest again, his reptilian mind noting that Zoe now slurped up cum like it was ice cream, and from the files of his mind came exhibits numerous and detailed enough to seal up a Supreme Court Case, snapshots of Zoe's tremors and winces, shudders and frowns, whenever, in the past - the past before Randy - Josh's cum had crossed her lips.

"It's a picture of me sucking his dick," she breathed on his cock, and his entire body jerked, seemingly ahead of her even saying the words. Her lips formed a smile and enclosed the head of his cock in a heat that threatened to burn.

Josh opened his mouth, and a sound left his throat. It might have been intended to be the first consonant in a half-formed sentence such as "Show me the picture," or "I want to see that." But the grunt that left his mouth was

misshapen and not from a human language, because just as he started to speak, Zoe's lips formed a tight, tight seal around the crown of his dick, her teeth just grazing, tugging gently against the ridge. And then she began to suck.

She sucked so hard that her cheeks hollowed in. Cum was siphoned from inside of him and into her mouth, and he felt the swipe of her tongue, within the suctioning cave of her wet mouth, before she started to suck again.

He put a hand out to her head, his abdomen rippled. "Oh God, Zo -" he stuttered.

She released him with a pop. Licked her lower lip, which had a pearl of semen on it, gray in the streetlight. Her hand went to his shaft and her fingers pushed his away to close on his dick. She rose up on her knees. "But that's not what it looks like," she said. Her voice was hoarse and sticky again, and with her hand on his cock, her lips smeared with cum, and the suggestiveness of what she was saying, it was impossible not to hear that the croak had been shoved into her throat by Randy's dick, over and over again, and his thick, creamy seed, gargled in the back of her throat.

She swallowed his cock to the edge of her hand before she unclasped him and proceeded to take him into her mouth, right to the base of his cock.

As he stared, his orgasm already straining through the vessels of his cock, ready to explode, she sank onto her heels again, forcing his cock to dip, to buck against the back of her throat. She looked at him and began to suck his dick again. The back of her throat massaged the crown, and by then, his mouth open, his body rigid, he was already spurting his cum into the back of her throat.

She released him slowly, her tongue swirling over his shaft, and then grasped in her hand to hold him this way and that as she licked cum from the underside of his dick, off his balls, back along his shaft and then from the slick, shiny crown, where his cum was glued to his flesh with a thick spit from deep in her throat. He wondered how many loads of Randy's cum she had swallowed that night. He shuddered when she sucked at the tip of his dick again, her lips closed around the face of his crown.

A final lick, and then her eyes blinked heavily again. She sat back, her hand listlessly on his thigh now. With her other hand she pushed her hair

from her face. "I'll tell you the rest tomorrow," she said. "I have to go to bed, Josh."

Her voice was almost pleading. He was still dumbstruck by her performance, his mind and his heart whirling in a sea of confusion. He said nothing, trying to find the right response, and Zoe seemed to tire of waiting. Her hand slid from his thigh to her lap, upturned, as if she had reached some level of desperation. The vacancy was back in her eyes.

This was brief. She snapped out of it and stood up. "I'm going to bed," she said, her hoarse voice crackling at the end of the sentence. "You coming?"

But she didn't go to bed right away. She went to the kitchen, and was there for quite a while.

The next morning he found an empty two-quart Gatorade container on the bottom shelf.

She trudged upstairs after that, pausing only to wave at him, in the strangest way, with a smile. "I love you," she told him.

And *then* she went to bed.

CHAPTER 6

She woke up to bright light. Only a few moments of calculation, whirling memories, and quick thoughts, were enough to make her jump to sitting, throwing the covers off of herself. She turned to look at Josh's side of the bed. It was empty, but slept-in.

Time. Time, time, time... she scanned the room frantically for her phone, but scanned her mind at the same time and realized it was in her purse. She was speeding down the hallway within seconds.

Josh was in the kitchen. "Hey, hey sleepy-head," he said. She held a hand up to him and dove for her purse. "What time is it?" she asked, frantically. She knew she sounded impatient, she dropped her phone as she tried to flip the cover open.

She was late for work, she knew that already. It was too bright for her not to be. Hessler allowed her to work a flex-time schedule but there was no way she would be able to get there in time even for that.

Josh was coming toward her from the kitchen. "Hey, it's only eight-thirty, I -"

"Eight-thirty?!" Zoe shrieked. The phone flew from her hand again.

" - I called in for you, late, don't sweat it," Josh said. He had a cup of coffee in his hand and was extending it to her. "You're good until twelve, half-day, Alicia said."

"Oh my God," Zoe said quietly. She pushed her hand through her head, shaking it. "No, no, no, no, no, no, no... I can't... this is *not* good."

She ran up the stairs, almost tripping up on the fifth stair.

"Zoe -"

"Josh. Just!" she sniped.

It was like a fever dream from college years as she moved through the bathroom, opening the door, spinning under cold water, changing to the closet, throwing clothes on the floor, feeling helpless looking into a drawer full of socks.

"Zoe," Josh said calmly from the doorway. "Calm down. It's all good, that's why I -"

She marched past him, facing him sideways, her eyes and face contorted by anger. She was out of control, and she knew it, and she also knew that she was directing all of that anger at Josh when it wasn't really

about him, or even the fact that she was late. But it felt good, because facing the messier truths below that layer of panic was too much for her at the moment.

"It is not *okay*, Josh, that's the problem. That's... you don't even understand what I... I've got so much shit on my diary, I'm so behind, I can't be... I have to take care of this crazy lady, she - you know what? Just... God. Never mind!" She was brushing her hair viciously, which was causing the large waves to frizz and the volume of her hair to grow exponentially.

The sight of it almost made her want to cry. What the fuck was she going to do with her hair? She was late for work, yet again, because she had been out all night, writhing like a slut and begging Randy to fuck her.

She hadn't told Josh everything, and now, in the light of day, she realized she would never be able to bring herself to give him all the sordid details of her submission to and humiliation at the hands of Randy, or the details of the things he had *done* to her. As she had driven home the night before, she had pared down the entire day and the things she was willing to share with Josh to just a single picture, a handful of details: things she thought would be enough, but not everything.

It was all out of control, on so many levels. It had been a terrible and idiotic idea from the start.

But, like a good friend who said the same exact thing about smoking, while waving an unlit cigarette in the air before lighting it, she saw her eyes in the mirror and knew that, while all of that was true, and she hated herself for it in many ways... she, like her friend, was just going to be smoking another cigarette again and swearing it was the last one.

She set the brush down, giving up on her hair. Battling with tears of tired frustration, some of which had to do with the actual situation - her hair, and being late for work - she pulled her unruly waves into a bun, angrily stabbing a handful of bobby pins, reclaimed from some long-ago fancy party and tossed into a drawer, into the mess to hold back the wildest strands. One of the pins was caked with spilled eyeshadow and had an odd blueish tint, but she didn't have time to care.

She adjusted her clothes briefly in the mirror, carelessly tossed on a little bit of makeup, and then looked at herself in the mirror.

For a brief moment, splintered into the guilt and shame that was bogging her down, her reflection reminded her of something. A wisp of

nostalgia ignited in her mind, but like a fizzled, phosphoric blaze, it burned hot, blinded her, and then was gone.

But while it was there, she laughed - a laugh that was not about anything funny, or out of nervousness. The laugh, and the sentiment of it, remained like the after-image of a bright light: it was mirth.

And then it was gone.

She collected some makeup into a bag and hurried down the hallway.

Josh had her coffee ready to go in a to-go mug.

Josh. Her eyes got wet.

"Hey, I'm sorry, I had no idea that you -"

She leaned in and kissed him, almost desperately. "I'm sorry," she interrupted. "I just... have a lot of stuff going on -"

"If I had known -"

"Really," she said, giving him a hug. "It's my fault, sorry I was snappy, I promise to... I promise to catch up on all of this, tonight, okay?" She looked at him. "*Everything.*"

Maybe she had meant for that to come out as a commitment to a confession. It was certainly how she had meant it when the word formed in her mind. But somehow, it left her mouth in a teasing, sexual voice.

She was relieved that Josh's eyebrows went up, and a smile formed at the edges of his mouth.

She put her arms on his shoulders. "I love you," she said, kissing him passionately on the lips.

"I love you, too," he said. He was partially confused.

"Try to come home early... or like, on-time, tonight, okay? If you can?" she asked. She kissed him again on the cheek. "See you."

"Okay, love you," Josh said, holding her hand until it slid from his.

"Oh, and, good luck."

She stopped at the door, juggling her purse and the coffee to open it.

"*With what?*" she was about to ask.

But she stopped herself. "Thanks," she said, smiling.

The light outside was murderously bright.

*

She stopped at a small park n' ride parking lot midway between the downtown core and the poorly-dubbed "Center," where Hessler's offices were, in a far-flung corner of the southwest archipelago of big box stores

and beige houses. It was, in another time, the "Center for Commerce and Technology," but was now just an odd skyline jammed into suburbia, name shortened and forgotten, and an annoying commute for anyone who didn't want to live in the aging subdivisions plagued by the occasional redirect of air traffic on windy days.

The lot was full, so she stopped with two wheels edged up on a ratty hill of grass, just to give the clear impression that she wasn't trying to park or be in anyone's way, though it was anyone's guess who she believed would witness this display. It was almost ten, and so the commuters had long since commuted.

She took her phone out with determination. The decision had been brewing since she left the house, and she was past the point of giving it any further thought. It took her only moments to delete the photos: she didn't look at them or linger on them. Typing a message to Randy took even less time, and she barely paused to look over the words and make sure she hadn't typed nonsense. She sent the message, and deleted all of their messages, including that one, and his number, and tossed her phone into her purse.

Feeling like a weight had been lifted off her shoulders, she drove back to the highway, and continued to work.

I have to get my head together. I can't do this anymore, it went too far. I'm deleting you from my phone, please don't contact me. It's for the best.

CHAPTER 7

Josh moved his hand under the table, realizing that he was tapping with increasing ferocity, the edge of his laptop. It was Jim Reid's sharp glance that alerted him to it. Once his hand was under the table, and tapping at his thigh, he realized his teeth were clenched. In his chest, his lungs were slowly constricting, as Pete Stark droned on, and on, and on.

The minutes on the sad office clock, which seemed painted to the face on any ordinary day, were now spinning wildly, time slipping away at a frenetic pace. It was as if the rest of the world was in another plane of space-time, though, because while the minutes were flying *out there*, making him later and later returning to Zoe, time *felt* like it had stopped in this bubble enclosing Pete, Jim, Josh, and the rest of the team.

Pete was looking at Josh a lot, as though he knew that Josh had somewhere else to be. True, Josh always had somewhere else to be, but Pete seemed to have sniffed the desperation in Josh's body *tonight*.

Zoe had already texted him twice. Something had been wrong with her this morning, and it wasn't just lack of sleep or whatever was troubling her about work. Between her return from Randy's, and the odd sexual encounter that night, and waking up in the morning, something had definitely changed with Zoe.

It was hard to believe, because she had slept soundly all night, and not even woken when he got out of bed. If something had been troubling her, wouldn't she have mulled it over the entire night, awake and troubled and not sleeping?

That's what Josh had done.

"Josh?"

Josh kept his expression completely still. This was always the best tactic when he spaced out, which he had considerable experience doing, and then getting caught doing. Since he had entered the "creative class" workforce, most let it slide, because almost everyone was a space cadet half the time in this field.

Still, there were always Pete Starks looking to grill you at a meeting.

"Yes, uh..." Josh said, and then scratched his head. "It's hard to, uh, say."

That was a good answer for about 97% of questions.

Pete folded his arms over his chest and blinked slowly, Displeased. Josh let his eyes flick quickly over to Jim, who gave an imperceptible shake of his head.

"Hard to say, as in, you're not understanding what I've been discussing at every single meeting for the past three weeks, or hard to say, like you can't get it done the way I'm asking you to?"

Josh inhaled. Now they were circling the issue, whatever it was, it had something to do with Pete Stark's endless, seemingly pointless, changes.

"Hard to say," Josh said slowly, "like, I don't want to sound like an idiot here, but some of these changes are not going to make a difference to -"

"Let me ask a question," Pete said loudly, leaning on the back of his chair, because he was standing, because he was always standing. Today Pete Stark, as always, was dressed in a black turtleneck sweater and black jeans. Like the psycho from the ill-fated con job of the decade, Theranos, Pete Stark fancied himself a Steve Jobs.

"Are *you* Modulation Inc.?" Stark continued.

Josh looked up at the ceiling and inhaled deeply. "Of course I'm not," he began.

"Good. Good, that is what I thought. So, you are *not* the client. So you are *not* paying to have this product the way you want it. Is that right?"

"Okay," Josh said, lifting his hand at the wrist, palm facing Stark. "I got it."

"Do you?"

"I got it."

"So, what's the hang-up, Joshy?"

Oh, this fucking guy.

The fantasy came to him at least three times a day, and today it manifested so strongly he could almost feel himself standing up, laptop in hand, and tossing it across the room at Pete Stark's face. It left his fingers like a Frisbee, sailing through the air, clonking his shit-eating mug right at the bridge of his nose. Josh could even hear the crunch of his hipster, non-prescription glasses, which he only wore to be a dick in meetings.

Josh sighed. "Pete, there's no problem. I just... I feel like we're going in circles, and I have something planned for tonight -"

"Un-plan it, Joshy. Or un-register yourself with TopTier. Anyone else have an issue with getting this finished by tomorrow, 8am San Fran time?"

Everyone stared at their screens.

"Great. Get on it."

Pete left, in his usual half-Nazi, half-gay march.

"Dude," Jim said, without looking at Josh.

Josh slid the phone out of his pocket. There were no new messages from Zoe.

He leaned back in his chair and stared at the screen of his phone, thumbs hovering over the digital keyboard. His heart was sinking with each passing second.

What to write?

"Wife?" Jim said, quietly, and without looking up from his screen.

Josh shot him a contemptuous glare, but Jim seemed to have already anticipated Josh's expression long before he looked up from his screen. He registered no surprise and looked back at his own computer, shaking his head. "It's a rough game, Wilson."

Josh stared at the blank message.

There was no choice, really: if he didn't stay late, he was going to be out on his ass. Out of TopTier, which in this town, in this field, meant literally out on his ass. Pete Stark would come and go, and so would this project, but the hellscape of freelancing for any other recruiter that awaited him if Stark got him fired was permanent and impoverished.

He flitted briefly through his imperiled life: the townhouse, the enormous car payments, the gravitational field of debt that tugged at him and Zoe from the borders of the middle class. And then he thought of Randy, and his Jag, and his probably paid-for Jackson Heights *house*. There was never a good time to lose his job, and their whole lifestyle with it, but now was a particularly bad moment.

He could suck it up. Zoe would be disappointed, and he sensed that there was some very profound problem that she needed him to address. He knew she wanted him to be home, to have time to delve into whatever had happened to her the evening before, whatever had changed her mood overnight.

He also had to admit to himself - however briefly, before covering it up as if he had lifted a tarp and found something he didn't want to see - there was the fact that, on a very carnal level, he wanted her to tell him the sordid details of her night with Randy. A night of fucking him, after a whole

weekend of fucking him. She had promised him those details, and he wanted those details. And he was *owed* those details.

He closed his eyes.

It was a Catch-22, and he knew it, and he knew, deep down inside, that he should be making a different choice when he opened his eyes and slowly typed his generic message to Zoe.

Zoe was not Pete Stark, and Zoe was not going to fire him instantly. He would find time to deal with Zoe, and this whole crazy mess with Randy - if he just finished up this project and got out from under Pete Stark's thumb.

Pete Stark was not forever. And neither were Zoe and Randy, and neither was the hurt he might cause her by not going home tonight as planned. The details of her night with Randy would be his to hear even if he had to wait.

But being fired by TopTier *was* forever, as everyone here knew.

Zoe, please don't be mad. This project is fucked, the client is schizo, and if I don't stay here and get this done tonight, I'm going to be out on my ass with TT I'll make it up to you, I promise. Just as soon as this project is over.

He almost wrote, "I love you," but it seemed trite.

He sighed as he tucked his phone into his pocket. "Okay," he said, leaning over toward Jim Reid. "Where are we with the product page... uh... what are we changing?"

Jim had his head tipped back to dump Tums into his mouth. He crunched chalkily as he answered.

"Everything."

CHAPTER 8

Zoe stared at Josh's message for a long time. She was wearing a towel around her body, her hair dripping rivulets of warm water down her back. She sat there so long that she started to feel chilled.

She had heard the beep of a message from the shower and hurried to check her phone. There was no way to be honest, even with herself, about what had caused the arrhythmia in her heart and the almost panicked need to get to the message immediately. Had she wanted it to be Josh, or Randy?

The answer was confusing, and thinking about it led her into a fog of emotions and thoughts. She wanted Josh to come home. She had done drastic things, and made bold decisions, and she wanted to follow through with them. She wanted to tell Josh she had gotten in too deep with Randy, she had planned, in the car, what she was going to say to him. She didn't want to give him details, or photos. She didn't want to keep going like this.

She was happy with Josh. When she said that aloud in the car, to herself, emphatically, as though he were there and she were talking to him, it had brought hot tears to her eyes. She was *happy* with Josh. She loved him, she loved their life, she loved the intimacy that they shared. When she thought about Josh, she thought about the warmth and the love in their marriage.

When she thought about Randy, she felt nothing like that. Randy was dark, an obsession, something she didn't like to think about for too long.

And she wanted Josh to come home, she wanted to explain all of that, to confess her mistakes and ask for forgiveness, to shove all of this under a rug and forget it ever happened. It had all been a mistake, and she knew Josh could forgive her because he had a part in it.

But as she scurried toward her phone, the towel wrapped haphazardly around her, she knew, deep inside, that her heart wasn't fluttering, and her limbs weren't so juiced up they were about to shake, because she was expecting to see a message from Josh.

It took mere seconds to cross the room and pick up her phone, and in those seconds she went through all the different scenarios that would follow if the message appeared on her phone with a telephone number - she would recognize it, she had a mind for numbers she was emotionally attached to - and a message from Randy. Maybe it would be filthy, and she would need

to delete it and try to forget it. Maybe it would be apologetic, and she would have to be strong and not take Randy's bait, because that's what it was: bait. Maybe it would be angry. Maybe it would be a concession to ending things, a sweet note to tell her he would never forget her, and he hoped things went well for her in life.

In those same seconds she had flash-fire thoughts of what she would do in each case. When her mind ventured to the more dangerous outcomes, she steered herself back on track. Filthy message: forget and delete. Apology: ignore and delete. Angry: show to Josh. Goodbye: don't respond, maybe save.

But the message was not from Randy.

Disappointment poured over her slowly, burning literally as if someone had poured hot tar over her head. It sank over her scalp, down her shoulders, dribbling to her waist. Was it disappointment that it wasn't Randy? Or did the disappointment come from Josh's words?

How many minutes went by? Five? Ten? Even more? It was dark when she finally put her phone face-down on the bed, and she stared at the inky-blue sky outside for a few minutes.

The feeling overtook her suddenly, unexpectedly. It began right in the center of her chest, in some cavity of her heart that she rarely felt. It was a cold and empty feeling, spreading, and then dulling to an ache, a sense of falling that didn't end. She waited, searching for the cause of it, but searching, deliberately, where she knew it wasn't. Searching only in the parts of her heart that were lit - not in the darkness, where she knew the answer must actually lie.

Perhaps it had to do with Josh, had to do with the endless, endless messages telling her he would be late, just until this project or that project ended. That would fit, wouldn't it?

She swept into the darker parts of her mind and her heart, reaching into them blindly. It was as if her fingers passed over something in the darkness, outside a ring of light, and she found something there and recoiled. Only the briefest of touches, only enough to give it a vague shape, a vague texture, a vague temperature.

Was it the form of Josh's distractions, his consistent late nights and putting work above their marriage?

She picked up the phone and looked at the message again.

An explanation so simple, an explanation that made sense.

The free-fall of sadness was still inside of her, not abating. Her eyes were wet. She looked for a name to give to the feeling and came back with "disappointment." She tried it out.

Disappointment.

She looked into the ever-darkening sky, now almost black. The house had grown dark around her. There was a memory from her childhood somewhere in that murk, but the implications, like everything we think about in the dark, alone, were far too grotesque. She stood up and flipped on a light switch.

She could see herself in the en-suite bathroom mirror.

Late did not mean he wasn't coming home. *Late* did not mean that he didn't care.

But didn't he care? Didn't care enough about what she had been doing with Randy all evening Monday, to come home and talk to her about it? She had sent him two messages telling him that she really wanted to talk, she had gone out of her way this morning to tell him to come home, tonight of all nights, because she wanted to talk to him.

A fit of adolescent rage overtook her as suddenly as the free-fall in her heart had. She marched, indignantly, like her sixteen-year-old self might have when told she couldn't say out past twelve, into the closet.

The juvenile character of her rage was like kindling, and before she knew it, she was jerking clothing off hangers with wet eyes and a head full of steam. She sniffed loudly and shook out the skirt she had selected, almost vengefully: a short, tight, Alicia-worthy skirt she hadn't worn in seven years but had left in the closet, as some kind of flimsy hope that she might go clubbing again someday. Next to it was a gold-threaded, tube sweater she had purchased in Ibiza, and she threw that on with no bra underneath it.

"Fuck," she spat, squeezing the sweater over her frame, "Both. Of. You."

She knew she was being childish. That was in the back of her mind the whole time. It was in the back of her mind as she practically slapped her tears off her own cheeks, as she angrily brushed blush on her face and had to remove half of it because it was grotesque. It was in the back of her mind - a running voice, the voice of reason and adulthood, over and over again saying, *you're acting like a teenaged brat* - as she dug into the bottom

drawer of her vanity and found her darkest eyeshadow, a thick black mascara, a set of lipstick colors that hadn't been used since her 21st birthday party, but which, like the skirt and the tube-top, had been moved from house to house like mementos, or perhaps shrines, to another time.

The voice was still repeating this to her, but it had become a bit of a background chant, one that was fading away with each passing minute, as she found a pair of shoes in the back of her closet that would sort of go with the outfit she had concocted. It chanted, fading, while she glanced at herself in the mirror, quickly satisfied, because at the end of the day, she was *hot*. She was a tiny, athletic girl with a flat stomach and perky tits, even with no bra. She had a cute face, and Zoe knew how men looked at her. She would never grace the cover of a magazine, but she would turn heads. Especially in a get-up like this.

She didn't linger on her appearance long. Her veins were pulsing with the adolescent rage, that was only burning brighter, feeding itself, causing a chain reaction that she knew, in the back of her mind, she could stop, if she tried.

She stomped down the stairs and found her purse. She grabbed a light black jacket, and it was longer than her skirt. She didn't bother to tie it in front. Vaguely aware she looked a little like a hooker, and not caring, she stuffed her keys, her change purse with some cash and her bankcard, into a tiny black purse.

She still didn't know where she was going when she realized she didn't have her phone. She stomped back up the stairs and retrieved it. With the final, far-flung hope that a message would be on it that would pour cold water on the fit she was having, she flipped it toward her and looked at it.

"Jesus. Fuckers," she said. She felt drunk, even though she wasn't, and she had no idea what she had meant by saying that.

She trotted down the stairs.

She paused at the foot, surveying the tidy living room, the matching furniture, the carefully crafted, hipster, creative-class life she and Josh had built. In the oh-so-trendy part of town.

A memory flashed through her mind, from long ago. High, a joint in her hand, at some gathering in... where? Ecuador? Thailand? She couldn't remember. She was laughing. "Jesus," she was saying. "I'll never have a fucking couch."

It surfaced so clearly in her mind, so tangible she could almost hear the music and smell the weed, feel the ratty fabric of the couch she had been sitting on with her bare legs. And then it was gone.

The clock ticked.

She made a sharp left and swung herself around the banister, a strange high making her feel like she was walking on air. She was getting calmer as if she *had smoked* a joint.

She probably should. But she didn't have one.

She left the cupboards open and the bottle on the counter with the empty shot glass. It was childish, too, but now the voice telling her she was acting like a petulant child was almost gleeful, almost her friend. Two shots of *pisco* - a terrible, horrible, drink she had brought back from Costa Rica, and left unopened - had her good and ripped before she even left.

It, too, had been moved from house to house, a reminder of things that used to be.

There was something to be found in all of that, Zoe thought lazily, as the pisco closed its fist around her mind.

"Fuck it," she whispered, closing the door behind her, looking for the Uber she had summoned, trying to think of where to tell it to take her.

CHAPTER 9

NOT

A

PROBLEM

The words swam in Josh's vision as he drove, almost recklessly - though Josh was not one for utter recklessness, not even in moments like this - home from the office. The streets were dark, it had been ten when he checked his phone and saw Zoe's message, which was sent at 9:00.

He had checked his phone repeatedly after sending his last missive, telling her he wouldn't be home on time as promised, and then he had gotten caught up in the project. Zoe knew he was like that - everyone knew he was like that. He started working on things and lost track of time. It was what made him a good designer, what made him eligible for TopTier, what paid the *fucking bills*.

Not a problem. What the hell did that mean, two hours after he had texted her?

He had sent messages into the ether, and the silence from her end had pulled his mind out of his workflow and into the real world, where his ideas and creativity were eaten away by thoughts of Zoe, as if a team of rats had been chewing on them.

Even the unflappable Jim Reid had lost his patience. Everything had taken forever. It was now 2am, and no one on his team was happy with Josh.

The messages remained, lonely on his screen, unanswered, one after another:

What does that mean, Zoe?

If there were anything I could do about it, I would. I promise.

Zoe, just write me back.

The final message, which he had never sent, still hovered on his screen.

That wasn't an invite to go see Randy

Mercifully, her car was in front of the house. Lights were on in the kitchen and upstairs. Zoe, a fanatical environmentalist of the reusable-bag-toting, drying-laundry-on-racks-type, was not one to leave lights on in an empty house.

He jogged up the stairs and unlocked the door.

He knew the house was empty without calling her name and standing in the wash of silence. He did it anyway, charging into the kitchen, where the overhead light shone down on an opened - cap still off - bottle of the liquor she had toted with them through every house move, some horrible crap, she had said, from Costa Rica. A single shot glass, with a tell-tale puddle of the same liquid, was on the counter next to it.

"What the...?" he said aloud. "Zoe?!"

He called her name anyway, and went upstairs, even though he knew he wouldn't find her there. He surveyed the scene: clothes on the floor in the closet, a hair straightener plugged in, and probably left on, but mercifully set on a timer, drawers open and makeup scattered on the counter. Not just any makeup: flamboyant, unusual makeup, the kind Zoe never wore anymore.

The surge came from the lower part of his abdomen, and the rage began at the back of his eyes. Both sensations traveled through him, colliding in his chest, constricting his heart in a cocoon of nausea and fury. The combination was unpleasant, his vision blurred, and he wondered if he was going to have a heart attack at age 28. He fished for his phone, but it wasn't in his pocket.

"Goddammit," he yelled. "Goddamn, fucking... fuck! Zoe! Fuck!"

Not even in his teenage years, when testosterone had grabbed him by the throat and turned him into the kind of person all nice boys become, temporarily, like wild animals that begin to bite and snarl at their beloved rescuers, was Josh ever the kind of guy to break shit, or punch holes in walls, or start actual fights. He had been a shit disturber, but a quiet one, the kind to lob acerbic wit and not physical jabs.

So it was a stunning development to find his fist embedded in the drywall, his knuckles screaming in pain. The seconds preceding that action were also lost to him. The wall caved in crumbles when he pulled it out, and he stared at the dust, the chalky-pink stain of blood, surprisingly small, that dotted his middle finger knuckle.

He was panting.

He stepped backward and sat down on the bed. The punch to the drywall had sapped the impulse that led him to be violent, and maybe that

was a good thing, because a clatter downstairs - keys on tile - announced the return of his wife.

*

She was drunk, that was evident immediately. Her eyes were glassy and slightly red-rimmed, and she stepped out of a shoe, tipping and almost losing her balance in a graceless way that was entirely unlike her.

His eyes moved over her body, and her attire, trying to absorb the details, a laser-focused, accusatory glance-over, looking for, even wanting to find the traces of her infidelity.

She gave her hair a toss, and her face was defiant. Her eyes were dark, shadowed by a trashy-looking, but also very sexy, dark eyeshadow. Thick, black mascara was caked to her eyelashes, but it was intact. As was her lipstick.

She was dressed in a skirt he didn't remember having ever seen, and a tube top he remembered only because he had unpacked it and held it over her head, teasing her to wear it. She flung her black jacket toward the coat hook, and it missed and fell on the floor. Her kicked-off heels were high, and her toes were red. She stood on one foot, with surprisingly good balance for a drunk, and rubbed one of them.

He could see by her expression that she was ready for some kind of fight - not usually Zoe's thing, a hard thing to activate, but once activated, almost impossible to diffuse. Of the two of them, Zoe was the more confrontational, the more likely to charge at something.

Well.

She didn't know what kind of mood he was in.

Whether subconsciously or not, he lifted his drywall-caked hand and held it in his left, massaging his fist. Zoe's eyes went right to it, but she knew him well enough, even in her soused state, to not be alarmed that he was threatening her. More like telling a story.

"What'd you punch?" she slurred, plopping into a barstool at the counter and leaning clumsily to grab the bottle of liquor and shot glass.

"Do you really think you should-"

"Do me a favor," she said icily, in a tone he had never heard before. She spun in the chair and tipped her head to the side. "And don't fucking tell me what I shouldn't do. Okay?"

"You just seem pretty -"

"And you seem like the picture of... fucking... mental health, Josh Wilson." She poured a shot and lifted it to her lips, smiled, and slammed it.

She made a face. "Oh, God," she said. "That really is terrible shit." She slammed the shot glass on the table. "What did you punch?"

He looked at his hand. "Upstairs. Where have you been?"

Zoe edged her elbows over the back of the barstool, which only she was small enough to do. It was a very imposing stance for a moment, as she crossed her legs - Josh would later reflect that she had sort of a Sharon Stone thing going, and for all his anger, he was, in the end, a man, and found it arousing - but her right elbow slipped and she almost fell off the stool as she was saying, "Wouldn't you - fuck." She righted herself and looked up at the ceiling. She let out a cry of frustration, and then looked back at him. "What does it even *matter*?"

There was a silence.

Zoe's eyes filled up with tears, but he recognized that this happened without her willing it, or even realizing that it had happened until one spilled over onto her cheek. She wiped at her cheek and looked at her hand in surprise, then tipped her head back in what looked like an attempt to get her tears to sink back into her eyes.

"I wasn't with fucking *Randy*, if that's what you're wondering," she said, when she tipped her head back.

Josh stared at her. A feeling, similar to the one he had experienced when watching Zoe with Randy in their bedroom, gripped him: *this* was not his wife.

But unlike the version of Zoe who had been fucking Randy in their bedroom, this Zoe did not pull him in two directions, one of which was arousal and the other of which was a savory jealousy.

This Zoe was completely foreign, totally unnerving. A Zoe who was doing something she didn't ever do, a distant Zoe. He was not connected to this Zoe through the same nebulous chain of events as the Zoe who slept with Randy. He hadn't nudged her in this direction, fantasized about her being like this.

A dark cloud of terror blossomed in his chest.

Zoe was still looking at him confrontationally, which was also atypical of her. He knew that the natural thing to say at this point would be: *so, who were you with?* Or even, *so, what were you doing?*

But those questions loomed somewhere in the periphery like monsters he did not want to face.

Zoe tipped her head to the side. "Are you going to ask me?" she said quietly. Her tone was even, her voice barely above a whisper. The end of her question cracked a little, but her eyes did not brim over with tears and her expression remained confrontational. Josh couldn't get a read on the spirit of the question.

His chest grew tight. What if the answer to his question was one he didn't want to hear? What if his wife had turned into an uncontrollable monster? What if he was the one who had unlocked this monster and let it loose?

As he deliberated, his chest empty of everything but the cold breath of fear, Zoe lost her patience. She shook her head and let out a laugh that was a little bit like a bark. She folded her arms across her chest. "I went dancing," she said, shaking her head with an expression of disdain.

Josh's heart fell through his body, as the new possibilities of Zoe's infidelity began to erupt, like ulcers, deep within his mind: images of Zoe grinding against a young, bare-chested man, having sex in a dirty bathroom stall, or an alley, floated into his thoughts. Inexplicably - because he hated all those ideas; they made his blood boil - his cock twitched to life.

Zoe walked around the counter and toward him, her eyes on his. As she walked past him, close enough to brush against his shoulder, which she avoided by scrunching it up, she turned to him. "By myself," she said angrily.

And then she went upstairs, while Josh stared into the empty kitchen, trying to make sense of that.

*

Zoe had closed the bedroom door, which was something Josh was fairly sure had never happened in the history of them living in the house. He almost abandoned his plan at the end of the stairs, but he had summoned a lot of courage and, in his opinion, maturity, by coming up to talk to her, so he walked toward it in the darkness anyway.

He knew it would be locked, which is why he turned it slowly, not wanting Zoe to hear him attempting to open a locked door. For whatever reason. As the handle turned slowly and then hit a hard stop, his heart sank, and he released it slowly, hoping she hadn't seen it turn. His face was inches

from the door, and for a moment he lived in an imaginary, alternate future: he lifted his hand and banged gently on the door twice with a closed fist. His imagination was so lucid he almost felt the cool wood on the meat of his palm, almost really heard the handle rattle as Zoe unlocked it, almost really smelled her skin when she opened it. His abdomen crunched against the dropping sensation as Zoe of the alternate future threw herself into his arms.

But he did none of these things. He stared at the door, inches from his face, feeling his own breath bounce off the wood and back into his stinging eyes. His hand throbbed. Anger crept from the base of his skull and around his head, and he became aware of his clenched jaw after a moment or two.

It was a maxim of marriage, wasn't it, that everyone should sleep on it? Besides, Zoe was so drunk, she would not be able to carry on a decent conversation.

He retreated to the office, and lay, facing the ceiling, in the room where he had lain just nights before, listening to his wife fulfill his dark fantasies.

He felt swallowed into the belly of a beast.

*

Zoe was gone when he woke up, after what seemed like almost no sleep at all, to the sensation of his phone rumbling. He felt for it in his pocket, and around him, and had to sit up to find it on the floor, vibrating against a leg of the day bed.

"Jesus," he said, disregarding the text, which was from the phone company. It was early, and he had plenty of time to get to work, but not if he had to confront Zoe before going in. Also, he was exhausted: the night had been a series of small sleep events, nightmarish dream-thoughts that he awoke from, sweating, unable to recall what about them had disturbed him so much. It was a primordial soup of terrible thoughts and worries, imagining that Zoe was going to leave him or become a raving whore, seeing his life and his future fall apart.

He stood at the bottom of the stairs and tried to get a sense of whether or not Zoe was up there. The light in the hallway told him the bedroom door was open. There was no sound from above, but it was hard to know if that meant she wasn't there.

"Zoe?" he finally said, as evenly as he could muster.

He trotted up the stairs and into the bedroom. "Zoez?"

He knew she wasn't there, by then. The sheets were crumpled on the bed: Zoe seemed to have slept as fitfully as he had.

He put his fingers on his eyelids and rubbed. The tiredness was almost all-consuming: his eyeballs itched, his balls ached, his forearms felt like rubber. He had no choice but to go to work. He shook his head vigorously and made an animal-like sound. Then he pulled his shirt over his head and headed for a shower.

There was a note from Zoe scribbled on the back of an unopened junk mail envelope. The coffeemaker was off and the coffee in the pot ice-cold. He picked up the envelope and stared at the words, his bleariness blurring the lines of Zoe's most jagged, hurried handwriting.

*I have to be at work on time, so I left early. I want to talk about things. Will you please, please, please find a way to get home at a decent hour?
I love you, Josh. We can work all of this out.*

CHAPTER 10

"Have a seat," Neil said, with the faux cheer that all managers use when they are about to provide "constructive criticism." Or a pink slip.

Zoe pulled the chair in front of his desk out sullenly and forced her features into as neutral of an expression as she could manage. The truth was that if he was firing her, she would be kind of grateful. It was unlikely to be the type of gratitude that extended through the week, but for today, she would be quite happy to grab the handful of knick-knacks on her desk, toss them in her purse, and go home to take a nice long nap.

"You're not in trouble, Zoe, I just want to clear that up, right off the bat. This is an informal meeting, nothing on your HR record, that's why Candice isn't here."

Zoe inhaled slowly, to avoid doing anything she would later regret.

"I just want to know if everything is going okay for you... you know... personally."

Zoe looked at her lap.

"It's just that... uh, lately your diary has been consistently behind, you're frequently late, you're looking... a little tired. Like I said, it's not anything I felt the need to bring Candice in about, not at this point, but, um... it's... noticeable."

Zoe nodded and exhaled.

"Is something going on in your personal life?"

Zoe crossed her arms over her chest and looked at Neil. A mischievous instinct almost got the better of her; she was tempted to tell him, *Well, actually, yes. My husband wanted me to fuck other guys, so I got into a BDSM relationship with my ex-boyfriend's father, and frankly, I'm just not getting enough sleep, what with all the anal sex.*

"I think it's pretty obvious," she said, instead, "that I've got some personal problems."

"Is it... is there anything we can do here to help you out? There are reduced-hour programs for family support issues and short-term -"

Zoe held up her hand dismissively. "It's not going to be a problem anymore," she said. Whatever Hessler Insurance's employment insurance programs looked like - and it was a fairly liberal company - she felt pretty

certain that "extramarital affairs getting out of control" would not be a qualifier.

Neil looked at her, and gave her the slow blink and forced smile of a person who knows you are talking complete bullshit, but does not want to call you on it.

She stood up. "I'm actually gonna - um, you know, thank you, it's nice of you to... think of this - but I'm just going to get back to work. I'm sorry about... all of... you know... my diary, the late arrivals. It's all handled now. Promise."

"Okay. Well. Just remember that if you need to access any of those programs, we're here for you at Hessler."

It took an incredible amount of strength to stop her eyeballs from rolling out of her head.

"Thank you, Neil," she said, in a saccharine voice with a saccharine smile, before turning to leave.

Her diary *was* out of control, and Alicia popped by to let her know she wasn't thrilled about it, because Alicia was downwind of anything bad that happened to Zoe's accounts.

She leaned her arms on Zoe's low cubicle wall and waited, as Zoe continued to type, pretending she hadn't heard the jingle of her enormous earrings, or smelled the bizarre combination of perfumes that Alicia used. Pretending, for that matter, that her peripheral vision was so terrible she didn't see the very tall, angry Latina woman twisting her bracelet, with a sort of mafia-like pointedness, less than two feet away from her.

Alicia waited, and Zoe typed with pursed lips, until she couldn't take it anymore. Still staring at her screen and typing, she said icily: "Do you need something, Alicia, or are you just really curious about this form letter I'm sending out to Stapley Sanitary Rentals?"

"I'm interested *why* you're sending that," Alicia rejoined instantaneously, her nasal Bronx accent particularly polished, "since I already did that for you, like the other twenty things I took care of this week, and last, to cover your ass. But no, I was here to ask you if there is any way you can send over your RPAs, *princesa*, because I've asked for them three times and now I got that Joe guy in accounting getting on my case about it."

Zoe pushed her chair back, ready to snap, but lost the will to do it - because Alicia had, in fact, asked for the RPAs *more* than three times, and she was entitled to be ticked about it. She sighed deeply instead and closed her eyes.

"Neil pull you in for a talk about your personal life?" Alicia asked carelessly.

Zoe shook her head and opened her eyes.

"Yeah," Alicia said. "He did that to me once, and honestly, it irritated the fuck out of me." Alicia punctuated this declaration by stabbing a pointed finger at the air. "You doing okay or are you going to get yourself canned?"

"I'm fine."

Alicia blew a bubble and said nothing for a moment, while Zoe sifted through some papers on her desk.

"Okay. Well. Get me the RPAs before you do anything else. I can print them out if you wanna email it, just... you know. Do it. Soon. This Joe kid is not somebody I want to talk to more than I have to."

Zoe turned back to her computer.

Alicia's bangled wrists left the cubicle airspace and she jingled slightly. "You know you can talk to me if you want to," she threw out, walking away.

Zoe stared at her computer.

Talking to Alicia. Is that what her life had become? She was taking advice from a twice-divorced accounts assistant who wore leopard print daily and slept with more men in a week than Zoe had in her lifetime?

She stared at her keyboard and willed her fingers to type.

CHAPTER 11

"You're home," Zoe said, an obvious note of surprise in her voice.

For a moment, Josh had a flare-up of jealous anger. Was there surprise in Zoe's voice because she had some alternate plan for her afternoon? The anger gripped him, and before he could stop himself, he said, "Why? Did you have some kind of afternoon plan?"

He sounded bitter, and immediately regretted it. This was not how he had wanted this conversation to start off, and in one simple exchange, it had already derailed from the conversation he had hoped for and envisioned. And he was the one who had derailed it.

Zoe tossed her purse - really, truly tossed it, hard, onto the couch. But because she gave it such a burst of energy, the purse bounced off the couch, onto an end table, and the lamp wobbled precariously, but did not fall. They both watched it with bated breath.

"Don't start with me, Josh," Zoe hissed.

Josh held up his hands. "I'm sorry," he forced himself to say. "I didn't mean for -"

"I broke things off with Randy," Zoe said, with almost a snarl. "That's what I wanted to tell you yesterday."

Josh was struck silent. It wasn't anything he had expected her to say.

"You broke..." he murmured.

Zoe looked at him.

"So why... what was all that... from last night... I mean... what happened?"

For a very tense moment, a lot of different expressions worked their way across Zoe's face, each of them threatening to send them, together, off on a different timeline, into different futures.

At last, however, Zoe's face settled upon an expression of confusion, and she took a few steps to the side, to collapse on the couch. "I don't know," she said quietly.

There was a lostness in her voice and her expression. Josh immediately felt bad for her, a reflexive desire to protect her. The anger he had been feeling left him like air rushing from a punctured mattress, without explosion, a slow but steady drain.

He sat down on the love seat, and there was a long and torturous silence between them. He recognized this kind of silence, the silence before real confessions, and while he didn't especially want to confront whatever Zoe was about to tell him, or try to confront his own feelings by having "a talk," he actually felt relieved that the moment appeared to be here.

He reached for her hand, at the same time that she looked up at him, her eyes brimming with tears. "I don't know," she repeated. She closed her eyes and two perfect teardrops sprinkled onto her cheeks. "I don't know what we're doing anymore, Josh. I thought I did, but now I don't. It's like... it went from something fun, to... something... I don't know. In like one day, I feel like everything got turned around. And now... I don't know what to do."

"Zoe," he said quietly. He knew what he *wanted* to say to her - or, at least, he knew what he felt and how he wanted her to understand about how he felt. Capturing it, with words, was going to be another matter.

"I've been trying to figure it out," Zoe continued, in almost a whisper. "Why I did it, why I kept doing it. Like, what was it that I expected, or wanted, or..." Her voice trailed off, and whatever was at the end of those thoughts, inside her mind, made her eyes wet again.

Josh didn't know what to say.

Zoe seemed to be finished. She was staring at her hands. He could see that there was still a lot more on her mind, but he didn't know how to coax it out of her without stepping on some minefield.

He put his hands behind his head.

The silence continued, and he couldn't bear it anymore.

"I guess," he said, "I don't know, Zoe. I don't understand what... I thought everything was okay, last weekend, Monday night. I got... carried away with it. But I thought it was something you were into, too, so... I just don't understand what changed."

Zoe wiped away a tear under her eye but remained silent.

He squeezed her hand. "Just tell me," he said. "Tell me what it is, what happened, what changed. I can't... I can't do anything about it if I don't know what it is. I'm sorry that I don't know what it is, Zoe. I really am."

Zoe stared at her hands, her lips trembling with words she obviously wanted to say. Or maybe she felt like him, and felt something, but had no idea how to express it.

"I don't know..." she began. "How to," she finished, in a whisper.

"Just try. Please."

Zoe shook her head vigorously.

"I thought everything was okay, Zoe. I thought this weekend was... I thought you were into it. I thought you went to see Randy the next day, you seemed excited about it, you were going to try and get a picture, and then Tuesday happened and it was just... what happened in between those two days?"

Zoe pressed her lips together and shook her head again. Then a sound, not a sob as much as a wet exhale, of tears and breath, escaped her lips, almost like a sound of incredulity. "That's just it, Josh. I don't, I don't... I don't..." She put her hand to her forehead.

"You don't know?"

She tsked. "I wish it were that simple. It's not that I don't know. It's that I don't... I don't know..." she looked up at the ceiling. "I just don't want... I don't want to tell you."

Fear, heavy like lead and cold as ice, bashed through his chest and dragged him down. A tightness took over his lungs.

"You don't love Randy, do you?" he asked, in an ice-edged whisper.

Because it was the first thing he thought of. And once he said it, he realized that it was the thing he feared, the monster lurking in his thoughts.

Zoe, however, jerked her eyes toward him and gave him a look of disbelief. "Love Randy?" she said, in the sort of voice Josh ordinarily hated in women: the taunting, disdainful tone they reserved for suggestions they found stupid. The tone of middle-school girls dismissing early love, strung to adulthood by all the dismissive ridicule of women.

The raw honesty of that tone, though, was welcome in this context.

"God," she said, looking at the ceiling. "No, I don't love Randy. What...?" she shook her head.

Her eyes dropped to the floor. "It's just the..."

She inhaled deeply and closed her eyes. Another tear snuck from her left eye and slid, glistening, over her smooth cheek. "It's the things I do... with Randy. It's the... I don't want to..."

"If you don't want to do them," Josh said quickly, "then you shouldn't do them. I don't want you to -"

"It isn't that," Zoe interrupted. Her voice was quiet but strong, jagged, like a serrated knife, and it cut through Josh's voice and all of his thoughts, straight to his heart. He had no idea what she would say next, but a cold feeling was creeping back through him again. "It's that I want to do them," Zoe said, her voice a whisper now. "I *want* to do them, that's what the problem is. But I don't... I don't want to tell you... I don't want you to know about them."

The pain that was traveling through Josh's body settled now in his gut, and a wave of nausea passed through him that turned his neck hot and made his forehead bead with sweat.

"You okay?" Zoe said, because she was looking at him now, and he knew what he looked like to her. Clammy, pale.

His hand had involuntarily relaxed around hers.

What could Zoe be doing with Randy, what conceivable, filthy, horrible thing - so bad that it exceeded the filth of the weekend, which he had seen with his own eyes in all of its filthy glory - that she didn't want to tell him about it? How depraved could Randy have gotten?

He could feel the color returning to his face. "You said..." he said shakily, "you promised you would... our agreement was that you would... tell me..."

His sentence fell apart, and he felt like he was spinning off in outer space, unable to see anything but a void, whirling around him, with no up or down.

"I know that," Zoe said. She squeezed his hand. "I know that. I know what I promised and I meant to keep that promise... this is... this is why... I had to stop. And this is what -" her voice seemed to get strangled, and he could hear in its breaking the same pain that he choked on himself. "This is what I wanted to tell you yesterday. It's what I was going to try and sort out with you."

She was back to whispering now. Her hand had relaxed. "And then, like always, you didn't come home -"

"Zoe, I couldn't have -"

" - and so I got so mad," Zoe said, her voice turning from a whisper to a fitful anger. Her hand squeezed tightly over his, as if she had forgotten his hand was in hers. "And so I just... went out. I went out and I was going to find some guy and fuck him, or, I don't know, go to Randy's, or something."

Josh stared at her, waiting, his mouth open.

"But I didn't," she said. "I just went dancing, by myself. And this guy was hitting on me, and he wanted to get out of there, and I told him I just needed to go to the bathroom, and then I left."

"Zoe, I didn't... I would have come home if -"

"That's just it, Josh -"

"You didn't even hear what -"

"But I already know. I already know what you're going to say, that you'd come home if you knew it was important. That's what you always say. And so, then I thought: okay, I was really just looking for a way to get Josh's attention, in this whole thing, that's what it was all about. Or... I don't know, I just wanted to do something that would make you *finally* put me over work, or something..."

Josh seized upon this. "Zoe... I only do this... I only put up with all that shit, all that shit at work, for *you*." But what began as a tender explanation, a reassurance, flared into anger without warning. "You think I enjoy taking Pete Stark's shit every day? No. But I do it. I do it because we *had* to have *this* townhome, this 300K-overpriced fucking townhome, in *this* neighborhood, and we had to have *this* furniture, and *those* cars -"

He cut himself off, because now it was Zoe who was staring at him with a look of shock on her face. She snapped her mouth closed.

He was standing; he couldn't remember having done that. Zoe pulled on her knees, and looked around the house. Then she shook her head again and put her hand to her forehead. "This is not... what I wanted to tell you."

Josh was breathing heavily. He was regretting having said what he said, because he could see from Zoe's expression that it didn't have anything to do with what she had wanted to say. Like all marital arguments seemed to, this one was growing heads, and he had lost sight of the original problem.

"Tell me what you were going to tell me," he said. "Zoe, I didn't mean to -"

"I didn't know this house..." Zoe's voice trailed off. "I don't even like this house that much. I don't even like... any of this." She looked around, throwing her hands to the side helplessly.

Josh could feel a new kind of rage building up inside of him. "That's just -"

Zoe looked up at him sharply. "Don't," she pleaded. "Don't... don't get mad, not about that, not about -"

"How in the hell am I not supposed to get mad about -"

"Because that's not what I wanted to talk about, Josh, it's not it, that isn't the problem, that isn't what's wrong, we're talking about Randy right now, about... this... thing..." she looked around again, and her voice trailed off. "I came home because I don't *want* to sleep with some other guy. That's not what... it's not just about getting your attention. It's something else."

"With Randy," Josh said coldly.

He wasn't hearing her, and he knew it. He knew she was talking about something else completely, but he couldn't lodge from his mind that single sentence: *I don't even like this house.*

"I have eaten so much shit," he said, fury undergirding his quiet voice, "so that you could have this life."

Zoe's eyes had been directed downward, and her eyelids floated upward now. Her eyes seemed to have become unfocused, as if she was looking through the wall. "That's just it, Josh. I love this life. I'm not... none of this has anything to do with *our* life -"

"Oh, no?" he shot angrily. "Explain that to me, Zoe, because you just said, and I quote, 'I don't like this house, or this life -'"

"That's not what I said -"

"It *is* what you said."

"It's not what I *meant*, then. God. It's not what I'm trying to say!"

Josh laughed bitterly in response.

"It doesn't have anything to do with you, or us," she said loudly, facing him. "It doesn't. It just doesn't. It isn't about *you*. I started it because of you, I started it because I thought it would be about you, and I *wanted* it to be about you. I really did. But it turned into something else. Okay? And now it's about... me. And anyway, anyway...God, *anyway*, I just explained that *it's over!*"

There was another long pause, terrible and silent, as they stood looking at each other, each of them tense with anger and resentment.

"This isn't what I wanted," Josh said. The thought left his mouth before he had much time to think about it, and as soon as he heard it, he was relieved, because it spoke to the most important truth. *This* wasn't what he had wanted or envisioned.

Zoe was still defensive. "Do you think it's what *I* wanted? I'm not -"

"Zoe," Josh interrupted, holding his hands up. "Please, look, listen... I'm trying to extend an olive branch, here. Okay? This isn't what I wanted. When I say that, I mean... I didn't want to fight with you -"

Zoe fell onto the couch with an exasperated sob. "What did I think would happen?" she asked the ceiling, practically crying. She shook her head. "Of *course* this was going to happen. It was a stupid, stupid idea and we never should have -"

"Look, Zoe. Before you get... so worked up -"

"Josh -" Zoe started to interrupt, and he held up his hand to stop here. "*Don't*. Don't... don't pick apart every word I say, please. Please. Just... I'm trying to talk about it, and it's hard, and if you dissect every single thing I say and the way I say it, we'll never get anywhere."

"You, too, then."

"What's...?" Josh started, but cut himself off. This was exactly the way arguments seemed to always go: turning into meta-arguments about *the way* the other person was arguing.

"Before you get any more upset," he said quietly, "please just listen to what I have to say. Or ask. Okay?"

"Fine," Zoe said, begrudgingly.

"I just want to know, I just want to understand, what it is that happened between this weekend, and Tuesday night. Because - and tell me if I'm wrong, Zoe, please tell me - but I thought the weekend was hot. And then you went out with Randy Monday, and that's where things seem to have gotten strange. By Tuesday, everything was fucked up, and now here we are. So all I want to do is get a better picture of what changed. Okay? That's all."

Zoe stared at the wall in front of her for a long time. She had her arms crossed, and Josh was having a hard time figuring out if she was angry, or sad, or some obscure mix of the two.

"This is the problem," she said at last. She looked at him. "I really don't... I don't know how to answer that question."

Josh edged toward the couch, and cautiously sat on it, like he was approaching a wild animal, because, at that precise moment, that was his best read on Zoe. If she bit him, he wouldn't have been all that surprised.

"Let's start with the weekend. Okay? I thought... I thought the weekend was hot. I thought you did, too. Things seemed okay at the end... you went to work. Do I have that wrong?"

"No."

"Okay. And then... Monday. Randy asks you to go to his place after work. You do -"

"So..." Zoe said, and then she pressed her lips together.

"So...?" Josh repeated. A stab of jealousy pricked him in the chest.

"What? Randy didn't contact you? It was the other way around?"

Zoe's eyes brimmed with tears and she chewed on her lip. Josh would have admitted it to no one - he didn't, in fact, even like admitting it to himself - but with her tear-filled eyes and swollen lips, she was incredibly arousing to him.

"This is the part..." Zoe began. She wiped a tear away. "This is the part that, um... I don't know. This is where..."

"I mean, Zoe..." Josh said. He put his hand on her knee. "If you called Randy, not the other way around, then it's no big -"

"That's not what happened." She was looking straight ahead again.

Josh's chest felt cool and heavy again. He waited.

"Randy, um... he *did* contact me. Monday. First. But, um..."

She put her hands to her face, covering it. "Oh God."

Josh reached deep into the realm of possibilities and came up empty-handed. If Randy called her, then what else could there be? It wasn't like he didn't *know* what she was doing. She had told him, after all. She had come home and admitted it.

"I don't get why you're... I don't know. Upset, Zoe."

In an instant, a fear materialized inside of him, and his entire body went ice-cold with its appearance as a thought. He looked down at his hand on Zoe's knee, and it seemed as if he was reaching toward her from another universe, and alternate reality, a place where things had gone terribly, horribly awry. "You don't... you haven't like, fallen in love with him or something, have you?"

His voice was quiet, almost a whisper.

Zoe whipped her head toward him. "What? Randy? God. No. Jesus... no." She shook her head and put her hands over her face again. "No, that's not... even remotely..."

Relief filled Josh's heart, because he realized, just as suddenly as he had feared it, that this was the only thing that mattered to him: that Zoe didn't have *feelings* for Randy. And, even if it made him a fool, he believed her.

He squeezed Zoe's knee. "Look. It's... so Zoe, whatever it is, whatever happened... if that's true, you don't have any feelings for Randy, you don't love him, then... there's nothing I can get mad about, or, you know... that's all that matters to me. If that's true, that's... you can tell me anything else."

Zoe kept her hands on her face and started shaking her head with greater vigor. Josh could tell that she was crying because of the wet sniffles.

"Just tell me," he said patiently.

"Josh, I just... the truth is, I just don't... know *how* to. I told you I would tell you everything, and I planned to, and it seemed like... fine, you know? That's what I *meant* to do. You have to believe me, I really did. But..." she dropped her hands.

Josh watched her face, as she stared at the wall, and he recognized in it the slow cementing of resolve on Zoe's features. The tears seemed to recede in her watering eyes. She took a deep breath in.

"Look," she said. "This is what happened. Everything happened just like you thought, up through Monday. And I also thought it was good, it was fine, it was sexy. Except... well, Randy said something that I'm not really sure whether he said or not, and..." she waved her hand toward Josh, "he probably didn't, actually, because of all this stuff that happens after that. So, forget it."

Josh frowned, but Zoe was moving on. "What happened is this: he came to my work in the middle of the day on Monday. We went to a hotel - or you could say, he took me to a hotel, and things were..." she looked over at Josh, and then seemed to be unable to look him in the eye.

Her gaze cut away to the floor. "Things were... kinky. Kinkier than usual. And, um, then I went back to work. And then... see, here's the thing, I have to, like, give you details, in order for this story to make any sense. And..."

It was almost impossible to sit through this next long pause, but Josh bit his tongue. Prompting Zoe right now seemed like a terrible idea. She was so close to telling him some truth, he felt, something that would explain all of this, and if he mis-stepped, he might lose this information forever.

Zoe exhaled. She uncrossed her arms and moved her right hand lazily on the seat of the couch next to her, like she was petting a dog. She watched her own hand as she spoke. "It's just that, in order to explain what... happened, or why I did the things I did, I have to tell you some things that, uh... I guess I just prefer... I don't really want to tell you about them."

A wave of perverse pleasure traveled through Josh, and on its heels a wild jealousy. Would it do any good, he wondered, to tell Zoe that saying something like *that* only fueled his appetite?

She was still watching her hand.

"So Randy told me not to do something. After the hotel. And then... I did it. And then when I went to his house, he, uh... things got really pretty kinky. At that point. And I had all these pictures, and I was going to show you, but then... I guess, in the light of day, sober, whatever. Away from Randy. I thought about what I had done and I realized I just... couldn't. I couldn't tell you about the details."

Josh waited.

"Why not?" he asked, after another long silence.

"Why...?"

"Why not, why couldn't you tell me about them?" he said. His tone was gentle. Sure, he wanted every sordid detail of what had gone on with Randy - that was the whole point of this, wasn't it? But not if it was going to turn Zoe into this person: melancholy, angry, uncertain.

"It's just... they're..." Zoe pulled her hands beneath her thighs, wriggling to get them under her legs. She looked at the ceiling and sighed. "They're just... so... filthy. Or something. I just... I don't want to tell you how I acted. I just... can't."

Josh rubbed his forehead with the nail of his thumb.

"Okay..." he said finally. "Um... look. Look, Zoe, please listen to me." He tugged at her arms to pull her hands out from under her, and faced her, pulling her arm so she had to shift and face him on the couch. He brought her hands to his lips. "I love you, Zoe. Okay? I love you, I love that you... tried this out. And I just... I want you to know that there isn't anything you could have done, except for falling in love with Randy, that would be... like, I don't know, whatever you're afraid of or embarrassed by."

Zoe laughed out loud, unexpectedly, and it was a wet laugh that culminated in her covering her mouth with a hand she jerked away hastily

from his grip, and a tear sliding down her cheek. "Really?" she said, from behind her hand. "What if I like, fucked a donkey or something?"

Josh was jolted momentarily by a filthy part of his brain that went ahead and generated an image of that very act for him. It was revolting, and even more revoltingly, it had its own aspects of hotness.

But he figured that Zoe would not appreciate this aspect of his mind. Bingo.

"So, look," he said. "There are like... a lot of aspects of myself, and what I like, and what I fantasize about, that... you know. I wouldn't want to share with just anyone. I shared them with you, and you were just... okay with them. And then... I guess... I guess I just always thought that, you know, being able to share something like that with someone else was like... a real release. It made me feel like I could talk to you about *anything*, and I guess I just assumed that if you could do the same thing with me, then -"

"I can't, Josh. I just... I can't, that's what -"

"So, hold on, let me finish," Josh said, putting a finger to her lips. "*I* assumed, *I* did the assuming, that if you had the chance to share all these details with me and you felt like you wouldn't be judged, or you know, that you just...could... I assumed that it would be what you wanted to do. Because it would be what *I* want. You follow?"

Zoe nodded, but in that slow way that is often indicative of misunderstanding.

Josh plowed away anyhow. "What I'm saying is this, and I just got this, just now, so don't be... don't judge the, like, clumsiness of the way I say it... me telling you my fantasies and secrets was my way of showing you I loved you. Love you. And I just assumed that would be the same for you, but maybe it's not. Maybe you... maybe it's hard, but I just have to, like, accept, that it's different for you."

He squeezed her hand. "Zoe, I didn't want this to come between us. I *don't* want it to come between us. So, what I'm saying is... if you don't tell me the details, you don't want to tell me the details. Fine. Just tell me... tell me what you can. Okay? Like this. Because now the story makes sense."

Zoe was silent. He added, "And I want the details, don't get me wrong. I want you to know there's nothing you could ever do that would ever make me *love* you any less. Nothing you can really do," he added comically, "that I won't want to hear about, either."

He became serious again. "But nothing you can do to make me not love you. Angry, sure. I wouldn't stick around to be your doormat either, just for the record. But I wouldn't be able to *love* you less. You know?"

Zoe's eyes, already brimming with tears, overflowed with one blink. "Josh," she said, after pausing to pull herself together, "I don't want you to... I don't want to lie to you. I really didn't know, I didn't expect... I don't know. Whatever this is. Or was. With Randy. I didn't expect it to happen like that."

"Zoe... he didn't, like... hurt you or anything, did he?" Josh asked, a new kind of panic taking over in his chest.

Zoe expelled another bubbly, wet snort and shook her head. She rubbed her nose with the back of her hand. "That's not it. Not exactly -"

"Not exactly?" Josh interjected. "What does -"

Zoe gripped his hand now. "Not *exactly*, okay? That's the thing, the thing I don't want to explain, or go into detail about... it's like, he just got kinky, and I... I don't want that kind of thing with you, I never wanted that kind of thing with anyone, and I just... I just got some kind of, like, thrill, or kick, or whatever from it. It was like... addictive, you know? Like it just kept getting more and more dangerous, and kinky, and I just wanted to see how far I could take it or how far it would go. Or I *wasn't* thinking. I don't know..."

"I mean, Zoe, listen... this is where I am. If this is, like... something you need, or you want, you want something kinky, and you don't want it with me, then I can, we can talk about it. I just want you to *tell* me, this is what you want, and not be... hiding it from me."

Zoe was shaking her head again.

"I just want you to have what you want, and if this is what you want... I don't *love* it that you can't share it with me, but if you can just be honest, then, you know, I can... figure out a way to accept it. I guess. Is what I'm saying."

"No," Zoe was saying almost before he was finished. "No, see, that's not... it's not the kink, it's not... it's something else. Fuck, how do I explain this? I get home and I wish I didn't have to tell you about it, I wish I hadn't done it, and I think, I just need to... and this is why I got so mad, Tuesday, because I wanted to say all of this and tell you I was breaking things off with him and tell you why, and then you came home late or just... couldn't get here for *that*, but you could always get here for something else, so I got

mad and I went out and I fully intended to just... find some guy and fuck him, but then, I realized I didn't want to. That isn't what this about -"

"Okay, okay look," Josh interrupted. "I think I get it, you're mad because I don't have enough time for you? Is that it?"

Zoe groaned. She shook her head again. "No, see, that's... it's *not* that. I thought it was that, I thought that was what I was doing. I really did. I even had that thought aloud in my own head: 'I'm doing this to grab Josh's attention.' And I really thought that was the thing. But it... I think..." Zoe's eyes lit up like she was just figuring out a problem. "It... isn't about...sex, or even this particular kind of sex, or not loving you or needing something else, or even getting your attention.

"All that was just stuff I was... telling myself. Because I didn't want to face what it was, or tell you what it was, and so I was covering it all up under all this... I don't know, psycho-babble. And stupid Randy, because he's a fucking shrink..." She turned to face Josh, a certain meanness in her eyes that for a moment Josh felt was directed at him.

"*He* knew what it was, and he pressed all the right buttons, and he's just trying to get what he wants, which frankly, now that I really give it some thought, is something pretty fucked up. And I spent all this time telling myself he was just manipulating me, he was just such a like, alpha male, that I was under his spell, and then I told myself I was just doing it for your attention... but that's not what it is." She gripped his hands with a smile developing on her downturned mouth. It faded to a serious, half-frown, but the smile had been there, Josh was sure of it.

"It's about *me*, and how..." Her voice trailed off, and her eyes moved over Josh's lap while she clearly wasn't looking at *him*, but instead at some corner of her own mind, overturning furniture to find the right words.

"It's about... me. Me doing something dangerous. For once. Instead of just... working in an insurance company and signing papers and wearing these fucking... knee-length skirts and flat fucking shoes. It's about being up late, having a hangover, being irresponsible, sneaking around, feeling... you know, more like the person I used to be. The kind of person who did something wild every weekend."

Josh stared at her. She looked up at him with wet eyes.

"So you... need to have more adventure...? Is that it?"

"No," she said, as if she had just opened a box and seen its contents. She was pleased. "That's just it. No, I don't *want* that. I just wanted the thrill. What's more insane than fucking your ex-boyfriend's dad? And if he turns out to be the kind of person who will pick you up from work and screw you in a hotel and make you late coming back, and the kind of person you have to lie to your husband about, then it's all the more dangerous. But... it's... like, the thing I realized, Tuesday, is that I just wanted to do something I *wasn't supposed to be doing*. Something irresponsible. I just liked the... taste of it. Dancing, in a tube top, and flirting with people, and being out late drunk. It was fun. But I don't actually want to *change* my life."

Josh leaned back on the couch. It was his turn to look at the wall.

"So... do you want to... I don't know, what are you saying? If you want to keep seeing him, if you need to keep seeing him, Zoe, I can deal with it, I guess... I mean -"

"That's just it. That's just the thing. Now that I get it, like *why* I was doing it, I don't... actually want to do it anymore." She moved on the couch to face him and put a hand on his far cheek to turn his head gently toward her. "That's what I want to explain. I *don't* want that anymore. It just... got to be too much. It was less like an adventure and more like a... I don't know, a suicide mission. You know. Like climbing Everest in a bikini or something."

Josh smiled, in spite of himself.

"I don't want any of this stuff enough to wreck our marriage over it, I guess, is what I'm saying."

Josh swallowed away a lump in his throat. In truth, his heart was soaring now, even if he was almost unable to believe what he was hearing. "A thrill too far," he quipped.

Zoe collapsed on the couch.

"Definitely."

CHAPTER 13

Some time later

"...and then I was thinking we could drive along the coast, stop by your friends' place -"

"Oh my God," Zoe said quietly, stonily, her voice cutting through the cheerful smile she had been wearing, turning her features rigid.

"Keep talking," she said, smiling even more creepily. She put her hand on his and stroked the back of it. Leaning against the palm of her other hand, she let her hair fall over the right side of her face. "*Don't*," she added, "look around."

"So keep talking," Josh said, adopting the same rigid smile as his wife, "about what? What was I talking about? And why is it you don't want me to look around?"

But he knew. He knew without confirming it, without looking around: the change in Zoe's demeanor, the electricity that was moving through her, the blush on her cheeks - they all announced the presence of Randy.

His stomach felt cold and began its free-falling, wild spinning again. Zoe's fingers continued to move over his hand, and it was as though her fingertips were connected through his body directly to his cock. His dick was throbbing rapidly to life, pulsing with the excitement that seemed to have poured through Zoe as well.

"Keep talking," Zoe purred. "I just spotted Randy and I want to pretend we haven't seen him."

"I can't think of anything to say," Josh said helplessly. "Just smile like we're having a moment."

Zoe smiled, and rolled her eyes.

Randy had been out of their lives for months now. Sometimes, late at night, Josh wondered if he was being taken in by his wife, if she actually still met Randy secretly, or if she told him everything about Randy's attempts to contact her.

But this moment seemed to dismiss all of his lingering doubts: if Zoe was seeing Randy behind his back, why would she point out that he was here?

It was a late Tuesday night at a place called The Hub: the bar was not very crowded, but there was a live band playing loudly on the stage and most of the patrons were drunk enough to be yelling. Josh leaned back, his eyes still on Zoe. "Where is he?" he asked.

"I just got a text," Zoe said. "I felt it in my purse."

Her cheeks were getting flushed. "It's probably from him."

Josh tapped his finger on the table and looked at his hand. "Are you going to check it?"

Zoe bit her lip.

They stared at each other. Josh was wildly turned on, and he knew what he was about to do and say were reckless things: after all, they had just worked through this. Randy was out of their lives: Zoe had come back to him, and she was his.

There was no good reason to do anything... risky.

"You know," he said, almost disbelieving his own voice, "and this is just... not anything, in particular. But... Randy thinks I don't know about him, right?"

Zoe's eyes glistened and she chewed on her lip. A smile developed, and she began to move the foot of her crossed leg in circles. "Right," she said.

"That's true, right? You didn't..."

"Josh!" She said angrily, but stopped herself, and composed her tone. "It's true. I promise."

"So... I could go up to the bar, right? And get us some drinks? And you could check your phone? And if he's watching, that would look... natural, I'm guessing. To him."

Zoe put her thumb against her lip. Her foot was moving rapidly now. "Mmm," she said. Then she shrugged. "If it's even him. The text, I mean."

"If it is."

Her foot moved under the table, and her whole body jiggled a little with it. There was a moment of tense excitement between them. "And *if* it is?"

Josh took a deep breath. "If it is..." he said.

Their eyes were locked. Zoe smiled.

Then she looked at their hands, dropping her right hand to pile onto Josh's. "Josh, if you're saying what... you know. I think you're saying... um... I don't know what to do."

She lifted her eyes to meet his.

"We just got out of that mess," she continued.

"I know," Josh answered.

Another lengthy pause lingered between them, the air almost crackling with the sexual energy.

"Tell me what you're thinking," Zoe said, in a low voice, leaning forward.

Josh picked her right hand up in his left and brought her fingers to his mouth. He was pleased by the ripple of goosebumps that traveled over her forearm as he breathed onto her bent fingers, with his lips close to her skin: "I'm thinking..."

Zoe's lips quivered with a mischievous excitement. Josh's cock pulsed, incredibly hard against his pants. "I'm thinking... it's going to be really hard to walk over there and get a beer."

They stared at each other for a moment. The tightness Josh had become so used to - and so afraid of, really, just months before - returned to grip him. But now it felt more like excitement, like the grip of a fear he was about to face.

But on purpose, because he wanted the thrill of it.

He recognized, in Zoe's face, the same expression he had seen on her face just before she did something wild. It lit her up from behind her skin, and her eyes had a glimmer in them, narrowed slightly, pupils wide. It was something he hadn't seen in her for a long time.

She put her hand up to her neck and rubbed it slightly, tipping her head to hide her face from the right side of her with her hair. "Maybe this isn't a good idea," she said, but not like she really believed it.

"Tell you what," Josh said, slamming the rest of his beer. "Check your message."

He stood up, glancing down at the state of his erection. Luckily his jeans were tight against his crotch, and he hoped it wasn't overly obvious that he had an erection. Satisfied with the assessment, drunk on two beers and the excitement of the situation, he decided it didn't pose a problem. He edged along the row of booths where they were seated, behind chairs left scattered haphazardly next to tables that patrons had abandoned, to the bar.

He could see Randy now, in the periphery of his left eye. Recognizing his form - the salt-and-pepper hair, the smug contours of his profile, the taut

muscle beneath his shirt - gave him a jolt. His abdomen rippled, almost like a reflex. He set himself on the edge of a bar chair and leaned on the counter, willing himself to look at the wall of liquor as if he were studying it.

Zoe was behind him, and he didn't dare turn around to see what she was doing, but his spine tingled as if she were raking her fingernails over his skin. Randy was sipping a drink calmly, confidently.

The bartender was in front of him now, asking him what he wanted, and he started asking questions about the beers, not even listening to himself or the bartender's answers. All he could focus on was Randy, how nothing seemed to be transpiring.

Maybe that was for the best. It was the most sensible thing, now that they'd gotten through that chapter of their lives, to leave it all behind. He'd had his fantasy, and so had Zoe, and she had been content to leave it behind. He ordered, telling himself it was all for the best, but he could feel the drop in his chest, the sting of disappointment, as the bartender turned to pour the drinks.

He took them, left a whole twenty on the counter, and turned away from Randy to head back to the table. Zoe was sitting erect in her seat, looking straight ahead.

As he passed her, and his body was between her and Randy, she said: "Act normal. It was him. I wrote him back."

Act normal. What did that mean?

Josh set the beers down and slid into his side of the booth. He pushed Zoe's beer toward her. She took it, and their fingers met around the glass. "Thank you," she said, and pulled it to her side of the table. She tucked her hair behind her ear and put her hands in her lap. "I'm waiting for him to write back," she said, and then leaned on her hand again. "So, don't act weird or anything."

Josh took a sip of his beer. "So, what do I do?"

Zoe smiled. "I'm going to go to the bathroom," she said.

The arousal hit him squarely, a wave of erotic heat, and jealousy, and dangerous thrill. His beer shook in his hand. Zoe looked down at the beer, alarmed. She had her hand close to her mouth, blocking it. "Only if you want me to," she said.

He realized he was breathing much more quickly than normal. His heart was pounding so heavily in his chest he could feel each roaring pulse.

They met each other's eyes for a long moment, scorching the air between them.

Josh put his fist to his mouth, leaning his chin on the meat of his palm. He raised his eyebrows. "What did his text say?"

Zoe rolled her eyes. "I'm here."

Josh had to laugh. This guy.

"And what did you say?"

Zoe put a finger on the edge of her beer glass, and seductively ran her fingertip over the rim, scooping up a tiny bit of foam. She put her finger in her mouth and sucked the foam onto her lip, where it lingered for a moment, the color of cum, before her pink tongue emerged and swept it away. "I see that."

It wasn't clear who she was running her finger through the foam of her beer for, and Josh realized that he would have to accept that maybe it wasn't all for him.

But some of it was. Zoe's eyes were on *him*, the plan was between him and her, she was waiting for him to give her the go-ahead.

She lifted her finger to her mouth again and sucked another bit of foam into her mouth. Josh's cock pulsed painfully. "Want to see what happens?" she asked.

He did. He wanted to see what happened. He knew it was reckless, stupid, and crazy, but he very much did. The Zoe in front of him was the Zoe he had married - she was daring, reckless, out for extreme thrills. And she was also a woman he hadn't known - this was the part of her that was dangerous. This was the Zoe who got something from Randy that she couldn't tell him about in full, the Zoe who did such unspeakably filthy things with him that she had to keep some of it a secret.

Was she on his side? Or Randy's side?

Zoe grinned and tapped the side of her glass, slowly, sexily.

"It's dangerous," Josh commented.

"Yep," Zoe said. She looked at her finger as she swept up a morsel of cum-colored foam. "You'll just have to trust me."

The world whirled around him for a moment. And then Josh turned sideways, leaning on the table and looking at the stage, as if he had waited all his life to hear this band. Randy was now in the periphery of his right side, and he could see him looking over at their table now, leaning on the

bar, sipping his own drink with a predatory gaze that Josh could feel, even without seeing clearly.

Zoe dropped her hand to her purse. "I have to run to the bathroom," she half-yelled.

Josh pretended to be caught up in the music, nodding carelessly. Zoe's foot rubbed against his outside calf, and then she scooted from the booth.

To his left, she disappeared from his vision, sauntering toward the restrooms.

Josh stared at the stage.

Randy rose from his chair, leaned in to say something to the bartender, and then crossed the bar - right in front of Josh, arrogantly enough to look over at him - and disappeared, like Zoe, to Josh's left.

CHAPTER 14

Once in the hallway with bathrooms, Zoe had no idea what to do, or where to go. The ladies' room was the kind of bathroom that had more than one stall, ditto for the guys', and she wasn't even sure what Randy would do.

So she stood by a large window at the end of the hall, near a stairwell that went into the basement, out of which she could hear clanging pots and pans, and looked at her phone.

I'm here.

So am I.

What would he say? Things had ended with him, without so much as a text of closure. To be truthful with herself, she had been grateful for that, in a way. After her long talk with Josh, she had known it was the right thing to do.

But a part of her pride had been wounded. She wasn't sure what she would have done if he had messaged or called her. Josh had given her permission to pursue her fantasy, and her needs, and only tell him what she wanted to. Once she had the green light, though, it hadn't appealed to her nearly as much.

But Randy had never called, and that had, truthfully, *infuriated her*. Maybe he knew that, maybe he knew that it would. Maybe this was all part of some evil plan. Because if there was one thing Randy was obviously good at, it was manipulating things in his favor.

So, what was he doing here? What was he going to say? What was *she* going to do?

She kept her eyes on her phone when his figure entered the hallway. Sensing it was childish, like some middle-school girl trying to pretend she didn't have a crush on some boy, she looked up. After all, she was standing here waiting for him.

If anything had occurred to her to say to him, it flew from her mind when she looked at his face. Very suddenly, the level of danger she was standing at the precipice of became clear to her. Not seeing Randy for months, she had begun to tell herself that she was more in control of things than she was. And in a way, it was true: she had the willpower to ditch him, not to call him, the sense to stay away from the danger that he represented.

But now, with his dark navy eyes on hers, and the inventive twist of his mind carved into his mouth, the stubble of his jaw nearing her skin and already making goosebumps rise as if he had brushed against her inner thigh, she realized that she was not the one in control. At all.

She let her phone fall into her purse. Her mouth was slightly open, and she knew that a pulse of fear was glinting in her eyes. His eyes were on her chest, on the artery that pulsed wildly near her collarbone, an almost vampiric hunger in them.

She looked quickly behind him, over his shoulder, but her eyes were drawn back to his by the slow, methodical shake of his head.

"Josh is right out -"

"I saw him."

She was spinning immediately after that, his hand on her neck, his other hand somewhere else, moving her in a pirouette, her feet losing their connection with the ground, then stumbling as her back scraped against a rough brick wall. His mouth was on hers, his body pressed against her. They were on the stairs, a few steps down, but his lips were against her and she couldn't move or fall.

She felt his fingers bunching the woolen fabric of her skirt, then against her thigh, moving up to her hip, the fabric of her skirt bunching at her waist. Below them, dishes clattered, and somewhere, deeply buried in her mind, she registered that she should be worried about the kitchen...

But that faded or was drowned out. Randy's fingers ripped through her leggings, found their way beneath her panties. She felt the smile of his mouth as his knuckles grazed their sopping wetness, and then he was inside of her. His fingers went deep, curled outward, and he ground against her body.

It took mere moments to bring her screaming to the edge of orgasm, and her vision began to blur and turn starry as the blood rushed to her ears and pounded. His teeth sank into her lower lip, and his eyes met hers. She was so close, her abdomen started to spasm, and she pushed against his fingers and his body, her fingers clawing at his shoulders.

His fingers left her body, and he smiled, running his tongue over her top lip.

He smiled at her, then leaned in, and whispered next to her ear. "I wouldn't want to get you in trouble."

His fingers, so tantalizingly close to bringing her to orgasm, slipped from inside of her. His eyes were locked on hers until, as if he had never been there, he was gone.

Zoe's knees gave in, and she looked down to find herself standing precariously on two different steps. A second of terrifying vertigo gripped her, and she sank to the floor, sitting for a moment before realizing that she hadn't breathed in many, long seconds. Her first exhale sounded like she was emerging from beneath the water.

A loud crash and a slew of curse words from below startled her, and she stood up rapidly. Her limbs and her body seemed unable to coordinate as she scurried to the top of the steps and down the hall. Halfway past the bathrooms she realized there was no way the food would be brought up this way, it must have been an emergency exit for the kitchen. She tugged her skirt into place and walked out anyway, eyes scanning the room for Randy, then for Josh.

Randy was seated at the bar, sitting casually as if nothing had transpired at all in the bathroom hallway. She could see the back of Josh's head. A wild current of guilt and fear rippled through her, even though she reminded herself that she had, specifically, obtained Josh's permission for what had just occurred.

The effect was exhilarating anyway. She wriggled into her seat, with her back to Randy now, and gave Josh a hard stare. Her forehead was damp when she brushed her hair from her face.

Josh looked down at his beer and lifted it casually. As he brought the glass to his lips, he asked, in a low voice. "What happened?"

Zoe brought her hand to the side of her face and drew a finger over her lips. Her lipstick was removed, she could feel the rubbery bareness of her lips. Josh was staring at them, and she saw the tightening of his jaw, the flinch of pleasure in his muscles. "Later," she mouthed.

She felt the vibration of her phone, could feel the shape of Randy's body at the bar, in her distant peripheral vision. She was sure he was holding his phone, sure he was messaging her.

"You ready to go?" Josh asked, a little loudly.

Zoe glanced at her drink, which was still full, and then nodded.

She wasn't sure how they left. When did Josh pay the bill? How had she walked out of the bar? It was unknown, a blur, all of her thoughts and

feelings centered in a few places, a collage of fragmented moments: Randy's lips, his breath on her ear, the stairs, his fingers in her pussy, the throb that remained inside of her, the buzz of her phone, the door opening and she and Josh walking away from the bar as though stunned, turning the corner, looking at each other, and then walking home, hand in hand, almost running.

*

Zoe had the look of a woman who had been fucked when she sat down across from him. Her eyes were glassy, her pupils black and large, eclipsing her irises. The light-colored gloss she had been wearing was gone, a smear of its pinkish sheen just above her upper lip, fattening the corner of her mouth. The rest of her lips were matte-pink, blood pulsing wildly at the stimulated surface. Her hair was not disordered, but he could see that it was just slightly damp at the roots. If he touched her neck, he would find a sheen of hot sweat there.

But there hadn't been enough time for that, certainly not by Randy's athletic and almost inspirational standards, unless the man was as adept at fucking quickly as he was fucking for hours.

Zoe was almost disoriented, walking in a daze from the restaurant. They passed Randy, who sat coolly at the bar, and she looked straight ahead. It was a good enough acting job that Josh could almost imagine an alternate universe, one in which he *didn't* know that Zoe was sleeping with Randy, in which he wondered briefly about her lipstick - or perhaps not, did men always pay this much attention to their wives? - and left the bar, clueless to her transgressions.

When they turned the corner at the end of the block, Zoe had looked behind her, as if she expected Randy to be following them. Then she had grabbed his hand and quickened her step.

They said nothing, hurrying home and plowing into the house, his lips on hers as soon as they stepped through the door. It clanged shut when he kicked it with his foot but bounced back with a crunch, the deadbolt turned to closed again by his eager, fast-moving, unthinking fingers.

"What happened?" he asked her, between violent kisses, as they peeled their clothing away from their bodies in a frenzy of sleeves being shaken from hands, lips and tongues crashing against each other, and stumbling steps. "You didn't fuck him, did you?"

Zoe's mouth tasted different, he was sure of it. She hadn't even taken a sip of beer. Just minutes before, Randy had almost certainly put something in it - his tongue, maybe even his cock. The image of her lips stretched wide for Randy's sizable dick flashed through his mind, and his own cock throbbed painfully. Zoe had already freed him from his jeans, which were sliding down his thighs, and her hands were dipping into his boxers, grasping his cock. "We didn't fuck," she panted. "He finger-fucked me, he got me so close, and then he left."

Josh was taken aback for a moment, He had Zoe pushed against a wall, and he leaned away to look at her face. "He left?" he asked disbelievably.

Zoe looked at him, and he could see she was telling the truth. She leaned close to his ear. "He leaned in like this, and he did this," she curled her fingers beneath his balls, pushing the pads against his taint and making him shudder, "and then he said, 'I wouldn't want to get you in trouble,' and he left. Just. Before. He made me come."

Zoe had moved her head back along his jawline, her lips were now close to his. She grasped his hand and pushed it into her panties, her skirt now sliding down her legs like his jeans. She had turned his palm toward her body, and his middle finger slid quickly into her wet and buttery folds. Her flesh was soaked, her temperature hot. Whatever Randy had done, she was wet and ready to go. When his fingers slipped into her pussy, she mewled and ground against him. "I was *so* close," she whined.

"Did you want him to fuck you?" Josh breathed, pushing his jeans and boxers away with his free hand. He curled his fingers toward the root of her clit and her eyes fluttered closed. Around his fingers he could feel her pussy quivering, spasming, and for a moment he thought she was coming. But it was just her hunger, sucking at his fingers like a wet, toothless mouth.

"Did you?" he asked, when she didn't answer. He pushed her legs apart, and she helped him, her hand guiding his cock to her hole as she lifted a leg and hooked it on his lower back. "Say it, Zoe."

Her eyes opened and she met his. "I wanted him to fuck me," she said. "Please, Josh."

She squeezed his cock, and he pushed himself toward her pussy, sliding his fingers from inside her to stuff his dick into her slick flesh. She bounced a little, and he pushed in deep, pushing her against the wall and

grabbing her ass to get leverage enough to pick up her other thigh and sink his dick deep into her.

But once inside, he stopped, and Zoe howled, squirming against him. She tipped her head back and closed her eyes, digging her heels into his lower back, rolling her hips to try and wring an orgasm from him. "Josh," she whispered. "Please, I'm so close."

He stared at her face as she writhed between him and the wall, sweat gathering at her temples and her neck, her breath becoming ragged. It was the kind of unbridled need he rarely felt in Zoe, and he wanted to cherish it a few more moments. Her pussy squeezed him, and her ankles dug into him, and from her throat came a warbled mewl of need.

He let her work herself up to her own orgasm, without moving himself, for as long as it took. When she came, her body went rigid, and her eyes flew open wide, she ceased breathing and made no sound.

And then, only then, after her body relaxed, did he hammer his cum into her drenched pussy, while her heels bounced on his ass, tethered to her legs, which had gone limp. Each thrust squeezed a whimper from her throat, but she held his gaze until he exploded inside of her.

Zoe's feet dropped to the floor, and she shook a little, as if her feet had fallen asleep. Their foreheads were touching, and they were panting. His cock slipped from her pussy with a slosh.

"Fuck," Josh said. "That was hot, Zoe."

She smiled, but he could see a flicker of worry in her eyes.

"I mean it," he said, pulling her by her neck toward him to kiss her. "It was hot."

They looked at each other for a while.

"Oh," Zoe said. "I almost forgot. I think he sent me a text."

CHAPTER 15

I've been a bad boy.

"You're sure that's his?" Josh said, finally.

Zoe looked at him sharply. They were lying on their stomachs on the bed, Zoe holding the phone between them. "Of course that's..." she said. She pointed at the phone with her chin. "That's the same number he sent the other one from."

"Right," Josh said, rubbing his chin on his forearm. "So, what does that mean?"

Zoe let the phone tip away from her hand and tipped her head into her palm to prop it up. They had read the message for the first time almost an hour ago, but that had ended in them having another wild romp upstairs, and now they were finally analyzing it.

"He's just being his usual manipulative self," Zoe said, after a pause. She narrowed her eyes and looked at Josh. "I shouldn't fall for it. Or... bite, or whatever."

Josh picked up the phone and looked at it. "Is this the stuff you can't tell me about?" he asked. "That Randy, like, outsmarted you or something?"

He knew Zoe hated that sort of thing.

Zoe collapsed face-first into the pillow and piled her arms over her head. "Gah!" she said. She shook her head. Then she lifted it again. "I just *told* you about this, dummy."

"So not this. This isn't what you wanted to keep under wraps."

"Not...? No. Not this. This is like... child's play."

Josh, in spite of their stunning double-hitter, which he was very proud of himself for batting through *without* Randy's Viagra crutch, felt his cock thicken. "Come on," he said, almost unable to believe that there was something *more*, something even further than what he was looking at on the screen right now, or had seen for himself that long-ago weekend Randy had spent with his wife.

Zoe flipped onto her back. "Josh," she said, exasperated. "We've been over this. I literally *can't* give you the details. I'm sorry. I just... I'm too, like... I can't believe the way this guy makes me act."

"But you like it," Josh prodded.

Zoe put her hand to her face. "That's the part that, like... I *do*, but I don't want *you* to like... *judge* me for it."

"I wouldn't," Josh said too quickly. He held his hands up. "I wouldn't," he repeated firmly, "and you can trust me when I tell you that, but we had a deal."

Zoe turned her face to look at him. She looked grateful.

There was nothing, nothing he could think of in the world that he would more *like* to get his hands on than the vivid, visceral, filthy details of whatever Randy did with Zoe... except, of course, Zoe's love for him.

He blinked, having finally distilled his feelings into an intelligible statement.

"What?" Zoe said, smiling.

He put his hand to her face. "I just got it," he said.

"What?"

He kissed her. "There's only one thing I want more than to know what you did with Randy," he said.

Zoe stared at him.

"It's going to be cheesy," he warned her.

Zoe's face grew serious. "I love cheese," she said quietly.

"You don't."

She smiled. "Maybe in certain cases."

"Okay. So... it's more important to me that... well, you're more important to me. Basically. That you're happy. So... if it makes you unhappy to tell me that stuff, then... I guess... *don't*." He kissed her. "I trust you."

Zoe put her fingers in his hair. Her eyes were wet. "I don't mean to be this kind of person."

"I like who you are," Josh said. He kissed her again. "Just... don't expect me to totally give up trying."

Zoe giggled, shaking her head at the same time.

"Now," Josh said. "The question. Do we take Randy's shameless bait? Or not?" He rolled back onto his stomach and looked at the phone.

Zoe propped her head up in her hand again. With her free hand she stroked Josh's back. "I don't know," she said, and it sounded like she really didn't.

"Then just... ignore him." Josh tossed the phone toward the headboard. "Maybe he's stalking you and he'll just turn up at random restaurants."

Zoe scrunched up her nose. "That isn't his style."

"Oh, no?" Josh said.

She shook her head and bit her lower lip.

"Do you *want* to take the bait?"

She bounced her head against her palm a few times. Then she laughed and rubbed her forehead. "I actually, just literally... I *have* taken the bait. I want to know what the hell he's going to say. You know? Just purely out of curiosity."

Josh shrugged and flipped onto his back, phone in hand.

"Are you - what are you typing?"

"Just nibbling. It doesn't mean you have to get reeled in," he said, his thumbs moving.

"Josh..." Zoe said uncertainly, but she folded her arms on the pillow and faced the headboard. "What are you writing?" she asked. "That's like, novel-length."

"I deleted and retyped. This is the first flirtatious message I've sent in like ten years," he said. "And it's to a man."

Zoe smiled and craned her head to see. Then she flipped around.

I'll bite.

"That's it?" she laughed.

"It's mysterious," Josh said, in a faux-feminine voice. His thumb hovered over the send button. "I'd dig it," he assured her.

"Yeah," Zoe agreed. "Yeah, it's good. Fine, send it." She studied Josh's face for a moment. "*Just* out of curiosity."

*

"I thought you said -"

"I did," Zoe pushed herself up on her knees. She had become steely and serious in a flash, and now her face was pale with anger. She ran her hand through her hair, staring at the phone. "I *did*. I said that I deleted it and I *did* delete it."

There was a sharp staccato, and embedded fury, and a tiny bit of controlled panic in her voice. Josh wasn't sure what to say. He was still holding the phone in two hands, as one would do to show someone a funny video. He turned it off and placed it face-down on the bed, suddenly aware of how ridiculous he looked.

Zoe's hand was still at the back of her head, holding her hair. Her eyes moved quickly from side to side, as she calculated the implications of Randy's text.

"Give me that," she said, holding her hand out.

"Maybe it isn't the same photo," Josh said. He was thinking aloud more than anything. Zoe shot him a look and stared at the screen. "You said you didn't do that with him, though, tonight -"

"I didn't. This is the photo. This is... *Christ* Josh, I would know if someone took a fucking photo of me with his dick in my mouth more than once!"

Josh sat up and pulled her hands toward him. "I know, Zoe, I'm - look, that just came out, I didn't mean it."

Zoe looked at him. He rarely saw anything like what he saw in them now: a raw panic, a feeling that Zoe rarely experienced, and, as far as he knew, had only shown once in her life, when a friend had careened off the edge of a cliff skiing, followed by a sickening crack. The panic had flitted through her features, and then she had blinked it away to go check on him.

But this, this was a lingering panic.

"What do I do?" she asked. "He... I took them off his phone, I deleted them, I deleted the sent messages. I don't..." Her voice evaporated in a gasp of helplessness.

Josh, of course, had already thought through the answer, but he wasn't about to open his mouth and explain it to Zoe at a moment like this. Randy was old, but he was tech-savvy, and he probably just backed everything up from his phone on another server. Josh did it himself. Zoe had spurned his suggestions to do the same, rolling her eyes and saying she didn't care about anything that much.

He took the phone from her hand and deleted the text. "Okay," he said. "Well... we have to find out what he wants by sending this photo."

Zoe looked at the phone in his hand. She shook her head. "No way. I'm done. This is... this is too far."

"Right, but... you want to be sure that this doesn't... I don't know, get out."

She was calculating, quietly, for several moments. "Maybe he just plans to send it to you," she said. She looked at Josh hopefully. "Right? Maybe he thinks he can get me back at his place if he threatens to send it

to... you..." She stopped talking, as if she were just tired of it. "But I would have to find out," she said simply.

She looked up at Josh. "What should I do?"

Josh crossed his ankles and sat back against the headboard, his elbows hooked around his knees, phone in his hands. He stared at the text messages between the number and his wife, the picture deleted, Randy still not added to the phone.

The picture Randy had sent was seared in his mind, Zoe's nostrils flared and her watering eyes locked on the face behind the phone, Randy's gnarled, fat cock stretching her lips to a barely discernible pink outline around the spit-soaked meat between them.

Josh's mind - many people would be surprised to find out, given his creative-class status - worked linearly, in flow-charts that led him to quick decisions, if he needed to make them.

"Look. Randy's a professional. He's not going to do anything stupid and ruin his career by posting this somewhere... especially when you have all this proof that he sent..." Josh's voice trailed off. He had deleted the photo.

But surely Randy wouldn't assume that.

Zoe was quiet.

"Come on, Zoe, think about it. He's got a career. He wouldn't risk ruining it by doing something with this photo, other than sending it to me."

Zoe was staring at the mattress blankly. She shook her head so slowly that at first Josh didn't see it.

"He might," she said quietly. Then she lifted her eyes. "There's something I didn't tell you."

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Zoe's confession began with the recounting of the whispered "I love you" she hadn't fully trusted to be real. She had a lengthy explanation of why she had decided not to mention it to Josh: her lack of surety about it, the complications it would entail, the fact that it was easier to just pretend it hadn't happened.

From there, the threads of Zoe's secrecy unraveled, and she told a sordid tale of the things Randy had made her say, and the reasons she had said them.

It was a long, erotic story of manipulation and dark desires, and by the end Josh was both highly aroused and highly disturbed, because the picture that Zoe painted was clear - if not to her, then at least to him: Randy was a man *obsessed* with Zoe.

Darkly, sexually, obsessed, and the obsession seemed lengthy and profound.

"I just need to understand something," Josh said, when she had finished. "Why -"

"Did I go along with it?" Zoe asked miserably. She shrugged. "It just... sort of happened. One shade darker at a time -" she lifted her eyes sharply. "That wasn't supposed to be punny," she explained.

No pun even occurred to him. He tipped his head a little in confusion.

"Like *'Fifty Shades'...*" Zoe groaned. "Never mind."

But Josh was already thinking about something else. "You don't feel anything like this for him -"

"I don't. I told you I don't. That's true."

Josh blinked slowly.

Somewhere inside of himself, in spite of himself, he felt a little badly for *Randy*. After all, he knew what it was like to be obsessed with Zoe. He knew what it was like to have dark fantasies, to need something from a woman so badly that you did questionable things. He knew what it was like to *love* Zoe, and he knew at least the contours of the pain of thinking she didn't love you back.

"I think we have to find out what he wants by sending this," Josh said, looking at Zoe. "After that, it'll be easier to figure out what to do."

He knew this was silly: there was really only one thing Randy wanted from sending this picture, and that was to fill Josh's wife up with load after load of cum, and get her to say that she wanted his cock, fulfilling what had obviously been his darkest desire for years. Maybe he even did love her, or maybe he had only said it in the dark after fucking her so much and it had meant something else.

But it was pretty clear that there was a statistically significant chance that Randy *was* the kind of man to do something very, very stupid and career-risking to get what he wanted. It might have been slim, it might have been large, but it was definitely there.

"I wish I hadn't done this," Zoe said, in a whisper.

Josh moved closer to her and pulled her to him. "We'll find a way to fix this," he said. "At the very least we'll find a way to take care of... this." He waved the phone.

Zoe was still staring blankly at the sheets.

"Hey," he said, putting a finger under her chin. "I know this is fucked up, but some good things have come out of it. At least I feel that way."

Zoe smiled. It was a small smile, but real.

"Okay," Josh said, falling back toward the headboard holding the phone. "How to deal with the evil villain and save the girl."

He looked over the top of the phone.

Zoe was looking at him gratefully.

CHAPTER 16

"What are you feeling?"

Zoe was placing the lacy edge of her thigh-high hose carefully at her upper-thigh, straightening the thick band of black lace, watching her fingers. She shrugged her shoulders, her lips in a beautiful pout. "I'm feeling... sort of bad, kind of."

"For Randy?"

She said nothing, just looked at him, and shrugged again.

"Do you feel like you're being manipulative?" Josh asked.

"I *am* being manipulative," Zoe said, tilting her head slightly, a sexy purr in her voice. It was a difficult comment to read.

Josh narrowed his eyes and turned her phone toward her, waving it.

"Don't forget who the real manipulator is here," he said.

Zoe dropped her foot from the bed. She was encased in black lingerie, which they had picked out together, for this, what was hopefully the final touch on their adventure with Randy. The underwear were a delicate, transparent material, scandalous threads of black rosettes framing her pussy, the scanty material resting on her hips, the cut a very short boy-short style. The transparent silk disappeared, in the back, between her buttocks, leaving the curve of her ass hanging from the delicate shape of the material. Her nipples were hard and visible beneath the transparent black of the matching bra, her white skin pouring from the lace-edged cups. Matching black lace trimmed her neutral-toned thigh-highs.

"You're right," she said.

"Zoe," Josh said, "If you don't want to do this... we can think of something else."

She gave her hair a toss and looked at him without saying anything.

"Are you going to be okay?" Josh asked.

There was still a certain amount of putting things on the line here, just enough to make Josh's insides swirl and his blood pressure rise when he thought of what they were about to do. He trusted Zoe now, he really did - but Randy was not a fumbling, bumbling idiot. Zoe could have all the intentions in the world to turn the tables on Randy, but that didn't mean she'd be able to.

But he saw in Zoe a hardening of spirit, a look he had seen before and found almost intimidating. It was the expression Zoe wore when she was about to do something dangerous, and Josh had long since learned that Zoe only got this look when she knew could handle it.

If she had gotten in too deep with Randy, they had found a way to get out.

At least, he hoped so. His chest began to feel tight again, and he imagined what would ensue between Randy and his wife tonight. After all, it was their intention to lure Randy into being at his most depraved, because that was the only way out.

It was *their* idea, but Zoe's to execute.

The problem, of course, was that Zoe was not a psychiatrist, and Randy was. She was also not naturally a manipulative person. Josh had a sinking feeling, which he tried to dismiss as quickly as possible, when he thought about the task ahead of her.

She met his eyes. "Hey," she said. "Don't go doubting me *now*."

And in that moment, he could see that she *did* have it. He put his hands on her shoulders. "I don't. I won't," he said. "You got this."

CHAPTER 17

"That's some dress."

It was the first thing Randy said to her, and inside her chest a little flame of victory flared. Randy's smug grin barely surfaced on his lips, but his self-assurance flashed in his eyes. Which is what she had wanted, because Randy, like a lot of men, was at his least perceptive when he became full of himself.

And the last thing she needed, if this plan was to work, was for Randy to be perceptive.

She slid into the booth across from him, a mingle of feelings passing through her like a vapor just before she steeled herself against them. Guilt, cool and exasperating - guilt for manipulating another person, a sort of pity for men that she suspected all women (except maybe Alicia) held somewhere in their softer, nurturing natures. Guilt for feeling as aroused as she did, because it seemed a little like a kind of betrayal, to both Josh and feminism in general. Arousal, hot and damp, was the feeling that lingered longest.

And then, flickering, growing like a phosphoric flare to a steady, bright flame: Zoe's love of a challenge, and danger.

"I'm on my way to something," she said quietly. She looked down at the table, and then met Randy's eyes. "It's insurance. You might say."

Randy cocked an eyebrow. "Insurance against what?" he asked, and the question was rhetorical, but Zoe answered it anyway.

"This is a dinner, that's all. I made that clear. It's insurance against doing something... I shouldn't."

Randy took a sip of his whiskey without taking his eyes off her.

Zoe looked away, which was part of the act, but also something she was happy to do, because Randy's intense stare was melting right through her. Her insides wobbled a little: this wasn't an easy task, because the truth was that she *liked* Randy's dominance, and she would have to keep her wits about her - pretending to give into it without really giving into it, not fully.

She folded her arms over themselves and cleared her throat. "Randy, I -"

"Let's not jump into the breakup so fast," Randy interrupted. "Stay, have a drink. Humor an old man. For old times' sake."

The knife of guilt, cold and slippery, penetrated and its poison seeped into her chest.

But that was Randy's ploy, she realized. Playing on the tenderness she had felt for him in the past. Josh had been the one to point this out, in that long, revelatory conversation they had finally had. Randy was a shrink, a skilled manipulator, and he was playing to win because he was obsessed with her.

The guilt, liquid inside of her, evaporated. She could feel it go.

"Randy," she said, in an exasperated tone, hoping he would think she was bending to his will. Let him think he had her feeling sorry for him. Let him think he could use that.

Let him use it.

And then go in for the kill.

"Just one drink. I promise."

Zoe moved her fingers over the tablecloth in a gesture of indecision, her head tipped slightly. She felt a rush of power in that moment, full control over her own sexuality, the will to use it, the thrill of luring Randy

in, the sanction to do exactly that from her husband - rather than subtracting from the thrill, as she thought it might have - only making it sweeter.

She smiled - a little, uncertain smile.

"Come on."

She looked to the side, fluttered her eyes. "Fine," she said. "But just one."

A waitress, as if connected to a signaling system under Randy's control, rushed to the table after only a moment, and Randy ordered a drink for Zoe and another whiskey for himself.

They looked at each other across the table silently, heat simmering between them.

Zoe wondered what would have happened if this hadn't been part of a plan, if she had agreed to meet Randy without telling Josh about her problem, if she had come here solely for the purposes of getting him to delete the photos and to end things. There was little doubt that something similar would have ensued, though she liked to believe that she would have chosen a less sexy dress than this tight-fitting black cocktail dress, short at the bottom and deep-cut in the center of her small breasts.

The waitress returned and set down the drinks. She seemed to sense something in the air between the two of them that precluded dinner, or even appetizers, because she disappeared without asking about anything.

Zoe shifted in her seat, and her foot brushed over Randy's leg. She pulled it away quickly, as if she hadn't meant to touch him.

"Cheers," Randy said, raising his glass to hers.

Zoe clinked his glass, and then looked down at the brown liquid. "So, look," she said. "What happened the other day... I've, uh... had some time to think about it, and... I think it's best that we really... *really*... cut things off."

Randy's leg, as she said this, tipped slightly beneath the table to lean against her foot, and this time she didn't move it.

"Really," he repeated, his tone flat. It was not a question, just a mimicry of her own "*really*."

Between her crossed legs, she could feel the warm juices of her pussy soaking into the transparent panties. Her thighs would be slick by the time they stood up to go anywhere.

Randy shifted, his shoulder moving almost imperceptibly, from the view of the rest of the restaurant, and his hand found her ankle, and pulled

her shoe off.

His fingers moved over her foot, brushing over her skin in a whispery caress, but he might as well have had his tongue on her clit. "Randy," she said, and the line came out perfectly - weakening over the length of his name, like her resolve - but she didn't have to act too much to make that happen.

He stroked the top of her foot, and then the sole, without tickling, his thumb pressing into the center of her arch and electrifying some buried nerve that sent a sexual shudder through her. He lifted her leg from her other knee without her noticing, parting her legs. She could feel the cool air on the slickness between her legs, which extended now to her inner thighs.

He placed her foot between his legs, and she let him do it, offering neither resistance nor encouragement when her toes brushed against the shuddering, hard shape of his cock. Her lips were parted, and she held her head very still, returning Randy's increasingly feral gaze.

He brought his left hand to join his right, passing over her ankle, up her calf, and then back down again, every inch that he traveled ringing something inside of her like a bell.

Under her toes, his cock pulsed, but she remained frozen, letting him believe that he was seducing her, that she really had some resolve inside of her not to let him fuck her tonight, so that he could believe that he had dominated her, and would let his guard down.

He held her ankle with one hand, so she couldn't pull it away, even if she had wanted to or tried, which she did not, as he put one hand over the table to lift his drink to his lips.

"I've missed you," he said.

"Randy," she whispered, looking out into the restaurant, as if for help. "I can't..."

"I think you've missed me, too," he continued, undeterred. He stared at her for a beat, his eyes burning into hers. Her breath, truly, really, caught in her throat, and her pussy pulsed with the memory of the member under her toes, filling her everywhere.

"Let's see," he said, and he was moving before she could do anything about it, bringing his drink around the table with him, sitting next to her, his muscled arm going over her shoulders, his scent filling her nostrils, the stubble on his jaw brushing against her temple.

She stared straight ahead, moving her abandoned leg back over her knee, as if she intended to deny him access, but she knew how pointless this would have been in either version of this story: the one where she was here to seduce him, or the one in which she allowed herself to be seduced.

His mouth was on her ear now, lips brushing over the hard, upper ridge, stubble scraping tortuously over her lobe. He said nothing, just barely kissed her, as he pulled her leg open again with a hand under the table.

His fingers skated, barely touching her flesh, along her thigh, pausing to feel the lace thigh-high. She felt his mouth smile against her ear. "I like that, Zoe," he whispered.

Over a very tiny patch of smooth dry flesh, and then they slid, right into the steamy wetness that the flimsy panties had failed to contain.

He brushed his fingers over her cunt, over the fabric of her underwear, slowly, tantalizingly. Zoe's eyelids felt heavy, and they half-closed. She moved a hand to Randy's, pressing on him through her skirt. "You have to... stop, Randy," she said.

His fingers moved, in that moment, beneath the panties, and as if he knew her body as well as her own fingers did, they hit home immediately, rubbing her engorged clit with an expertise that was truly remarkable.

Her mouth was open to complain, she tried to turn her head to look at Randy, but all that left her lips was a mewl.

Randy's fingers slipped inside of her, and he rapidly, easily, dexterously, brought her body to a boil, while he held her head to his lips with the arm he had stretched behind her. His breath, steady, warm, spilled over her temple, down her cheek, to her neck, as she quivered with increasing frenzy, trying to hide how close she was to coming.

There was no hiding from Randy, who, when she was just seconds from the apex of an orgasm, ceased the movement of his fingers, held her head to his lips for a beat, and then slowly retracted his fingers from beneath her dress. "If that's what you want," he said. He nuzzled her ear. "If that's what you really, *really* want."

Zoe's heart seemed to have crashed to a stop in her chest for a moment. She was breathing rapidly, shallowly, her eyes faintly watering. "I can't do this Randy," she whispered.

Randy's fingers moved to the collar of her dress - the plunging neckline dipped to the very edges of the skimpy bra. They traveled along the collar,

over the mound of her breast, and then to the center of her throat, where they almost floated, just skimming, a few molecules of air between his finger and her skin, over the rapid pulse of her heart fluttering in the hollow of her throat.

"You've already done it, Zoe," he breathed.

She wasn't sure how he turned her head, or how long his lips traveled over her lips, which also seemed to pulse with her heartbeat. His stubble grazed her chin, her hand had come to rest on his cock, which she felt when he said, after however long he was doing this to her:

"Come on. Come home with me. I'll make you come until you cry. That's nothing," his fingers traveled down her dress, to the center of the neckline, and she shuddered, "you haven't done before."

*

"I have to be home at a reasonable time," Zoe said, turning around to glance at Randy as she walked through the now-familiar entranceway to his house. She had a genuine look of uncertainty on her face, a hesitation that she hoped Randy would interpret as a last fling with reluctance, the guilt of a cheating wife, and not for the thing that had actually rattled her inside.

She fished deep into her big purse for her cell phone, her fingers sliding over the other items she needed to be able to find quickly, use adeptly, to make this plan work.

"I have to send a message," she told Randy. Her hand was shaking a little, but he would take that for the same energy that had coursed through her so many times before. She typed, she sent, she deleted. She hoped she had seen correctly. She dropped the phone into her purse and stood in Randy's immense entrance, hand on hip.

"You seem nervous," Randy said.

Zoe gave a toss of her hair, savored the way it slid back over her shoulder, just a smidge too short to linger behind it. "I am," she told him, a note of defiance in her voice. She dropped her eyes. "Maybe this is a bad idea," she said, taking a step toward the door, and Randy, who moved cat-like, quickly but in a way that made it seem like he hadn't moved at all, to his left, so that he was directly in front of her.

"Stay for one drink," he said. His fingers found her hand, clutching her bag, and stroked the back of it. "You're already here."

Zoe looked at him, feigning indecision. It was an easy expression to fake; she had only to wonder about herself. What would she be doing if this whole situation were real? If she hadn't told Josh about Randy, if she and Josh hadn't hashed things out to meet in the middle? Would she try to leave?

Or would she have stayed, and let herself be smooth-talked by Randy, let him strum her like a guitar until she had already gone too far?

"It's a mistake," she said weakly.

"You feel bad about Josh."

Randy was putting on his calm, psychiatrist voice now. Over the obsessive, dark man he was deep inside, he was piling the layers of professionalism, of kindly father-type, older man of wisdom. And even though Zoe was attuned to the falsity of it all, to the dark intentions that lay beneath it, it wasn't very hard to let herself sink into her own role, as receiver of this act.

"I am," she said. "This was never supposed to be like this."

Randy intertwined his fingers in hers, and tugged gently on them to turn her around, lead her into the room with the bar. It was such an immense house she didn't know what to call half the rooms. "Have a drink. Talk to me about it."

Talk to him about it. She followed, marveling at Randy's technique, marveling at the way she had fallen for it all before.

Randy started to make the drinks, and she leaned on a heavy, custom-built piece of furniture that oozed an amount of wealth she would probably never attain herself. The wood seemed oddly warm beneath her forearm. "Now you're going to try to talk me into it again," she said wryly. This was an unexpected statement, not the direction she had intended to move in at all. But it was too late to take it back. "Give me a bunch of that smooth psycho-babble."

Randy turned from the bar with two drinks in his hands. He looked surprised, but the surprise amused him. He crossed the room to place the icy drink in her hand. "That's a new tune for you, Zoe," he said. "But yes. That's my plan."

"Maybe it won't work this time," she retorted, before sipping her drink.

"No?" Randy asked casually. He sipped his own drink. "I'll have to try a new approach, then."

"You sound pretty sure of yourself."

Randy smiled. A flicker of fear ignited in Zoe's chest as he turned and walked back to the couch, the same couch where he had fucked her the first time, and sat down, elbows on knees. "I'm more sure of you than I am of myself," he said.

Zoe took a sip of her drink. "This is crazy," she whispered.

"You're here for a reason, Zoe," Randy said. "You want me to stop playing games? Okay, I'll stop playing games. But then you stop playing games, too."

"What game am I playing."

Randy leaned back and put his arms over the back of the couch.

"We're all adults here, Zoe. Josh wanted you to fuck another man. You wanted to fuck me. I wanted to fuck you. So, everything was fine and level, except that *you* didn't tell your husband about us. Now, why didn't you do that, Zoe?"

Control was an odd thing. A lot of people tried to have it by exerting more energy into how they moved their bodies, which is the sort of thing that maybe works on a flat piece of ice or a groomed run. But anywhere else, where variables are too many to ever account for, gaining control involved ceding some of it to the temperament of your surroundings.

"You're the shrink," Zoe said. "You tell me."

"Come over here, and I will."

Zoe caught a piece of half-melted ice in her molars and crushed it. She shook her head. "Tell me from there."

Randy tipped his head back and gave an amused groan at the ceiling. Then he looked at Zoe. His fingers moved over the top of the couch, strumming, and she could see on his face that he was aware of the way he was insinuating something with them, as if he were touching her sternum instead of the couch, ready to move down, until he was between her legs.

"You didn't tell him because you liked fucking around on him, Zoe. You *like* fucking around on him."

"Why would I like that?"

"Because it's dangerous. Because you work at an insurance company and it's boring," Randy said, so quickly that it seemed as if he had been expecting the question and rehearsed the answer a million times, like lines in a play.

Zoe couldn't think of anything to say to that, because it was true, and because she was busy thinking ahead of it, yards and yards away, making an adjustment now so that she could stay upright later. It took only seconds for it to all fall into place, and then only seconds for her to act on it. In many ways, Randy, with his arrogant, accurate perception, had handed her the entire plan on a silver platter.

She downed the rest of the whiskey, and set it down, looking at it as if she were placing an object on the credenza for display. Her bag was still slung over her shoulder. She moved her finger around the rim of the glass, slowly, knowing that Randy was watching it with interest and arousal.

Then she gave him a poignant look, turned on her heel, and walked back the way they had come.

From that room, the hallway led to the foyer, or whatever you would call that first high-ceilinged room - a grand entrance hall? - where the front door and the stairs were.

She knew that Randy would sit there, ever smug, arms draped over the back of the couch, waiting to hear which direction she went. She walked slowly, her heels clicking on the hard floor with a sound that was somehow sexual, and then, out of sight from Randy, she paused at the foot of the stairs, near the door.

And then, walking slowly, imagining Randy's smile as he sipped the rest of his whiskey, she ascended the stairs.

*

Once upstairs there was a hallway, which would obscure Randy's view of her for a few moments even if he immediately got off the couch and ran upstairs. Zoe felt unexpectedly calm as she slipped her hand into her purse, her walk still steady and slow, her heels echoing in the vastness of Randy's stone and hardwood home.

She dropped her purse at the door, and stepped out of the heels, and that was when she moved quickly. It was easier to do than she had imagined, even if she had only just concocted this part of the plan moments ago. The floating shelf, with the immense snake plant in an expensive-looking steel container, was in a slightly different place than she had remembered, but it would still work, maybe even better than she had imagined.

She placed her Go Pro there and walked back toward the door. From where she was, she could see that Randy was not in the hallway, so she slipped her heels back on, and sat down on the bed, leaning back on her elbows, legs crossed.

Randy turned the corner of the hallway, and she was satisfied by the brief look of surprise that crossed his face again, but it didn't linger long.

Randy, after all, like her, was a creature of control, who also knew that the best way to take it was to conform to the new landscape.

CHAPTER 18

I'm going to be a little late

It was the agreed-upon message, a signal that she was going home with Randy, in case he was looking over her shoulder or caught sight of it. How late she would be, and whether their plan - which Josh found tantalizing but far-fetched, and honestly a bit tenuous - would work or not, were two different things.

It was a way to end things, a way for Zoe to ensure that Randy would never have the audacity to use her photos against her or in some awful way, a way to bring certain closure to their relationship, and leave no doors open for a rekindled affair.

Or was it? As much as Zoe had bared her feelings, confessed her indiscretions, told him the details of Randy's sordid handling of her, as much as he believed that they were working together, there was always a little gremlin of doubt gnawing at him, a final denizen of the infestation in his heart, the one that would not let go.

Maybe he just had to learn to live with it. In some ways it was thrilling pain, something that he enjoyed. Why else would he seek out this particular fantasy, this particular pleasure from something painful?

He had come to realize that he was no more able to explain it to himself than he was to Zoe, but he understood it. It was fair that she would have something similar inside of her, something he could never ever be completely sure about it.

It came down to trust; and trust, like faith, and ultimately, love, was defined by its lack of proof. And so there was no way out: love was shown through trust and faith, and trust was ephemeral.

Why any of this was so sexual was a mystery beyond him. It simply was.

His stomach was alternating between hot and cold, his cock swollen, precum staining his boxers and his pants as he sat, staring at his phone, brooding, imagining Zoe with Randy. Right now, Randy was again peeling away her clothing, ripping away the pretty, delicate undergarments to feed his immense cock into her every hole. Would he leave her thigh-high stockings on all night, so they would be soaked with his sweat and cum when she returned to her husband? Would she capture every depraved

moment in video like she promised, or would she fail, leaving him to always wonder if she had failed on purpose? Would he, at last, see the details Zoe couldn't bring herself to talk about, the filthy things he made her say and do?

There was only one thing to do, and that was wait.

The next text came in fifteen minutes.

68129. I think.

CHAPTER 19

"Let's watch it first," Zoe breathed, when Josh at last took a moment to catch his breath. He barely remembered the drive home, his cock hard the whole time, Zoe, staring out the windshield with a wild look on her face, a smile. She occasionally looked behind her, like they were fleeing a bank robbery and she wanted to make sure the police weren't behind them.

This was the first thing she had said since they had climbed in the car.

Josh groaned, because he wasn't sure how much longer he could endure the erection that had stained his pants with a torrent of pre-cum and was gripping all of his lower abdomen in a fierce, dull ache. But Zoe's eyes were alive with excitement, and raw sexual energy, and she was already fishing the Go Pro from her purse, slipping beneath his arms, getting ready to go upstairs.

By the time he straightened himself out enough to walk, she was upstairs, connecting the camera to the screen of her computer, which she had propped up on a side table. She unzipped her dress and stepped out of it, stretching out on the bed. Her thigh-high hose were still on her legs, the only undisturbed article of clothing - her underwear having been abandoned at Randy's house.

Josh wriggled out his clothes awkwardly, trying not to disturb his aching cock too much. He stretched out behind his wife, and she grinned back at him, pushing her ass against his dick, which made him groan. "I don't know how long I can make it last," he said, with a laugh, to her ear.

This made her smile, and she clicked away at the computer to bring up the video. "Just try," she said. "I think you missed most of this."

*

The screen filled with Zoe's face, and her hurrying away from the camera, to quickly step back into her shoes and sit, sultry, at the foot of Randy's bed. The camera was positioned to the right of the bed, a little higher, and the very corner of a frond of some plant tipped into the upper-right hand corner of the frame.

"Dammit," Zoe said.

"It's a good angle," Josh said, hurriedly. "It's good."

It was better than good: it was crystal-clear, the sound was excellent, and when Randy stepped into the frame, Josh felt a punch to the gut: it was

almost, *almost*, like being there.

On the screen, Randy drew Zoe to her feet and turned her around to find the zipper of her dress as if he had purchased it for her himself: it was well-hidden, a tricky clasp, but he was slowly tugging the teeth apart, splitting the material down her back. It slid from her shoulders and then fell away, sliding over her narrow hips once it was below her lower back. Randy helped it along, pushing it down her body, until it fell to the floor.

He pushed her over, bending her at the waist, his hands on her ass, kneading her small bottom with his large, wiry hands while he watched her flesh fold in his grip.

"You've been very bad, Zoe," Randy said, reaching behind his back to grab his shirt and pull it over his head. He threw it carelessly to the floor.

Zoe's hair was spread around her head on the bed, and her hands were on either side of her face. She pushed up from the bed, looking directly at the camera, but Randy pushed her down to her chest again. "Stay like that," he growled, his hands moving over her ass again, each of her ass-cheeks small enough for him to palm and grip fiercely. The camera, with its incredible resolution, captured the red mark left behind by his fierce massage.

"Do you need a spanking, little girl?" Randy asked, one hand working his zipper down. "I think you do." He was pushing his pants down, and his cock sprang out in front of him, visible from the angle of the camera, turgid and ready.

The slap was amplified by the sound capture of the Go Pro, its frequencies collapsed to the sharpest of cracks, and Josh jumped inside his skin.

"Honey," he whispered, a little horrified. On the screen, Zoe's skin turned white-hot, then faded to pink, then to a bright red, where Randy's hand had sliced into it.

Josh stared as Randy spanked her five times, slowly, methodically. He watched his wife's reactions, from sexual purrs, to gasps, then whimpers. She mewled on the very last slap, which echoed in the room as Randy took a moment to admire his handiwork: Zoe in her submissive crouch, her ass upturned to him, without resistance to the power of his punishment.

Next to Josh, on the bed in their real world, stretched out next to him, Zoe rolled so that her bottom was within Josh's reach. She was reclined in a

feline pose, on her side, looking over her shoulder. He moved his hand to her bare skin, felt the slight imprint welting there, just slightly rough. "Does it hurt?" he whispered, half-aghast, his fingers feeling her skin while he shifted his eyes from the real Zoe, whose eyes were glistening wildly, and Zoe on the camera, who had risen to her forearms to rock her hips back and forth while Randy rubbed her freshly-spanked skin.

"Don't ever take this ass away from me again, little girl," Randy said, his words clawing their way through Josh's consciousness.

On the screen, Randy jerked her panties down to her thighs, where he left them, her knees together, the peach of her ass and the tender eyelet at the center turned up for him to abuse as he pleased.

Zoe on camera let out a squeal, a mix of a moan and a yelp of pain, and arched her back, pushing the tender rounds of her ass against Randy. Josh's cock throbbed against Zoe's thigh as, on camera, he watched Randy slip his hand into the folds of her sloppy wet pussy, and then push his thumb into her ass.

"Oh," she squealed on camera. Next to him, beneath his hands, Zoe pulsed.

Josh stared at the screen as Randy finger-fucked Zoe's ass, using first his thumb, then his pointer finger, then sliding two fingers inside of her, coated with the juices of her pussy, as she looked backward at him and moaned in obvious pleasure.

What he had seen in real life, in his bedroom, had been partly obscured, but the angle of the camera allowed him to see in sharp detail the stretching of his wife, the violation of her ass, each inch of Randy's probing fingers sinking deep into her flesh.

It wasn't anything new: he knew Zoe was this kind of girl with Randy, but seeing it again, at such a clear angle, he felt his heart drop. Josh slipped his fingers into the crack of Zoe's ass, where he encountered the slickness of her juices, of Randy's slowly seeping cum, of sweat. He would never know what combination slicked his fingers.

On the screen, Randy's fingers plunged into Zoe's ass, while Randy stared at the gap he was creating, the way that Zoe was reacting, as if she were a puppet or a doll that Randy could manhandle and fuck as he liked. It was obvious that she liked it, and Josh was once again confronted with the

reality of watching his wife behave like someone he didn't know or recognize.

Josh's fingers found the rim of her ass in the center of the slippery valley, and Zoe lifted her ass so that he could slide his fingers over the stretched eyelet, slimy with cum that was still spilling from inside of it.

He would never want to fuck Zoe in the ass, but his fingers explored her gape anyway, almost of their own accord, as though to confirm what Randy was experiencing. Inside she was silky and hot, dirty and used, and his cock, though it seemed unbelievable, grew even harder as he slipped his fingers into the depths of her ass.

Randy was turning Zoe over on camera. "Spread those legs for me, Zoe," Randy said, after sliding her panties off, all the way down from where they'd been stretched across her thighs. "That's good." Zoe was spread out on the bed, her pussy gushing, her heels still on, her thigh-highs framing her groin. "Show me that pussy."

Randy stood over her, watching, staring at her gash as she opened her legs obediently and held onto her ankles, knees bent.

Randy dropped his hand between her legs and started to play with her clit. Zoe moaned. Randy's expert fingers worked on her pussy, and Zoe's legs began to tremble, fall apart further, drift open, as her hips began to rock against the bed, jumping up to meet Randy's touch. She bit her lip, staring at Randy's face, mewling.

She lifted her head suddenly, and stared at Randy's hand. Then she tipped her head back and let out a cry.

"You didn't think I would let you off easy, Zoe, after you took this pussy away from me for so long, did you?" Randy said. Josh closed his eyes to the menace in the man's voice. He had to stop himself from turning to Zoe in disbelief, asking her if this was really what she wanted. She wanted it, she couldn't fully explain to him why, any more than he could explain his desires to her. And so there they were, a sort of erotic tit for tat, and he had promised himself explicitly, and Zoe implicitly, not to judge.

"You know what I want to hear," Randy coaxed. "If you want to come, you need to give me what I want, Zoe."

"Please, Randy," Zoe begged. Randy had his cock in his hand now and was stroking it languidly, staring Zoe down as she squirmed on the bed.

"I want you to fuck me," Zoe begged. "I've always wanted you to fuck me."

Randy's cock throbbed noticeably at these final words. It was perverse, but he made Zoe continue, climbing onto his knees on the bed, still stroking his cock, staring down at her. His voice was too low to be intelligible, but he spoke some new command that made Zoe wail on camera.

Next to him, Zoe had shifted again and was watching the screen with him as he tenderly slipped his fingers into her gash, over her clit.

"What did he say?" Josh choked out.

"Shh," Zoe whispered softly. "You'll see."

Randy was climbing up Zoe's body now, her legs between his, closing together so that they were at her ears. The view was obscured a little by Randy's torso, and by Zoe's heeled foot, which was now twisting in the air next to her head. Randy moved up the length of her body, until his fat ball sack was dangling over Zoe's mouth.

Josh was able to see, just barely, her lips around his balls, her tongue flicking out to swirl over his wrinkled, hairy sac. Behind him, her glistening cunt gushed, her ass sphincter throbbing closed.

Randy reached between his legs and grabbed a handful of Zoe's hair. Josh watched as he shifted, and then the cacking sound that followed made clear what he couldn't see because of Randy's bulk: Randy's hips moved back and forth as he fucked Zoe's mouth with her pinned to the bed.

Inside, he was screaming: the scene was more filthy than he could have imagined, his wife a pretzeled plaything in Randy's hands, being manhandled and mauled, and there was only more to come, he knew: the cum in her ass and her pussy, told of a long and sordid tale.

After what seemed like an eternity, Randy withdrew from her throat and Zoe gasped for air and nibbled at his cock, which he lay over her lips and occasionally lifted to slap onto her face. "You want it?" Randy told her.

Between slurps and gulps, Zoe's voice moaned, "I want it," she purred, like some porno bimbo.

Randy stared down at her. His voice was a mumble, low and unintelligible, but Josh had already watched Randy play his games with Zoe, and so he guessed at what he had said: feeding Zoe the supplicant lines he wanted her to hear.

"I want it so bad, Randy, I want you to fuck me, I want you cock."

"Where do you want me to fuck you first, Zoe? Hmm? In your ass?" Randy twisted his arm behind him and slipped his fingers into her gash, where he began to rub rhythmically against her clit. Zoe continued to slurp on his cock, breathing heavier, her body attempting to squirm against his fingers. She was pinned in such a way that she could only rock her ass and twist her feet helplessly.

She let out a tortured moan when Randy's fingers stopped their pulsing. "Hmm?" Randy asked.

Zoe was pinned, her heels by her head, Randy's cock over her lips, her ass and pussy behind him where he could play with her at his leisure.

"Please," Zoe begged. "Please, Randy, I want you to fuck me."

"Yeah?" Randy asked, cruelly. "Say it again. Say what I want to hear."

"I want you to fuck me. I want you to fuck my ass full of cum."

"Keep going," Randy said, his fingers moving slowly in the slosh of her engorged pussy.

Josh stared at the screen, riveted by it, while his own fingers, guided by some other part of his mind, slipped into her pussy in real life. It was sloppy wet, and loose, stretched from whatever would take place on this film over the next few hours.

Zoe's flesh pulsed all around him. "I'm sore," she breathed in his ear, "be gentle."

On camera Zoe howled. Randy's fingers were still again. "Lick my cock and tell me how much you want me to fuck you."

The pulse of Zoe's pussy at the sound of these words was unmistakable, and a hot stream of jealousy ran through Josh's veins. He could never talk to his wife like this, never use her and degrade and make her beg this way. But she liked it, it turned her on just hearing it again.

On the screen, Zoe's tongue emerged again from her mouth, curling around Randy's fat shaft, tracing the crooked veins that bulged from his meat. "I want you to fuck me so bad, Randy. Please, please fuck me."

Randy's voice, too low to be heard.

"I love when you fuck me," Zoe gushed. "I love your cock, Randy."

Zoe was squirming against him, her mouth open, her eyes closed. "I said it loud so you could hear it," she panted.

It took Josh a moment to realize that she meant for *him*. It was dizzying, the effect of that statement: even as Zoe had been begging Randy

to fuck her, licking his cock like a whore, she had thought to be heard by her husband.

How true was it, what Zoe was saying? Did she love Randy's cock? Or were those just words to her, in the heat of the moment? She had answered this question, and he couldn't ask it again and again and again, but hearing her lap at Randy's cock and beg him to fuck her, the question of truth gnawed at his insides.

Randy backed up and threw Zoe's right leg to the side so that it was draped onto her left. He lowered his body onto hers, and her feet drifted up with his weight crushing down on her. His cock, Josh knew, but could not see, was sliding into her pussy.

Randy collapsed onto Zoe's body, his hands now at her head, pushing her hair from her face. He was speaking to her in a low voice, his fingers moving down her jawline, pulling her mouth open.

"What's he saying?" Josh said hoarsely.

Zoe rolled to face him, sliding her fingers down his torso to find his cock. "He's telling me all the things he's going to do to me. He likes to do that."

Josh's eyes were glued to the screen, to Randy's slow-moving hips and his prying fingers on Zoe's face. To the side of Randy's body, Zoe's feet, still in heels, bobbed as he fucked her. "Do *you* like it?" Josh whispered. His fingers had found Zoe's pussy again, and he slipped two fingers easily inside of her in time to feel her squeeze him in answer to his question.

"Just watch," Zoe whispered.

Zoe on screen started to mewl. Randy began to fuck her faster, and her heels bobbed away from her feet before falling, one by one, to the bed. Josh listened as his wife's voice changed to a shrill scream, her hands escaping Randy's grip and slapping him on the back before digging into his shoulder. She was coming, wildly, but Randy showed no signs of stopping.

Zoe's fingers were moving slowly over Josh's head, smearing the precum to glide in lazy circles around his hole. "Zoe," he breathed. "I can't..." He didn't want to come, not just yet, not knowing that the Viagra-popping Randy was far from finished with his wife. If he had to watch Zoe getting fucked after coming himself, he might lose it.

Zoe put her hand around his cock and squeezed, smiling.

On screen, Randy was still hammering at Zoe, who was now whimpering, her body loose and floppy. Slurpy wet slaps filled the room for what seemed like an eternity, until Randy groaned, and the muscles of his back and buttocks tensed, and then he yelled, loudly, as he emptied his seed into Zoe's pussy.

But both Zoe - of the film - and Josh, the watcher, knew enough of Randy to know he was nowhere near done with her yet. He rose onto his knees, letting his cock slide from Zoe's pussy, flipping her leg back up and over to the other side of his body. Zoe was spread-eagle in front of him again, and he stared down at her, his only *slightly*-deflated cock in his hand, stroking himself.

Josh stared at Zoe's swollen gash on the screen. It was engorged to near-disfigurement, and he could see a slow trickle of pearly white cum snaking from its red mouth.

Randy backed himself off the bed, still looking at Zoe. "Stay like that," he ordered her, loudly enough for Josh to hear.

Zoe stayed, legs spread, but she squirmed magically, like a slutty whore, bringing her finger to her mouth and smiling at Randy deviously. Randy moved almost off-screen, and Josh thought he could hear a drawer opening. Zoe propped herself up on her elbows to watch him.

Josh's heart was falling to his feet when, on screen, Zoe looked to the camera, and smiled. It was a long, deliberate look, a reminder that she was thinking of him. He sucked in his breath. His arm was going to sleep propping his head up, but he didn't care. Zoe began to move down his body, pushing him onto his back. He grabbed a pillow to rest his head, as his wife put her lips on his cock.

He dared to tear his eyes away from the screen to look at Zoe sharply. "Zoe -" he said. She smiled up at him and shrugged, licking a bead of precum and then lifting her head, sitting on top of him to watch the screen, his cock in her hand.

On screen, Randy's plaything Zoe had gotten onto her knees, Randy's voice having rumbled an order just before that. Randy was back to the foot of the bed, a drink in his hand. Zoe scooted forward on her knees, until she was close to Randy, looking up at him, an expression of supplication on her face. Randy fished an ice cube from his drink and rubbed it over her lips, then fed it to her, and Zoe sucked his fingers with her eyes locked on his.

A chill traveled through Josh as he watched Randy move his fingers in Zoe's mouth, playing with her as though this was just another orifice that he would violate and fill with cum: and it was. And Zoe, eternally submissive to Randy's prowess, opened obediently, and met his eyes as surely as if he had demanded her to, yet no vocal command was given.

A knife of cold pain twisted in his gut: Randy's power over Zoe was an animal, feral power. That sort of sexual dominance was outside of his abilities. But Zoe liked it, he could see her melting for it, submitting to Randy's physical desires, however perverse they might become.

Zoe in real life, who was straddling him now, was also absorbed in the image. He could feel her pussy juices trickling down her inner thighs. Her hand moved slowly on his shaft, her thumb occasionally swiping his slick crown, but her eyes were absorbed in the image.

On screen, Randy moved his big hand up to Zoe's head, and pushed her down to his cock. She opened her mouth wide, and Randy fed himself deep, cradling her head, and then pushing and pulling her to make her suck him off. The sounds of his cock driving to the back of Zoe's throat were excruciating to listen to, but Josh's cock bobbed and flexed wildly in Zoe's hand. She smiled when he looked over briefly to her and began to lower her head again.

"Not... yet... oh, God, Zoe..." Josh breathed. He knew he sounded like a moron, making no sense, but he couldn't find the words to explain what he wanted - not to come before he saw more, the entirety of this depraved scene, all that there was to see, because if he did, he might not be able to finish watching. Not in one go. And he had to see what Randy would do next.

Randy watched as he palmed Zoe's head and she sucked his cock for several minutes, which seemed like an eternity. He reached forward, leaning over her, his other hand still cradling her head, and cupped her left buttock in his meaty hand, fingers slipping into her crack. Randy's fingers pulled on Zoe's hair, and he slid his other hand between her legs, forcing Zoe to bend her back, eliciting a sound from her throat that was choked off by his cock.

"Oh my God," Josh said listlessly, not daring to tear his eyes from the screen to look at his wife. A spluttery sound came from the video, staccatos of spit and the flesh of whatever orifice Randy's left-hand fingers were

clawing into. Beneath that wet staccato came the mewls of his wife, sticky and meaty as Randy drove his cock deeper into her throat.

At last he released her head, pulling her with his fingers entwined in her hair, along his chest, pushing her toward him with his left hand. A thick strand of spit stretched between Zoe's lips and his cock, falling along her chest, as she looked up at him. Her lips were red, her mascara smeared, and Randy held her like this for an interminable moment, stretching a thumb out to touch her lips.

"Such a dirty little slut, Zoe. Are you ready for Randy's big cock now?"

Zoe didn't answer, just sucked on his thumb.

"Say it, little girl. You dirty, little slut."

"I want your cock," Zoe purred, and then sucked on his thumb again. "I want to sit on your cock and milk the cum with my ass."

Josh went cold, and the shock of it throbbed in his dick against Zoe's hand. Her bold, filthy statement seemed to shock even Randy, who paused for a moment, looking down at her, as if he might not even be sure what to do.

Then he smiled. "You dirty little girl," he said, amused.

As the protagonists of this terrible porno shifted on the bed, Josh dared to steal a look at Zoe in real life, in his bed, straddling him. She was looking down at him, an expression of triumph etched into the features of her face. Before he looked back to the screen, he had a flicker of understanding light inside of him.

Randy was on his knees once they had rearranged themselves, facing the end of the bed. Zoe was climbing onto him, reverse-cowgirl style her spectacular body nude except for the thigh-high stockings. Randy's eyes were on her ass, almost disbelieving, his fingers gripping her small frame at her ribs. Zoe reached between her legs to guide his cock to the right position, while Randy stared, open-mouthed.

Zoe sank onto Randy's cock, her eyes moving to the camera but temporarily blank, mouth open in a silent cry.

"Oh fuck," Randy said. "Fuck, you dirty little slut, that's it, take it all, oh God, Zoe..."

Zoe leaned back against his chest, and Randy dropped a hand to support himself. Zoe's eyes were now on the camera, a slight smile on her

lips, as she spread her legs open and rolled her hips to fuck Randy with her ass.

The fat column of Randy's cock could be seen beneath the gushing mess of her pussy, disappearing as she tilted down, slithering wet from inside of her as she arched back. Again and again, Zoe pumped Randy's cock, which squeezed the creamy cum he had deposited in her cunt from her ragged, engorged flesh. It ran down her taint and snaked around his column before greasing it for yet another plunge into her ass.

Randy's free hand came to Zoe's throat, and he placed his lips next to her ear. "Oh fuck, that's it, show daddy what a good girl you are," he breathed.

Zoe on the camera, looking to Josh who would be watching her later, opened her eyelids, which had closed in sexual passion, and smiled.

And Zoe in real life, who was straddling Josh and was moving the tip of his cock through the liquid heat of her pussy, rubbing him over her clit, smiled as well. "Gotcha," she breathed.

Josh's abdomen was beginning to roll in waves, an orgasm coming upon him so rapidly that he barely had time to grab Zoe's hips and push her away from him. "Hold... on..." he managed to choke out, his eyes going back to the scene in the film Zoe had made.

Zoe bounced on Randy's cock, moaning, doing, as she had promised, exactly what she said she would: she was milking the cum from Randy's cock, squeezing him with her ass, working and grunting like an animal, a sheen of sweat glowing on her skin from head to toe.

"You dirty, dirty girl, that's so hot, fuck Zoe," Randy was saying.

Zoe moved her fingers to her pussy, fluttering her eyes up to the camera to meet Josh's eventual gaze. She slid them into her wide-open gash as she stroked her clit and milked Randy's dick.

The scene went on for a long time, perhaps not as long as Josh believed, because for him it was an eternity, with Zoe's gaze burning through him, her spit and cum covered body writhing on top of Randy's lap, wet slurps piercing the air between Randy's filthy words in her ear that could not be heard.

"Make yourself come, that's it," Randy said loudly enough to hear. His fingers closed tightly around Zoe's throat, and her face grew red.

"Zoe," Josh whispered, not sure what he meant by that. Whatever had happened had happened, and Zoe was quite clearly still alive and well, so in his heart he knew that she wouldn't be choked to death by this monster, but the sight of it still made his body cold with fear.

Zoe began to scream - a strangled, open-mouthed rattle, and from her pussy a gush of semen-tainted cum began to spew.

"Oh my God!" she gasped, when she was spent and her legs trembling, and Randy let go of her neck. He flipped her with a sudden, maniacal move, getting her onto her knees and facing away from the camera, her body flopping uselessly as he manhandled her into position. He grabbed her hips and began to hammer into her.

Now the length of his cock as it penetrated her ass could be seen in full. He stretched her legs open, crouching to accommodate her tiny frame, and thrust into her deeply over and over again, his ball sack slapping her pussy with wet slaps.

Randy fucked like an animal: the scene was so primal it was hard to watch. Zoe's limp body scooted forward with each thrust, before being pulled back by Randy's big hands that almost encircled her hips. At last, he yelled loudly, and slammed himself into her, filling her ass with another load of cum.

Josh was not breathing, just staring, as Randy jerked a few more splutters into Zoe's ass with short thrusts and a jerk of pleasure that rippled through his whole body.

Randy collapsed on top of Zoe, and then rolled to the side, taking her with him, his dick still inside of her ass. He pushed her hair from her face and his hands drifted to her body, playing with her tits, down to her pussy.

"I can't," Zoe murmured. "Oh Randy, I can't, I have to go..."

"He says, 'I'm not done with you yet,'" the real-life Zoe said, almost archly. Josh stole a look at her. She was staring at the screen, supremely impressed with herself.

On the screen, Zoe squirmed away from Randy, his cock flopping from inside of her. She sat up, turning her body to look at her lover, who was sprawled, slightly surprised, but gearing up for more seduction, staring at Zoe.

She gave a turn, putting her hand on Randy's chest. It was an almost tender gesture, and it made jealousy flicker in Josh's chest for a brief

moment. But after she dropped the hammer on him, not even a second later, he saw it as a kindness, and almost felt sorry for the guy.

"I'm done with you, though, Randy," Zoe said, clearly. She didn't wait for his expression to change before turning toward the end of the bed and scooting herself along, dragging the sheets with her.

Randy seemed to have not processed this. He put his hands behind his head, looking almost amused. "That's right. Got to run back to Josh before he gets any *inkling* of what you're up to."

Zoe turned to Randy quickly, and Josh knew her temper had flared. But she calmed herself, and stood up, and found her dress. She slipped into it as Randy watched, the same arrogant look on his face.

The hammer hadn't truly dropped for him yet, Josh realized. He looked at Zoe's face, and he saw that she was seeing the same thing. But he couldn't suppress the flutter of joy inside of him seeing that regret, or anything resembling pity, did not swim beneath Zoe's features.

Zoe on camera zipped her own dress, in a yoga-like move that made Randy raise his eyebrows, and Josh as well. Then she picked up her shoes and walked calmly straight toward the camera.

"No," she said, and her hand obscured the lens. It was gray and blurry for a moment, only her voice providing any clarity as to what happened in that last moment. "I'm *done* with you."

There were some sounds, blurs of light, a muffling as Zoe dumped the Go Pro, still on, in her purse. But that was all.

It went black.

*

The rest of the story, of course, Josh knew.

Randy had leaned back on the bed, a wry smile developing on his face. "Zoe, Zoe, Zoe," he said, cool as a cucumber. "What *are* you up to?"

Zoe had faltered for a split-second there, perhaps because she had expected Josh to come bursting into the room at that moment. But anything could have happened to that part of the plan: they had only ever given it a 50/50 chance of working, and Zoe had thought ahead to what she would do in that case.

"This is my insurance. I'm sure you understand." Zoe patted her purse.

"Insurance," Randy repeated, marveling at something, though it was difficult to know at what.

"I've got to wrap this up, Randy. Like, really, *really* wrap it up."

Randy laughed. He pushed up from the bed and rubbed his nose before resting his arms on his knees, legs spread, a man of supreme confidence to the end. "Don't tell me you're trying to get out of this without Josh knowing."

Josh's stomach felt, for a brief moment, as if it had been thrown into the air.

"I'm not," Zoe said simply.

Randy's face changed then, a light of realization flickering in his eyes. He was a smart guy, and he seemed to realize in that moment that he had been played, even if he wasn't sure how.

It was for this reason that Josh had wanted to be there, that he had risked entering the house, which he felt pretty sure was technically some sort of felony, should Randy decide to pursue it. Zoe did not seem to understand the sort of rage a man could have when a woman fucked him over, however justified it might be, and so while she had insisted Randy was not the violent type, Josh had insisted on being there just in case.

Though he also hoped, sincerely, that Zoe was right about Randy's nonviolent nature.

"Give me the tape, Zoe," Randy said, holding a hand out to her.

Josh looked at the ceiling, praying silently that Zoe would not choose this moment to make a sarcastic joke that she often did, about "tape" being something from 1978.

"No," Zoe said. "No, I'm keeping it. You keep your pictures, and I'll keep my tape, and that way no one will be tempted to let anyone... see anything we wouldn't want someone to know about."

Randy tried out some bravado. He snorted. "What makes you think -"

"You wouldn't want this to get out, Randy. I can think of one person off the top of my head who you really, *really* wouldn't want to see this."

She was talking about Derek, of course. It was a gamble, in Josh's opinion, but he could see instantly that it was the right one. Randy's face changed.

"I can't keep this up. No more games. We have to end it," Zoe said firmly.

Josh hadn't expected it, but he felt a little sorry for Randy. He was relieved when Zoe added, more gently, "We both know the thrill isn't going

to last forever, Randy. You got something you wanted, and so did I, and so did Josh. But it's got to stop, for real."

Randy looked at Zoe's purse. "And that's your gambit? Mutually assured destruction?"

Zoe shrugged. "It's all I got. But I feel like it will work."

Randy ran his hand through his hair and shook his head. Then he brought his hands together in three slow claps.

"You had me going," he said. "How long has Josh known, out of curiosity?"

Josh closed his eyes and his stomach sank. As much as Randy deserved to be crushed, he hoped Zoe would take pity on the guy.

"Long enough," Zoe said softly. "He's waiting for me," she added.

Then she turned and walked toward the door. When she was close to the frame, she saw Josh, and gave him a funny look. He waved her off, and beckoned her to keep walking. She looked confused for only a moment. Josh crept backward to the stairs and began to descend.

"Randy," he heard Zoe say. "It was... good while it lasted. Really."

Randy said something Josh couldn't hear, and by the time he reached the door, he had decided not to ask about it.

*

"Why didn't you go in?" Zoe asked him, trailing her fingers over Josh's chest. They were on the bed, legs tangled together, after a very brief session of lovemaking, which Josh had barely managed to endure for five minutes, because of the state of his arousal at the end of the video. He had sneaked into Randy's house to see only the very end of what had transpired between Randy and Zoe.

Josh looked at the ceiling and reached for Zoe's hand. "Truthfully," he said, "I just... kind of felt sorry for the guy. Like, he was a controlling, manipulative, sonuvabitch... but you really kicked him in the balls, you know? It just didn't seem right to go in there and kick him again."

That was actually the truth. Josh wasn't confrontational, and he had never been in a real fight, unless you counted a mass squabble at a house party that had been broken up right after it started, which he didn't. The thought of talking trash to Randy had made him nervous, but he had been planning, right up to the last moment, to go ahead and do it.

But after Zoe broke up with him, and revealed that she had manipulated him as well, Josh had felt like it was punishment enough.

After all, Randy might have a Jag and a really fucking unbelievable house, and a really huge cock, and a lot of swagger... but he didn't have Zoe.

Not really.

Not in a way that really mattered.

Not ever.

Josh pulled Zoe toward him and kissed her forehead, then her lips, and then began to explore her body again with his fingers. He felt Zoe's lips form a disbelieving smile, and she laughed.

"Again?" she said. "Already?"

"I'm inspired," Josh said. "I'll go slow." His fingers slipped into the slickness between her thighs, where Randy's last load of cum mingled with his own. He delighted in the way that Zoe's body jerked as he touched her engorged flesh. "I love you, Zoe," he whispered.

Zoe, who in the end, was completely his, spread her legs open for him, and pulled him inside the liquid heat of her body.

"I love you, Josh."

END

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